

walking with the *Master*



GRAHAM DOUBLE

baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ
nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba na
kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla ked
baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ ba
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kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla k



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Graham Double (Jiṇāneshvar)

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PREFACE

Walking With The Master is a day by day account, as I experienced it, of what happened and what was said over a two month period in the life of Shrii Prabhat Ranjan Sarkar, also known by His spiritual name, Shrii Shrii Ánandamúrti and affectionately addressed by His followers as Bábá, meaning beloved Father.

In this book, references to Bábá are capitalized to reflect the author's regard for Him as an embodiment of the Supreme Consciousness.

Some interviews have been conducted after 1980, to verify information, Sanskrit words, names used and to expound on ideas or information. To retain continuity of story this interview material has been integrated, where appropriate, into the body of the text as if it was taking place in 1980. All direct speech of Bábá is from the actual time in 1980.

Some formal Darshans given by Bábá during my time in Calcutta have not been translated from the original Bengali, at the time of printing this book. I have taken a general verbal translation and then paraphrased this material to give a sense of the subject Bábá was talking about at the time. Any inaccuracies in this regard are solely my own. Please refer to the original Darshan for an full rendition of what Bábá said in the Darshan.

Although Bábá used the masculine throughout most of His books and speech, it is to be understood that He is referring to all people, male and female equally, unless He is specifically addressing an individual.

Calcutta is used throughout the book as that was the city's name in 1980, but now India has changed the city name to the pre-colonial name of Kolkata.

All names used are those of the person at the time in 1980. Any previous name relevant to the story or subsequent name change, is noted on the first mention in brackets after the name.

The responsibility for accuracy in this book rests with me. I have attempted to confirm exactly what Bábá said by cross-referencing with those present as soon as possible after His Darshan or conversation. Other particulars of dates or names mentioned, have also been verified where possible with relevant Ácáryas, the Publications Department or the Archives of Ananda Marga Global

Camp Headquarters, Kolkata. Likewise, to establish the accuracy of my diary entries, I have cross-referenced them with what Bábá has said in His own books currently published in English and detailed this at the back of the book. I have also attempted to follow Bábá's directions to the Publications Department regarding publication of His Darshans, conversations and image, in particular, the cover artwork is an artistic representation, not an actual photographic image of Bábá.

If anyone has any corrections or queries about the accuracy of any details, I would be grateful for their correspondence to improve any future edition.

All mistakes are mine. All credit must go to Bábá without whose grace and inspiration there would be no book. On the 21st October 1990 Bábá left His body in what is referred to as Maháprayan – a great departure. Shrii Shrii Ánandamúrti (b. Shrii Prabhat Ranjan Sarkar) (1921-1990).

PRELUDE

“Have you recorded what I said last night?... I have not said this previously... It should be recorded, not for you, but for others”, my Guru instructed me.

With these words, Bábá (Shrii Shrii Ánandamúrti) instilled in me the impetus to write this book. Bábá, meaning father, founded Ananda Marga in 1955 to promote His system of yoga and to engage in service work around the world. Much of the importance of His lessons were unclear to me at the time, but I am seeing that some lessons had been addressed to me in the unfolding future. I am still learning from His instructions that I have recorded here.

Through His words and example, Bábá’s inspiration is always with me. In the writing of this book, my prayer is that this inspiration is also showered abundantly upon the reader. God knows we need it. Both in the ongoing struggle of our personal inner lives and in coping with the chaotic turmoil of world events that, in these times, seem to teeter our tiny planet on the edge of one global catastrophe after another.



Introduction

A hot lonely wind whistles across the train platform. I look up and down the track. It is empty for miles. The next train will arrive in a few hours to take me back to Calcutta. Crowds of sweltering locals stand, squat or lay resting along the length of the platform. They had stopped staring at the foreigner a long time ago. With their curiosity satiated for the moment, I think now is a good time to take a photo of this typical Indian railway scene. Gingerly I pull out my bulky, old SLR camera and put the viewfinder to my eye. Before I can blink, people start to crowd in front of me. A group of intrigued people stands within a few meters around me and directly in front of the camera, staring at what I might do next with unabashed curiosity. It is impossible to take a photo, unless I want a shot of the head of the person inches from the front of the lens, looking at the camera. There is nothing to do, but put it away. Dissatisfied at the removal of their object of curiosity, the crowd slowly disperses to their waiting positions along the platform. Some cute, intently gazing children linger hoping that I might bring the camera out again and take a picture of them.

I wander out to the entrance of the station. A large baked earth parking area stretches in front of me. It is empty except for a cow grazing calmly to one side and a dozing rickshaw driver out in front waiting for customers. On the far side of the road, sitting on the ground, is a man in the shabby orange dress of a wandering holy man, a *sádhu*. The look of him intrigues me. The *sádhu* also sees me and gives a welcoming wobble of his head to invite me over. What is he doing in this empty stretch of rural countryside? I nonchalantly stroll across the gravelly expanse until I can see that he has a small sign erected. Written on it in scrawled English is, 'Palms Read, Rs 10'.

This looks like the most exciting thing happening anywhere around Shantiniketan station this afternoon. I approach him and foolishly enquire, “Do you read palms?”

“Yes, palm read for only ten rupees, no problem, ok?”

“Ok”, I agree. It is a cheap enough price for some entertainment and who knows, I might learn something. “Please kindly sit sir and let me look at your palm.” I squat down and extend my hand.

He barely glances at my palm, then looks me in the face and without blinking an eye, proudly announces, “You have come from very far away.” I am dumbfounded. Is this the best he can do? I think it is fairly obvious that I don’t come from up the road in rural Shantiniketan or for that matter anywhere else in India. Another fleeting look at my palm and he elaborates, “You are from Australia?”

“Hey, that’s pretty good”, I think as I nod. He must have picked my accent.

With a big smile on his face, he coolly continues, “You are from Sydney?” What! He is right. I am living in Sydney. He rapidly continues, “Do you know Kings Cross in Sydney. I have visited there several times. I was a merchant seaman before I became a sádhu and I travelled all over the world.” He leaves me gob-struck. Of all my luck, I pick the only sádhu in India who wants to talk about Kings Cross, the seedy area of inner city Sydney with all the nightclubs, bars and strip joints. I begrudgingly say I know the area and thrust my palm forward hoping the sádhu might continue the reading without further comment on his maritime past life.

Unperturbed, he smilingly obliges and to my surprise, continues his reading with remarkable accuracy. The sádhu details certain aspects of my life with a precision that sets me aback as he traces his finger across my palms. Then he stops and studies a particular part intensely, turning my palm one way and another to better catch the lines in the light of the dusty orange setting sun. He looks me straight in the eye and solemnly proclaims, “God has saved your life three times”. This is his conclusion to the reading. Slightly perturbed by this last statement, I pay the ten rupees, thank him and walk back to the station.

He was right. My life had been saved in seemingly lucky strokes that miraculously denied the odds against me. When I was young, about six years old, I snuck into a huge construction area for a new university, near my home. It was still mostly bush with road works in progress. I wandered through the area hiding behind trees and watching all the heavy earth-moving vehicles driving around. I proceeded up a small hillside where I could view a large construction area below. On my hands and knees, I crept in closer to see what was happening. One man was setting some things in the ground and everyone else was walking quickly away towards one end where they sheltered behind bulldozers and trucks. The last man ran back, sounded a horn and then pushed down on a small box. Everything in the construction area erupted in a massive explosion. Terrified, I upped and ran through the bush. Boulders of every size, many as big as basketballs, some like fridges, rained down all around me in a horrifying hailstorm. The workers, seeing me run, yelled and screamed in panic. I just kept running. Somehow, I wove my way through this pepper-shot of rocks as they pounded into the ground all around me. I was untouched. God had saved my life for the first time.

In my early teens, my brother Wayne, three years my senior and our friends would go to the beach almost every weekend of the summer to body surf. Australian beaches are a wonderful place to grow up and we loved every sunburnt, thrill-seeking moment. We were fit and youthfully confident in the water. Late in the season of one particular summer, we heard on the radio that the waves were unusually large at the beaches due to the tail end of a cyclone up north and board surfers were headed off to their beach of choice in droves. We piled into Wayne's car and drove excitedly to our favourite beach, Scarborough. The waves were big, breaking far out and rolling strongly right up to the beach. Without hesitation we dived in and swam out to the break. The water was wild, bigger than I'd ever seen it and with a dangerous undertow sucking back out to the next break. Within no time, I was in trouble. The waves were too rough and powerful to surf and I found myself just being rolled in the current. When I came up, nearer the beach, the undertow just dragged me underwater and back out to the next massive breaking wave, only to be tumbled and pummelled back to another undertow. This continued

until I was breathless and exhausted. One more wave came and I took a shallow breath, but hardly had any strength to battle with the wave as it rolled me like a giant washing machine, bouncing me continuously on the abrasive sandy bottom. Floppily I came up unable to get a breath as the tow dragged me back out to the next wave. All of my strength was concentrated on holding my breath. Bodily I was like a rag doll spinning with the current. I knew that when I came up next time, it would be my last. I had no breath, no strength left and I would be dragged under by the next tow without time to replenish my air and then be hit by another enormous wave. As the wave pushing me towards the beach slowed, the undertow began pulling me out again. Surprisingly it slowed in its ferocity such that I was able to unsteadily make a stand. I took a great gasp of air. There was a break in the wave cycle. Another wave had not come. With every last ounce of my strength I pushed towards the shore and away from the next massive wave surging towards a breaking roll. These few seconds were just enough for me to move out of the full strength of the undertow. I struggled, unbelievably exhausted to the beach and collapsed. My gratitude for those few seconds of break in the waves was immense. I found it hard to believe that at the exact moment where I would be dragged down for the third and last time, there should be a lull. God had saved my life for the second time.

Entering the old train building, I find an empty seat and sit for a moment. I can't think of a third time. There were no other life-threatening moments in my life like these two. Was it something I was unaware of? Some near-miss averted by the hand of God? Was the palm-reading *sādhū* mistaken? Maybe these previous two were just plain luck; the random chance of a materialist world? If so, I was particularly lucky. Then it came to me. There was a third time. Different, but dramatic in its own way and part of the reason I was here in India in the first place. For me this was clearly beyond the mundane and drew me into a greater reality.

All through my teens I had struggled with questioning life's purpose, reading everything I could get my hands on, looking for anything that could make sense of a confusing unjust world and a difficult childhood

of family violence and alcoholism. In my late teens, while at university, I was consumed with inquiring about the meaning of life, of my life. On my daily travels to university, I would change buses in the city with an hour or so's cold winter wait in-between. Across the road was a warm pub with a window seat where I could watch for the bus to arrive. Here I would sit, have a drink and continue to ponder the confusions and conflicts of my life. As this ritual continued day after day, my ponderings became more morose and study at a university whose motto was 'Know Thyself', held less meaning. Gradually I began to miss one bus and wait for the next. Eventually I did not go at all. I began to spend the days in a pub-crawl swirl of drunken introspection. Although the extremes of this time were only a few months, they were a destructive spiral downwards.

One day, I found myself in a tiny skid row wine bar buying a drink for the bum sitting next to me. I didn't know where I was or what I was doing. I was completely drunk. In this stupor I raised my hand calling out to the bartender, "Two ports, mate." I was probably on the slippery slope to alcoholism, not unusual in my Irish heritage. In that instant, a voice rang out clearly and loudly in my head, "THIS IS NOT THE WAY!" I snapped into complete awareness as if someone had given me an electric shock. Suddenly and with great clarity I moved from stupor to being fully awake, such that I found myself in this dingy bar with arm raised ordering port for the down-and-out beside me. Astonished, I lowered my hand, slid off my barstool and walked out, never to drink again. God had saved my life for a third time.

Here in India, at a lonely railway station, I am reminded that my life, despite the sometime confusion and difficulties, is being directed and assisted by a Benign Reality. This last event did not remove my inquiry into greater meaning in my life. It shifted it to more productive means. With a clearer mind and a deep yearning, I continued struggling to make sense of the world I lived in. Why did particular things happen? What was I here for? Was there more than this, a mundane day-to-day existence? As I read, studied and experimented with life, small slithers made sense, but overall, life still felt confusing and devoid of an essential cohesive meaning.

A feeling that there must be something greater than what my senses perceived, consumed me. This was to the extent that, to find the answers, I threw away the beginnings of a promising corporate career. I was propelled by a sense that this universe must have intelligence behind it and it would reveal itself to me if I sincerely inquired. I was compelled to go on this quest and staked everything.

Finally under this intense inner searching and questioning, I achieved a satori, a profound awakening. I came to a deep spiritual realisation of the interconnectedness of all things and myself, that answered this quest. The pieces of the jigsaw puzzle all came together in a blinding flash of awareness one day on a journey into the Australian outback. This was an awareness that did not abate, that could not be denied or rationalised away. This ‘something greater than myself’ was experiential. The source of the universe did reveal itself to me. With this experience came an appreciation of the ever-present mystical path that runs through all spiritual and religious traditions, sometimes referred to as ‘the Perennial Philosophy’ or as Sanātana Dharma, the Eternal Path. With this awakening, I became aware of the greater evolutionary process and that certain spiritual practices, like meditation, could deepen and speed up this individual spiritual evolution towards total awareness or enlightenment.

I was aware of energy surging through my body and my senses were keenly tuned to all around me. I focussed my mind by using the simple mantra, ‘*Be Here Now*’ that had been part of my awakening process. In this regard, my prañams go to Neem Karoli Bábá who had inspired this.

Sages of the past have said, ‘When the disciple is ready, the Guru appears’. In my case, I was ripe for the picking. I had some small theoretical familiarity with yoga, but I did not grasp its inner meaning until this point of awakening. It led me to seek the path of meditation in earnest. I found that it was on my doorstep, waiting. There were several yoga and meditation groups in my town. One group, Ananda Marga, appealed to me and I went there for personal instruction, called *tāntrika diikṣā*. This initiation into the Tāntrika system of meditation is where an *Iśā mantra* or personal Sanskrit mantra and

an *Iśā cakra* or point of concentration during meditation is prescribed by a qualified teacher¹.

On a stinking hot, summer's day in 1973, I sat awkwardly cross-legged before a yogic monk, Ācārya Dharmavedānanda. We were in a tiny windowless room of the Ananda Marga *jāgrti*, a yoga centre or ashram, located in a leafy suburb of Perth, Western Australia, my hometown. As the Ācārya sat there meditating, I also stilled my mind. Then in the deep silence of this hermitage cell of a room, he imparted the secrets of thousands of years of Indian mystical practice to me. This was the Guru's modern day distillation of the yoga of Shiva, the first propounder of the ancient mystic tradition of Tantra Yoga originating several thousand years ago.

The meditation technique of mantra repetition is a simple practice to be carefully learned and replicated exactly for the desired result of drawing the mind into a serene sensibility and growing closeness to God awareness. I was ecstatic with my initiation, after several years of sometimes excruciating inner search and confusion.

Over the next few years, I involved myself more and more in the activities of Ananda Marga, until, among other work, I held a national position as the Education, Relief and Welfare Secretary. Partly due to the many duties and responsibilities I had undertaken in this service work conducted by Ananda Marga and also due to the Indian State of Emergency during this time, I did not go to see Bábá, who resided in Calcutta, until 1980.

Although eager to meet Him, this did not concern me overly, as I primarily viewed the concept of the Guru as a Presence within and around me all the time, as God, my Higher Self, or Cosmic Consciousness. Awareness of this Presence had been with me before I encountered Ananda Marga and I now responded to this as reflected clearly through Shrii Shrii Ānandamūrti, whose spiritual name means, the Embodiment of Bliss.

To me, the Guru represents or reflects this Universal Awareness, that Entity which leads the devotee from darkness to light and may be in a

body or not. Being in the presence of an embodied Guru was an added bonus. Some might say it was a bonus rare among many lifetimes. Over the preceding several years I had a growing awe of this person whom I had entrusted my spiritual life to, but knew so little about directly. Eventually, my wife, Áshrava (Esme) and I flew to India from Sydney, Australia with this in mind.



The Journey Begins

25 February 1980

I have never really been overseas before, other than to New Zealand where I met Áshrava and which has a similar culture to Australia. At this time I didn't know of any backpackers' guidebooks to India, or anywhere else for that matter, so I made inquiries from friends who had been there. Unfortunately, I didn't seem to get any clear information about what to expect, either practically or culturally. Nevertheless, Áshrava and I embark with very little guidance and a lot of faith. All I really have is an address in Calcutta for Ananda Marga and a letter of introduction.

To those who have never ventured to India, here is a story my brother Wayne told me. It characterises India in its size, vast numbers of people and poverty. He was flying into Bombay, now called Mumbai, on a transit to London, having never yet travelled in India itself. Flying in, he looked down as the plane was descending and the airport could just be glimpsed. Wayne could see tiny specs in long lines moving on the vast grassy areas of the airport grounds. Intrigued, he craned his neck as the plane drew closer and closer, finally making out that these rows of moving specs were humans, hundreds of them. The plane zoomed in, levelling out for the runway approach, and Wayne saw these people bending down doing something, all crouched over, moving slowly forward in long lines on their knees. As the plane's wheels squeal-touched on the runway, he could now clearly see row upon row, hundreds of workers, in long lines, all with clippers in their hands. They were mowing, blade by blade, the vast airport grounds by hand. His story left me to wonder at what the rest of India would be like. Although embracing modernity, India still practises rituals from the

Bronze Age in everyday life. One of my attractions to Ananda Marga was that, unlike some other spiritual groups I checked out, it challenged superstitious and exploitative traditions and created an intelligent blend of social change and spiritual practice.

Áshrava and I fly into Dum Dum Airport, Calcutta, on the morning of February 25, 1980. Moving easily through customs, we push our way past the huge airport arrivals crowd of hotel pickups, awaiting relatives, touts, and numerous taxi *wallahs* to eventually settle on an insistent, but cheerful looking taxi driver for our journey. We clamber into his little black, bashed Ambassador taxi for the couple of hours drive it will take to reach the Ananda Marga Central Office at Jodhpur Park, a suburb in south Calcutta, the other side of the city from the airport.

Cows, cars, noise, and people are everywhere. Accompanying these are unaccustomed sights and sounds that compete for our senses as we drive on. Áshrava and I, engrossed with what is outside the windows, are mute and occasionally glance at each other with excited looks. At one point, the taxi stops in a long jumble of blocked traffic of every shape and size – bicycle rickshaws, cow-drawn carts, motorbikes, trucks, buses and Ambassador cars, to name a few. We edge slowly forward through a tangled bottleneck. The cause shows itself as a rubbish pile so high it has toppled to spill across the road from the pavement only allowing one lane of traffic to pass at a time. There is no traffic control and vehicles from both sides inch their way into the available single lane to get through. A team of workers is shoveling and hand-loading this mass of refuse into a battered old truck. Negotiating passed the roadblock, our taxi continues on its way.

When we near our destination, the driver pulls over and asks a rickshaw man directions to the street we are seeking. Another rickshaw wallah joins in and they seem to be pointing in opposite directions while speaking Bengali loudly in an animated fashion. Unperturbed, the driver sets off and repeats his enquiry a few more times before the taxi finally pulls up to a halt in front of a two or three storey building in a quiet suburban street. With a tilt of his head and wave of his pointed finger, the driver indicates we are here. I look up at the rough red and yellow

brick building flanked by other paint-washed concrete apartment blocks. Long brightly coloured saris trail down from a window, drying in the sun and breeze. Graffiti scrawled in Bengali and tagged with a red hammer and sickle is painted on the next building's wall. I see no name or signs for Ananda Marga, so I am cautiously unconvinced that we are actually at our destination. Then Áshrava excitedly calls and points to where I see a familiar saffron coloured monk's robe adorning an Ácárya in the doorway. This must be it. I pay the driver and we climb out to be greeted with a friendly welcome of namaskár from the Ácárya. "Namaskár Dádá", I greet him in return. Dádá, meaning elder brother, is an affectionate term to address male Ácáryas; Didi is elder sister for female Ácáryás. "We have just arrived from Australia," I tell the Ácárya. "Please go upstairs to the office and introduce yourselves to the Office Secretary. He will make any arrangements for you", Dádá directs us.

Áshrava and I hoister up our backpacks and clamber up the narrow stairs to the first floor. I tentatively peer in the doorway at the top of the stairs to see a throng of Ácáryás talking around a cluttered desk. When one Dádá notices us, I ask for the Office Secretary, who steps forward from the group. Introducing ourselves, we eagerly inquire as to Bábá's schedule and when we can visit Him. "Bábá is at His house in Lake Gardens, but wait until this evening when you will be able to see Him", directs the Ácárya. They then make provision for Áshrava to stay at the nearby women's jágrti and for me to be able to stay here at Central Office in the men's dormitory.

The Central Office building consists of several office rooms for the different departments of Ananda Marga in public relations, disaster relief, education and publications; Bábá's personal office area; a large open space for group meditation; bedrooms; and the rooftop for washing, food preparation and dining. Ananda Marga runs everything on a shoestring, including extensive social service work, thanks to the volunteer work of so many members and Ácáryas. This, the international 'Central Office', is a no-frills establishment where charitable social works, rather than administrative or personal facilities claim the scant finances.

This has become even more so since the infamous Indian National State of Emergency from June 1975 to March 1977, when Ananda Marga lost most of its assets and infrastructure to Government pilfering or destruction in a systematic campaign to wipe out all opposition to Indira Gandhi's unlawful government. This also saw widespread detention without trial of all opposition politicians and many other groups including Ananda Marga; forced vasectomy, without anesthetic, of thousands of lower caste men in the guise of the notorious family planning initiative; and Government media propaganda within India and overseas, to legitimise its dictatorial actions. Many márgiis, as members of Ananda Marga are referred to, and Ácáryas were detained in jail. This was a dark chapter in India's history. Although Indira Gandhi is no longer in power, there is still aversion towards Ananda Marga because of its opposition to corruption and its successful service projects.

An Ácárya directs me down the corridor where I find a place to plonk my backpack in a corner of the large room used as a dormitory at night and activities during the day. Áshrava is taken on a walk of a few blocks to the women's jágrti. There she meets the Didis in residence, deposits her luggage and freshens up.

Later, up on the office rooftop, Áshrava joins me for lunch. There are a few Indian márgiis, but most of the people up here for lunch are Ácáryas. Everyone is sitting at wooden benches under the bright blue sky. Black, shiny-backed crows peer at us, cawing incessantly as they wait to swoop down on whatever scraps we may drop or leave after a meal. When it arrives, dinner is literally a pyramid-sized plate of white rice. On the side in a small stainless steel dish is a dollop of *sabji*, well-cooked chilli-hot curried vegetables. While it is a departure from our usual meal of copious salad or lightly steamed fresh vegetables, Áshrava and I gratefully eat all we can. Even so, we hardly make a dent in the mountain of rice. Sitting with the márgiis and Ácáryas in the brilliant rooftop sunshine, we chat about Bábá, while answering all their questions on Australia. The one question we need clearly answered is, "How do we get to Bábá's house?"

“That’s easy. Go out of the front of the office and ask any rickshaw wallah to take you there. They all know the way”, says one helpful Ācārya.

Still we write down the address of Bábá’s house, which He has named Madhu Málaiṅca (sweet beautiful flower). It is situated near PA Shah Rd, at 162/188, in the nearby suburb of Lake Gardens. The Ācārya instructs us, “Go there in the evening, just before 9.30pm, you will be able to greet Bábá when He comes out to drive off for His evening walk”. We also get some indication of Bábá’s current schedule and other times when we might see Him.

This, then will become our routine while in Calcutta: mornings greeting Bábá at His residence as He goes out; His occasional daytime *Darshan* (an audience where devotees get the opportunity to be in the presence of the guru); night-time greeting Him again as He goes on and returns from an evening walk. What follows, are my interactions, observances and thoughts over almost two months of being in His presence, as we do *kiirtana*, singing the Sanskrit spiritual chant ‘Bábá náma kevalam’ for Him and engage in conversation virtually every day. Bábá’s words are recorded as accurately as possible. All else is my personal experience and interpretation.

Come evening, sure enough, the first rickshaw driver we approach, just outside the office building, beams, wobbling his head from side to side and encouragingly replies, “*Ācchá, ācchá*”, as he beckons us to climb aboard. The driver briskly pedals off, while we comfortably sit, perched high in the back seat. From here we have a clear view of the passing sights lit by dangling bare light bulbs like so many stars. There are corner *chai* shops brimming with customers sipping their sweet strong tea, markets with copious amounts of vegetables and flowers, and locals walking in the cool evening air. For ten or fifteen minutes, we wind our way through back streets and down alleys across the distance between Jodhpur Park and Lake Gardens until we pull up outside Bábá’s house. Checking my watch I note that we have arrived a little before 9.30 in the evening when, we are told, Bábá leaves for His evening walk. Āshrava and I alight, pay the driver a few rupees and look about.

Bábá's residence is two storeyed and painted a quaint shade of pastel pale green trimmed with a rustic pink and surrounded by a high brick wall rendered in the same colours. A fragrant bushing of jasmine vines bridge across the top of the driveway entrance. Iron gates in the same pastel green open on to a concrete driveway stretching half a dozen metres to an open garage. Bábá's car, an old, immaculate, grey Dodge Desota sedan sits awaiting Him in the garage. There is a small guardhouse on the left entrance of the driveway and a lawn and gardens on the right. All around the property, pots and pots of plants, especially orchids, line every available inch of wall and lawn edge.

There is a group of about twenty márgiis milling around the driveway and the lawn area in small groups, talking and waiting. They are there for the same purpose, to see Bábá, greet Him, and seek His blessing. Some are here to ask Him a personal question and receive His guidance. A few VSS personnel, márgiis volunteering as bodyguards of Ananda Marga, in their soft grey uniforms and green cloth slouch hats are waiting casually, but alert, at the gate. I approach the guard standing next to the shiny black Enfield motorbike and ask the whereabouts of Ácárya Akśáyánanda. The guard points out Dádá standing on a small marble veranda near the meditation room entrance, which takes up a large part of the ground floor of Bábá's house.

Áshrava and I had been told before leaving Australia that Bábá is creating a botanical museum and collecting many types of plants, especially endangered or unusual species. With this in mind, we have brought two interesting Australian orchids for His collection. Ácárya Akśáyánanda is in charge of the plant collection and accepts botanical contributions on Bábá's behalf.

"Namaskár Dádá. We have just arrived today from Australia." Áshrava steps forward, the orchids in her extended right hand, touching the elbow with the left hand in a gesture of respectful offering. She goes on to explain, "We have brought these Australian terrestrial orchids for Bábá. We think that they are somewhat unique, as they don't grow anywhere else in the world except the southern part of Australia. Also they grow completely under the ground and only pop up a flower just

above the surface.” Dádá’s gentle face expresses equal amounts of inquisitiveness and amusement as he accepts the orchids.

“Thank you very much. I will inform Báábá that you have brought these orchids and He will give me instruction how to plant them properly. Many márgiis are starting to bring plants. Thank you once again. I will also tell Rámánandaji, Báábá’s Personal Assistant, that you are here, but I think Báábá is coming soon, so go now and join the others near the car.”

Báábá’s car has been driven out of the garage and parked just before the gates. The dozen or so márgiis here at Báábá’s residence tonight, knowing the routine, are forming a line from the beginning of the driveway, up the path on the left side of the house leading to the front door and stairway upstairs. Taking our leave of Dádá, Áshrava and I join near the end of the line. Someone at the front begins the devotional chanting of a kiirtana tune. We join in with everyone while watching with anticipation up the laneway. The melodious Báábá náma kevalam chant echoes dreamily across the garden and mixes in my senses with the sweet fragrance of the jasmine blooms on the gateway above me. My mind focuses as the tune stirs the devotional longings of my heart. Shortly, the VSS bodyguard at the front door snaps to attention and salutes as Báábá walks out.

Through the line of craning, peering devotees, I catch a glimpse of Báábá. His face has a beaming smile as He slowly walks down the pathway. His hands are together at His chest in a namaskár greeting to all. Some people are calling out their greeting of namaskár. Others are silent. Báábá is a figure in radiant white flanked by the vivid saffron orange of His assistants, Ácárya Rámánanda and Ácárya Akśayánanda, who accompany Him. Even in this short space, I can see that Báábá is a charismatic person of simple tastes. All eyes in the crowd are riveted upon Him. There is a glow about His face. He is wearing a simple, white cotton *kurta* shirt and *dhoti*. Báábá is short at 154 cm (5’1”). His hair is cropped close and receding on a round head. The skin of His face is remarkably smooth. He proceeds with an air of calm authority, self-contained, and glowing. As Báábá reaches the car, He walks around

to the far rear door already opened in readiness. He steps into the back seat of the car. The driver is already in the car waiting and a VSS guard positions himself in the front passenger seat. Bábá talks a little to the guard and then swivels a little around to look at some of the márgiis still in their line on the opposite side of the car, before turning back again. Two guards swing open the wrought iron gates and Bábá is driven off for His evening walk, preceded by a motorcycled VSS guard.

It is like an electrical storm has just passed. The lightning, thunder and clash of massive clouds have rolled on and now all is quiet. The devotees stand around talking softly or walking about the lawn and garden waiting the hour and a half that Bábá takes to return from His nightly exercise routine. The evening is pleasantly warm. The air is fragrant with tropical flowers of jasmine and frangipani. Áshrava looks at me. Her eyes sparkle and there is the hint of a tear. She too has felt the electricity in the air.

The time passes easily as Áshrava and I sit on the edge of the verandah quietly soaking up the atmosphere. Then all the márgiis turn when the two guards left at the front gate snap their feet together and stand at attention while Bábá's car smoothly swings back into the driveway. As the waiting márgiis again line up along the pathway, Áshrava and I respectfully jostle for a position in the centre. Bábá alights from the car and walks around it to the front of the line of márgiis beginning at the guardhouse. He passes along this line greeting each person and stops just down from us. I can hear Him talking to a European márgii, Púrma Premá, about the history of the Czech & Slav races from which she is descended.

Concluding, Bábá proceeds along the line. Ácárya Rámánanda, in tow behind, directs Bábá towards Áshrava and me, commenting, "These are márgiis from Australia, Bábá." Bábá pivots and greets us with a silent namaskár, slightly tilting His forehead to His raised hands, palms together. He touches His thumbs to His third eye (*ājñā cakra*) between His eyebrows and then to His heart. His ideation is slow and intense. Although namaskár is an general Indian greeting, in Ananda Marga it is also done with an ideation, the thought being: I pay respect to the Supreme Entity residing within you – with all the goodwill and

simplicity of my mind and the love and sweetness of my heart. The idea in this mode of salutation is that everyone is the manifestation of the Supreme Entity, so it is a suitable greeting to all regardless of age or status.² Áshrava and I likewise return Bábá's namaskár. For me the Supreme shines through Bábá very clearly and my ideation has a new import. Turning first to Áshrava, He inquires, "And what is your name?"

"Áshrava, Bábá."

Then to me, He also asks "And your name is...?"

When I reply, "Jiṇāneshvar", He nods His head in a gesture of knowing approval while looking at me with a penetrating gaze. Then He turns and continues walking up the line of people towards the doorway.

In this first brief encounter, I am overwhelmed, but am not sure whether it is because I have heard so much about Bábá or because of His charisma and spiritual presence. In short, I am awestruck by His presence. This sense of grandeur does not wane during the entirety of my visit, even though, most of the time, He creates a very informal atmosphere. Slowly, as I meet with Bábá more, I begin to realise that it is Bábá's spiritual presence that engulfs all around Him.



A Mini Birthday Party

Tuesday 26/2

Next morning, after a breakfast consisting of a large mound of rice and vegetable curry, Áshrava & I decide to walk from the Central Office over to Bába's house. Half way on the twenty minute walk, Áshrava points out a small shop with an enormous steaming wok set out in the front. Having a little time to spare, we go over to look. Supporting the blackened wok is a rough brick fireplace burning smoky charcoal. A steaming milky substance is brewing, while a young boy languidly stirs it with a heavy wooden ladle. Terracotta bowls of various sizes line a shelf. Hesitatingly I ask the shop owner what they contain and with a wobble of his head he answers, "Doi". Seeing I don't understand the Bengali, he emphasises, "Curd, curd !". Ah, I understand, this is a yoghurt shop. We buy two medium clay cups of freshly made yoghurt from milk thickened by slow evaporation in the wok and then set overnight. It's delicious and we'll be back for more next breakfast. The only problem is the exquisitely hand-turned terracotta cups are disposables here. Reluctantly we throw them onto an existing pile of cracked and broken cups. At least they are not polystyrene foam throwaways polluting the environment.

A little further along, and still with time to spare, I decide to duck into a bank and change some money. The exchange rate is eight Indian Rupees to the Australian dollar. With our modest savings bolstered by the inexpensive jágrti accommodation, we should be able to stretch out our time here for an ample stay in Calcutta. To change some money seems at the time a simple enough process, but in India everything requires triplicate paperwork, a stamp from every desk in the office and a different person to process each portion – the British system of bureaucracy expanded mightily. Although I thought the banking would

be only a matter of a few minutes diversion, it has taken us much longer. When we get the Rupees in our hands we quickly move on to our destination.

On arriving at Bábá's house, there is no car in the driveway. The guard at the gate sees Áshrava and I looking a little perplexed and informs us, "Bábá has already gone on field walk. You have missed Him." Oh no! Did we take that long on our walk? I thought we had enough time, but it just seemed to run away without us quite noticing it. I ask the guard his name.

"Parimal", he tells me. "Bábá will be back some time later", he adds. There are a few márgiis still here waiting for Bábá's return. Moreover Parimal goes on to further detail how Bábá had given two American devotees, who were here to greet Him, some type of special blessings. With resignation, Áshrava and I meander over to the lawn area.

Over the next few hours of waiting, I loll about the garden. I feel that I have missed out. Today is my birthday and I would have liked something special for this day. Had I not gone into the bank, had I not stopped for a curd, then would I have also been in line to receive a special blessing – whatever that means? From a bright and happy morning start, I notice my mind and emotions spiralling down. This won't do and eventually I try to pull myself out of it.

I can't keep mulling over this in a negative frame of mind. I must put it down to the grace of God that I will receive what I need at the right time. I decide to nip this negative train of thought in the bud and surrender my desires to God. These events cannot be foreshadowed or lamented about, but I must take them in my stride with the philosophical approach that I will always be taken care of by a Benign Universe. How can I know what is waiting around the next corner for me regardless of how circumstances seem now. Little do I know, but the events of the day will prove this true and give me a birthday to remember.

Eventually, there is a small kerfuffle over at the gates, as the VSS guards jump to and swing them open. Bábá's Dodge draws up to a smooth stop in the driveway and a guard opens the door for Him to

alight. Although a short man, Bábá stands erect, with relaxed dignity and authority. He waits at the car door for a few moments. By His gaze, Bábá singles out Áshrava and me from amongst the small group of devotees, looking directly at us, intensely, and then walks on to the house and inside. Initially, I feel that He is intimating, ‘Where were you!’, but I put that thought aside and see another interpretation, that He is acknowledging the intensity of my inner dialogue about not being there to see Him. This introspection and assigning meaning to every look, movement or word of Bábá is present all through my interactions with Him. He is a man of mystery by His own admission and although I try not to read undue meaning into everything that happens, being around Bábá heightens my awareness and focus in this way. Being in His presence is like a mirror to my inner self.

The morning’s event over with, Áshrava and I wander around the outside of Bábá’s house looking at all the plants. At the back, there is a row of large green painted clay bowls, at least a metre wide, acting as ponds for water-plants and fish. Next to this there are couple of plots of vegetables, some banana trees and a large, iron, hand-operated water-pump. All this is edged by numerous orchid plants in small pots filled with terracotta chips to hold them in. Dádá Akśayánanda is squatting down tending to some of the orchids. I interrupt him, “Excuse me Dádá, what is Bábá doing with the botanical museum?”

“Bábá is collecting rare and endangered plants from all over India and the world to protect them and for research”, Dádá explains.

As Dádá continues his gardening work, he shows us around the garden, pointing out particular plants of interest. Holding one exceptionally striking flowering orchid, Dádá explains, “Bábá’s favourite is the orchid and there are hundreds of them here in the garden. They are a special kind of plant. Orchids are the most numerous of flowering plants and considered one of the most advanced in evolution. Did you know that although they grow on rocks and trees, they are not parasitic? They live off nutrients washed over the rocks or tree bark they cling to and from the energy of the air. I think they might survive directly from the pranic energy in the air.”

After a lunch of the obligatory rice, *dal* and sabji curry vegetables at the Office, we go shopping through the fantastic array of Bengali fabric stores for more suitable clothing in this hot climate. I find a light kurta top and trousers in plain white cotton. Áshrava buys a sari and a simple white *shalwar kameez*, an Indian cotton top and trousers set. Báábá recommends that foreign devotees dress with discretion and respect for the Indian culture so as not to bring disrepute on Ananda Marga.

In the evening, we arrive at Báábá's house to find a large group of more than thirty márgiis thronging around the driveway and front garden, quite a few for this small area. Kiirtana starts up and we join in vigorously clapping and swaying to the music's rhythm. Kiirtana in Ananda Marga is the repetitious singing of a *Mahámantra* (great mantra), as in the '*Hare Kṛṣṇa*' or '*Om Namah Shiváya*' *Mahámantras*.

Báábá created the mantra Báábá náma kevalam. The same Sanskrit words are always repeated, but can be sung to any tune in a variety of combinations of the words used. This gives a range of tempo from the sweet to the ecstatic to the riotously rousing. The Sanskrit words, particularly of *Mahámantras*, have a variety of meaning. They are somewhat difficult to translate into English as there is often no direct translation.

One example is the *Mahámantra* of the Tibetan Buddhists, *Om Mani Padme Hum*. When asked, most Tibetans say that the *Om Mani Padme Hum* mantra is just for good luck, or brings blessings. Others say its literal translation is 'the jewel is in the lotus', but they have difficulty explaining clearly any more than this partial literal translation. On the Internet, there are troves of explanations to *Om Mani Padme Hum*. His Holiness the Dalai Lama contributes an internet page explaining the mantra's meaning:

It is very good to recite the mantra *Om Mani Padme Hum*, but while you are doing it, you should be thinking on its meaning, for the meaning of the six syllables is great and vast... *Om Mani Padme Hum* means that in dependence on the practice of a path, which is an indivisible union of method

and wisdom, you can transform your impure body, speech, and mind into the pure exalted body, speech, and mind of a Buddha.³

Bábá náma kevalam means, the name of the Lord is everything. Náma literally is translated as name, but can also mean ‘vibration’. Kevalam means everything that can be perceived. Thus all that I perceive, all of the world around me and my internal thoughts and feelings, are actually the embodiment of the vibration of Bábá (love, consciousness, awareness, God, the Guru). A simple understanding of Bábá náma kevalam is: love is every-where; or consciousness is everywhere; or everything that I see, hear, feel, think is consciousness or awareness. The mantra is to be felt and thought about, but predominately experienced. Kiirtana is an aspect of the Bhakti Path of loving devotion and involves not just singing the Mahámantra, but also you may dance in a swaying motion from left to right while lightly tapping one foot behind the other. Thus, the whole body, voice and mind are engaged at the time of doing kiirtana in spiritual focus upon the Infinite.

Lalita mármika, the dance used in kiirtana, expresses the sense of surrender to the Supreme, as the arms are held high above the head, palms facing up. In this pose, the elbows should not drop below a horizontal position as it lessens this effect. If the devotee becomes tired during kiirtana the palms can be brought together at the chest.

Lalita mármika has multiple effects, both mundane and subtle, upon the physical body and mind. The dancer bends the knees slightly while doing kiirtana. This flexes and loosens the knee joints and aids in sitting cross-legged during meditation. The dancer also steps sideways from left to right, tapping the big toe of the raised foot lightly behind the standing foot. This alternate tapping of the toe stimulates a meridian energy point. This point corresponds to acupuncture and reflexology location on the underside tip of the toe, and activates the pituitary gland and ájñá cakra in the forehead between the eyebrows. This is an aid to concentration in meditation.

The gathering group of devotees move as one with the kiirtana tune, swaying from left to right and clapping out every beat. When

Bábá is seen coming down the stairs, the kiirtana intensifies and the group raising their collective voice, pour their spiritual longing into the singing. Bábá comes to a stop before the group to listen and we take it to a crescendo and then tail off to a hushed ending. Obviously pleased, Bábá comments to the gathering how sweet our kiirtana is. He then enters the car and leaves for His evening walk.

One of the márgiis, Púrńa Premá, tells us that, since Bábá will be away for at least an hour, whoever is awaiting His return usually joins in the *Dharmacakra* collective meditation in the downstairs meditation room of the house. We follow Púrńa Premá and the others and enter the room. It is a mini hall with white tile floor and freshly whitewashed walls. These walls have a brilliant orange band of paint from floor to hip height. Surprisingly this colour combination gives a calm, but sharply focussed edge to the room. Higher up, also painted in orange and circling the wall there is partially finished Sanskrit *shlokas* from Bábá's book *Ánanda Sútram*. These shlokas give the essence of the Ananda Marga ideology in succinct couplets.

Everyone sits in rows upon the floor and the formal group meditation procedure begins. I couldn't think of a better way to spend my birthday than here, even though my ever-incorrigible mind runs to the events of the morning when I felt I had missed out, stirring up trouble and trying to make me feel disappointed again. I lay witness to my mind's antics, allowing these negative thoughts to be, without giving them undue attention, and repeatedly move my mind back to my personal mantra. In this way, I don't give energy to these thoughts I have no need of and they gradually fade from my conscious stream of thought, leaving me to bask in the serenity of my meditation. Often I have a great sense of inspiration during meditation, like I want to and can tackle any issue. Many times I come up with solutions to tasks before me during this time. Mostly there is just a pure sense of inspiration and gratitude washing over me. I am pulled from this deep relaxation by the whispered, ancient chant ending the meditation in Dharmacakra:

Nityam shuddhañ nirábhásañ nirákárañ Niraiñjanam
Nityabodhañ cidánandañ gururbrahma namámyaham

[Eternal, pure, without semblance, formless, without blemish;
With eternal wisdom, consciousness and bliss – to that *Brahma*,
the Guru, I surrender].

After the meditation finishes, everyone mills around in the driveway or garden, looking at the plants or talking quietly in small groups. Abruptly the guards at the gate leap to attention. The gates are already open and Báábá's car quickly swings into the driveway as people scatter to the sides to get out of the way. A devotee belatedly starts up a kiirtana tune and some others, all caught unprepared, join in, but this is a half-hearted attempt that soon grinds to a disjointed halt. The VSS guard opens Báábá's door and He eases Himself out. Standing and looking about at the gathered márgiis, Báábá addresses them in a mix of Bengali and English, appropriately about kiirtana, saying, "Kiirtana is singing the Lord's name loudly and clearly. It vibrates out in waves to affect every particle of the universe and draws us closer to the cosmic nucleus." He further stresses the importance of kiirtana and says that we should make many new tunes. Finishing, Báábá goes upstairs.

Áshrava turns to Púrña Premá and asks, "What happens now?"

Púrña Premá, with a big smile on her chubby cheeks, jovially replies, "Nothing. This is the end of the evening programme." The assembly of márgiis begins to disperse. All will be quiet for the night now. Áshrava and I remain with a few others to savour the atmosphere and talk quietly. One by one, people leave, stepping out through the now closed gate's small doorway and into the night to walk or catch a rickshaw.

A short time later, to the surprise of those left, Ácárya Rámánanda calls out from one of the upstairs windows, "Báábá wants everyone to come up for Darshan. Come quickly." One guard races out into the street to call to the two Americans, the ones who had received the special blessing in the morning, as they have just stepped out of the gate. He returns shaking his head saying that they are nowhere to be seen. Without delay, the six remaining márgiis; Áshrava, Púrña Premá, Gañesh (from Adelaide, Australia), Ácárya Krśñapriya (now Ácárya Krśñasevánanda Avadhúta), an Ácárya from Assam, and I, excitedly proceed to the stairway. From the comments of the Ácáryas, I gather

that this is not a usual event. Such is His grace and for me a birthday to remember.

We eagerly scramble up the stairs and into the foyer to see Bábá sitting in an alcove at the end of the room. I hesitate a moment and take in my surroundings. Bábá is sitting elegantly on a softly furnished daybed smiling gently in anticipation of our arrival. Ácárya Rámánanda shepherds our small group towards the foyer and we tentatively and respectfully approach and sit on the carpet in front of Bábá.

Bábá asks us all our names and what sector of the world we come from (as per the Ananda Marga system of grouping world regions). One by one, we reply. When Ácárya Krśñapriya answers that his posting is Suva Sector, Bábá corrects him, clarifying that his actual posting is in two sectors, not just one. Dádá realises his mistake, agreeing with Bábá. The thought crosses my mind: of the thousands of Ananda Marga workers, does Bábá remember everyone's organisational posting? The depth and intimacy of Bábá's knowledge is constantly revealed to me during my stay in Calcutta.

In relation to the mention of Suva Sector, being Australia and the Pacific islands, Bábá talks for some time about the continents in the past ages. "There was no India, no Himalayas. Australia was the southern most part of a continent called Gondwanaland, made up of Southern India, Indonesia, Malaysia and Australia, and at that time what is now the Atlantic Ocean was called Atlantis, west of the Iberian Peninsula."⁴ Finishing this theme, Bábá sits in silence for a short while with eyes closed, and we just gaze at Him, thinking upon what He has just said. I cannot keep the thought out of my mind, "Who is this man?" I have had a relationship from a distance with Him as my Guru and now I get to sit before Him and deepen that relationship in person.

When Bábá opens His eyes, He turns to me and asks me to repeat what He had said earlier in the evening about kiirtana. Having been at the back of the driveway group and not hearing it all clearly, I repeat how I understood it, "It leads you towards the Cosmic Nucleus and it sends out waves vibrating all the masses". By 'masses' I meant 'all the earth's people in general'.

Bábá comments, “Little boy, you have said very much” and then gently corrects my misunderstanding as if I were a young schoolboy. “When you do kiirtana, it sends out waves that vibrate the whole cosmos, every single particle. Human beings are only a small part of the universe.” He elaborates simply and eloquently, “Kiirtana vibrates the entire cosmos and touches every heart.”^B

Bábá’s speech is slow, emphasised, moderated. He pauses momentarily at key words, accentuating what He has to say. I sit transfixed on His every word because He gives such import to what He says, to each word. I have studied many of Bábá’s books and taught classes in His philosophy, but this is the man Himself talking directly to me. I am overwhelmed by gratitude at this opportunity to sit at the feet of someone I believe is one of the great thinkers, philosophers, polymaths and teachers of our times. More than these, He is my Guru, one who leads you from the darkness to the light on the spiritual journey. The Guru is the dispeller of darkness, the one who removes the spiritual darkness from the mind. Any indication or direction from Bábá is direction from a maestro of the soul, from a person who has made the great journey to enlightenment and sees from an immense height in which direction I should go. It is my journey and only I can traverse it, but the Guru can give invaluable direction and inspiration.

Bábá continues fondly in this manner, saying that He will ask questions as if it is primary school and He is the teacher. In a typical fashion, first He asks, “What is the correct pronunciation of ‘question’? Is it quest ion or ques shun?” The group offers a few lame answers with no basis of knowledge, and Bábá benignly explains, “Question comes from ‘quest’, in the Latin, meaning ‘to search’. The correct answer is quest ion.”^C

My initial reaction is, “What is He talking about? What does it matter how I pronounce the word.” And then I remember, Bábá is a linguist. He unravels history and language. So much of His philosophy is clarifications that give the understanding of how to apply things, not just a rote application of ritual. The understanding of language is very important in social change. I had been witnessing the feminist and

anti-racism challenge to words that kept exploitative systems in place. What could I learn from Bábá's questioning?

With His approach, Bábá is defining our relationship. He clearly is the teacher and asking the questions. But in this case it is not just questions to elicit information. He again has defined this in laying the derivation of 'question' in the Latin 'quest' – the diligent search for something, the mystical, the spiritual. I am on a quest. A quest is often characterised by a long and arduous search to fulfil a lack of something in your life. A journey towards a goal. A quest is often characterised as a journey to realise something and thereby return home. This 'home' is from where we originate and the place for which we feel the deepest affection – God, consciousness, our real Self.

Following on, Bábá asks of the group, "What is the Latin for 'north'?"

From amongst the group some bright spark up on their Latin smartly replies, "*Septemtrion*, Bábá." I was never one for languages. Spelling and grammar became very difficult for me at one point in primary school when the English teacher made fun of my name in every class provoking a lot of laughter from my classmates and embarrassment for me. I think that this constant distress somehow stunted the languages section of my brain. Next Bábá asks for 'south'. Again, someone responds with a correct answer of *austri*. I vaguely remember from school history classes that the name of Australia had something to do with south in Latin. It is derived from the Latin word *australis*, which means 'southern'. Terra Australis, Latin for 'land of the south' was used by Aristotle to describe the theoretical, fabled, great continent in the southern part of the Indian Ocean that he thought must be there to balance out the continents of the northern hemisphere. It took quite a few centuries for European explorers to eventually find this Terra Australis, although the indigenous Aborigines have been living there for at least fifty thousand years – the longest uninterrupted culture on earth, I hear.

Bábá pauses for a moment and casts His eyes across our little gathered group. I happily sit there basking in the pleasantness of the

moment. “Jiṇáneshvar!”, He booms. “What is ‘east’?” For some reason, Bábá directs His question straight at me.

I furtively run around in my mind yelling out to my slumped brain cells, “East, east! What is the Latin for east? Find it, quick.” Stumped and apologetically raising my eyebrows, I stupidly reply, “Ahh..., I don’t know, Bábá.” Although I am following the questioning, I still have moments where I am just looking at Bábá. My brain just doesn’t seem to be in gear when I am in His presence. I can’t quite explain it, but I rationalise my mental vacancy, by telling myself that my mind goes into serene quietude in His presence. Sages say a Spiritual Master emanates an energy field widely around Himself. I think I become susceptible to this in some way. That’s my excuse anyway.

Bábá’s demeanour changes. Pointing at me, He emphatically says, “You do know!” with such conviction that I am momentarily stunned. I am at a complete loss for any response and gape in bewilderment. Bábá turns expectantly to the rest of the group and someone quickly answers the correct Latin, ‘*orient*’ in a chirpy tone. Instantly I realise that of course, I do know this word. Had I only assumed that I didn’t because I don’t have a depth of knowledge of Latin? Could I just not find it in that stunted language part of my brain? I am still stunned by Bábá’s emphatic statement ringing in my head like a gong, ‘You do know!’ I ponder His directness and possible meaning. He was correct, of course. I did know. However, was He just aware of my psyche and pointing out that I did know the answer or was He telling me something else that I should take note of? Was this a marker for me to look at something larger, more significant in myself? Bábá was definitely taking me on a quest, the ancient search for the mystical, and right now, I was at a loss as to which direction I should even proceed in. Bábá was my guide and I would follow His direction. Was I headed into the depths of the ‘orient’, the mystical, wise east?

As Bábá continues His teaching, He explains that there are two sorts of pronunciation in English: Norman and Anglo Saxon. “English vocabulary abounds in Nordic, Alpine and original Normandic words. English is a blended language and it has two sets of pronunciation – the

Latinic style of pronunciation and the Nordic or Anglo-Saxon style of pronunciation. For example, The English word ‘knife’ came from the French word ‘*kanif*.’ In English ‘knife’ is pronounced incorrectly when the ‘k’ is silent. ‘Education’ in Latinic style is pronounced ‘*adukation*’ and in Anglo-Saxon style ‘*ejucation*’.”⁴

Casting His gaze slowly across the group, Bááb settles on Gañesh and me sitting side by side. I’m slightly anxious, but at least I’m not singled out this time. Nodding His head slowly, He asks, “You two boys, what is the French pronunciation for ‘education’.”

I feel stupid again and we both reply in unison, “I don’t know French, Bááb.”

Raising His arms up in the air and looking around at everyone in a surprised manner, Bááb responds, “You don’t know French...? They are just like me.” With some relief I laugh with the whole group at this joke by a man who reputedly knows innumerable languages fluently. Despite His assertion, Bááb proceeds to give the answer, “The French pronunciation of education is ‘*e’ducation*’. ‘t’ is pronounced as ‘s’ in French.”⁵

After all this seeming digression with linguistics, Bááb directs a question of philosophy to the Ácárya from Assam. “What is the difference between Cosmic and Supracosmic? You may answer in any language that suits you, English, Bengali, Assamese, or any other language... then, I will give the correct answer.” In the face of this challenge, the Ácárya begins an attempt at answering, but does not seem to really know in any language. Bááb then asks Ácárya Krśñapriya, who correctly answers, “The Cosmic is within *Saguña Brahma* [qualified consciousness – Cosmic Mind including the manifest universe within it] and the Supracosmic [unqualified pure consciousness] is beyond *Saguña Brahma*”.

Satisfied, Bááb further expands the answer by asking, “What is the origin of the Cosmic Mind?” In Ananda Marga philosophy, the Cosmic Mind would be likened to a ‘God-like mind’, but although vast in its scope, it is still part of the finite manifest creation. Whereas the greater concept of ‘God’ conceived as *Parama Puruśa* includes the unmanifest,

an infinite ocean of consciousness with a manifest drop in it called Cosmic Mind/Creation/the Universe.

“What is the origin of the Cosmic Mind?”, repeats Bábá. We all strain to think of an answer, any answer. I turn the question over in my mind, but nothing jumps out. Everyone stares blankly. I expect the Ácáryas, well versed in Ananda Marga philosophy, to come up with at least a reasonable response, but they too are mute. Maybe I am not the only one whose mind is slowed in Bábá’s presence. In the face of this silence, Bábá answers, “There is no answer. It is beyond time. The origin of creation exists in eternal tempos. The goal of our *sádhaná* [sustained spiritual endeavour or practices] is Supracosmic and kiirtana helps in the march towards the Suprapsychic/Supracosmic stance – *Nirguña Brahma* [unqualified pure consciousness].”^D

With this statement Bábá has brought His lesson in a big circle back to kiirtana and the evening Darshan is over. Bábá sits back and gives us a slow namaskár and as we get up to leave, He slides His legs to the edge of the daybed and also stands. Accompanying us to the stairs, He turns to Gañesh and me cheerfully saying, “Well little boys, isn’t this a mini DMC?”

“Yes, Bábá”, we chime. We are thrilled and spill out into the barmy Indian night to contemplate our mini *Dharma Mahá Cakra* (DMC), a special discourse and blessing by Bábá.



A Small Notebook

Wednesday 27/2

I wake up inspired and motivated by the events of the night-before. Bábá has said so much in this special intimate Darshan and blessed me more than I had hoped for in my visit to Calcutta. I want to remember what He has said and share it with any márgiis back home in Australia who may be interested. With this in mind, as Áshrava and I walk to Bábá's house in the morning, I stop in at a small stationary shop crammed with every imaginable variation of paper item in bundles and stacks from floor to ceiling. How they find anything I don't know, but when I ask for a small notebook they duly pull a suitable one out from under a pile. I start with a reference to the first evening's meeting with Bábá and then continue writing up to last night's Darshan. Bábá covered so many things and I want to get it down as clearly as I can.

Although I am writing for my personal reference, I want to be as accurate as possible. Besides my recollection, I confer with Áshrava and a couple of the others who were present. When I clearly have what Bábá said, I put it in quotation marks; otherwise I give the general sense of what He talks about to the best of my ability. With this small beginning, little do I know at this time, what my jottings will develop into?

This morning we make sure we are at Bábá's residence on time. When He comes downstairs to leave for His field walk, He comments, "It was a nice DMC, was it not?" Áshrava and I agree enthusiastically with Bábá. This further motivates me to record what He has said and give sincere thought to what He imparts and how this might apply to my life.

Over the day, I read from my writing and consider Bábá's questioning of the previous night. Bábá has said that questioning was

one of the three prerequisites for spiritual knowledge. In His book, *Ānanda Vacanāmṛtam*, Part 4, Bábá writes:

Among so many people in our human society, very few get the opportunity to acquire spiritual knowledge. And among these, a still smaller percentage get the chance to undergo practical training. Why? Because science is rare, the aspirants are rarer, and the teachers are rarer still.

We want spiritual practice to be performed by one and all. And the minimum qualification for acquiring spiritual knowledge, spiritual bliss, is that one should have a human body. Simply having a human body is the requisite qualification. You may or may not have education, you may or may not have any social status, but what you must have is a human body.

Now, a person having a human body must also have the following three aspirations. One should be ready to enjoy spiritual bliss and acquire spiritual knowledge through *prañipátena*, *pariprashnena* and *sevayá*.

That is, an aspirant should have a sincere desire to know Him, a sincere longing for Him. One must be ready to sacrifice one's everything for that purpose. Then we will say that one is ready to do *prañipátena*. *Prañipátena* means complete surrender. Without this complete surrender nothing can be done. With all one's propensities moving towards crude objects, how can one move towards the Supreme Entity? So one will have to withdraw all psychic propensities moving towards cruder objects, and guide them towards the Supreme Entity. This is *prañipátena*.

Pariprashnena. *Pariprashnena* means 'question'. The root verb 'quest' means 'to look for'. The noun from quest is question. In Samskṛta, in the like manner, the word 'pariprashna' is derived from the prefix '*pari*' and the root verb '*pracch*'. What is *pariprashnena*? You know, sometimes just to quench the thirst of your inquisitiveness you ask a question; and sometimes just to befool the other person you ask a question. The answer is

known to you, but just to befool the other party you make an inquiry. And sometimes you ask a question meaninglessly. All these are nothing but whimsical expressions, capricious expressions. They are not *pariprashnena*. *Pariprashnena* has only one meaning, only one import, and that is that you are to ask a question in order to get a certain reply, and that reply will be followed by you in the practical field. You ask the question knowing that you will act according to the reply. So all the questions of spiritual aspirants must be *pariprashnena*, and not ordinary questions.

Sevayá. *Sevayá* means ‘through service’. When you want to learn the spiritual science from *Parama Puruṣa* [only *Parama Puruṣa* knows the spiritual science, and He preaches spiritual knowledge through a physical body, which we know as the Guru. So, actually, the science is known to *Parama Puruṣa* and to nobody else], when you want to know something from Him, you will have to satisfy Him. When He is pleased He will give the reply, He will teach you. His is not a mercenary business. So you will have to satisfy Him, please Him. And the only way to satisfy Him is to satisfy His children. The entire living world is His progeny. He is the Progenitor. So to satisfy Him you will have to render selfless service to His children. This rendering selfless service to the entire created world is known as *sevá*.

You know, our transactions are of two kinds. You give something, and at the same time you take something – this is called a commercial transaction. You give some dollars and receive some article in exchange. This transaction is mutual. This transaction is a business. When the transaction is unilateral, that is, when you are giving something and don’t get anything in return, it is called *sevá*. In English, *sevá* is unilateral or one-sided.

There is another way of explaining it. Let there be a commercial transaction: you will give some money and take something in return. Now, if you want to take the most costly article from Him, you will have to pay Him the highest sum. Thus, if you

want to get the most costly thing, that is, spiritual knowledge, you will have to give yourself, and not money.

Both of these may be treated as sevá. When your giving is unilateral, and when you are giving your everything to Him and receive spiritual knowledge, in both cases, it is sevá.

So in order to acquire spiritual knowledge and enjoy spiritual bliss, three actions are to be done by you. They are prañipátena, pariprashnena, and sevayá. This is the process of spiritual approach.⁶

I believe I had sincere desire and longing for the Supreme. What was I prepared to surrender to achieve that goal? Mostly, it was my ego that needed surrendering. The ‘sevá’ part of selfless service seemed straight forward enough, but the prañipátena, the questioning, the quest, seemed a little more elusive. ‘To look for’, with the commitment that upon finding the answer, it is to be acted upon in a practical way to achieve this goal. Something here seemed to turn my head round and round and I couldn’t quite grasp the implication of it. The question to ask seems to be the all-important thing. This is because there must be the commitment to put into action the result of the question. How often do we want something, but are not really prepared to do what is required to achieve that thing. Instead, we go on asking in our mind for that something and wonder why it never eventuates.

I remember once, when I was really, gravely ill and the doctors were recommending serious surgery for my bleak assortment of symptoms, I had a dream of Bábá:

I am asked into Bábá’s room. He is sitting on a daybed. I prostrate and then sit before Him. There are a couple of assistants nearby, Ácáryas. While sitting, it occurs to me that I should ask Bábá lofty questions like, ‘Why am I here in this universe?’, ‘What is the purpose of my life?’ ‘What should I be doing with my life and for my spiritual progress?’ When the time comes, my mouth opens and other words just pop out automatically, “Bábá, I am about to have an operation, what must I do to assist this?”

Previously in the dream, with my lofty questions, I had forgotten that I was ill. While I am asking the operation question, I am also thinking, why I am saying this; I had all these really important questions to ask. Báábá replies simply, “*ásanas*” and proceeds to get down off the bed to demonstrate them to me personally. Báábá positions Himself into *Gomukhásana* (Cowshead), where the feet are bent and intertwined and He sit on His heels, then hands are grasped behind the back. This *ásanas* is followed by *Mayúrášana* (Peacock). Báábá stretches His body out and balances horizontally with the elbows to the stomach and hands to the ground. He also demonstrates a couple of other *ásanas* well known to me from a number of years of practice. Báábá instructs me as to how the yoga exercise is conducted and names the postures. I notice the assistant writing these names down. This is a semi-lucid dream where I am partially aware I am dreaming and that I must try to remember the names of the *ásanas* for a later, wakeful state. I repeat the names to myself, trying to commit them to memory. Then Báábá does one last *ásana*. While standing in star shape, legs spread, facing forward, arms pointing out to the side, He raises, almost imperceptibly from flat feet up on His toes, holds a few seconds and returns. This simple movement is repeated. I have never seen such an *ásana*. It is so minute a movement that I think, what use could this be? Báábá, as if in response to my sceptical thought, comments, “If anyone doubts the effect of this particular *ásana*, then tell them that I personally recommend this.” Báábá then returns to the daybed. The interview is over and I am ushered out of the room by the assistant.

I awake immediately, the dream vivid in my mind. I remember the Sanskrit names of some of the *ásanas* and write them down. Later, I cannot find any reference to the last *ásana* in my yoga manuals or even in consultation with an *Ácárya*. In the dream, Báábá refers to “if anyone [else] doubts the effects of this particular *ásana*”, but then it hits me! It is not about, if anyone else doubts the *ásana*, but if *I* doubt this *ásana*. I am the one who doubts the benefit and effect of these *ásanas* to assist me in relation to the upcoming surgery. Although a practitioner of yoga

ásanas for years, I still have a subconscious doubt as to whether ásanas would be effective in this extreme situation. I mean, this is a serious operation. I could die. What are these twisty bendy ása exercises going to do, particularly a simple little one like rising up on my toes?

In my dream, Bábá created the example of this last ‘ásana’ that just seems too simple to really have a substantial effect. In this way, His approach has its desired result, as I now see my subconscious doubt and my resistance. Only after this realisation do I take seriously ásanas in relation to my illness. In Consultation with an Ácárya, I design an ása set that I commit to practising diligently over the next few months in the lead up to surgery and notice that my physical health improves markedly. This, I think, is pariprashnena, the question followed by the sincere commitment to put the answer into action.

In the evening, Áshrava and I go to Bábá’s house a little earlier, at eight o’clock, and start kiirtana and *bhajans* (devotional songs) to fill the hour or so before He arrives. Gradually, other márgiis come and join us in singing. When Bábá comes down for field walk, the group of devotees is doing kiirtana wholeheartedly. At this, Bábá comments on how sweet the kiirtana is. On His return, everyone is standing around waiting. There is no kiirtana to greet Him. No one seemed to think, no one took the initiative. In a disappointed tone Bábá says, “They are not doing kiirtana now!” He proceeds along the laneway and upstairs. We get the message. He likes us to do kiirtana all the time. With Bábá gone upstairs to His quarters, most márgiis leave and a few wait around enjoying each other’s company once again and the serenity of this sanctuary.

A little while later to our immense surprise, those still waiting are again called upstairs, this time for Personal Contact (PC), the chance to meet Bábá individually and privately for His counsel and blessing. A small group crowds into the anteroom outside Bábá’s personal quarters and is arranged in line to see him. We all sit down and meditate. Lined up in order there are some Indian márgiis; an American márgii, Guhán; Gañesh; myself; sisters Púrña Premá, Jivánii and Áshrava. One by one, in this order, people from the line are called in to see Bábá. Eventually, from my meditative state, I hear ‘Jiñáneshvar’ called out. I open my

eyes and rise from a deep meditation. Dádá Rámánanda is standing at Bábá's doorway motioning me to come forward promptly. Dádá holds aside a curtain across the door and I enter a simple room where I see Bábá opposite me, sitting cross-legged on a low white cloth-draped couch. I effortlessly glide myself across a soft white carpet, prostrating fully before Him in *saśtaunga prañám* a salutation done at times like this to the Márga Guru and representing surrender to the Supreme.

Bábá directs me to rise from *saśtaunga prañám* and sit before Him. In a deep and melodious voice He enquires of me, "What is your name?"

"Jiṇáneshvar"

"That is a good name, isn't it?"

"Yes Bábá", I reply, acknowledging that He is again clearly affirming the appropriateness of the spiritual name my initiating Ácárya had given me. I like this name with its meaning made up of *jiṇána* (knowledge/wisdom) and *iishvara* (controller/supreme) indicating both 'controller of the intellectual propensities' and 'supreme wisdom'. This is an appropriate ideal for me to aspire to and ideate upon. Unfortunately, the pronunciation and spelling have been an irritation for me as other people always misinterpret it as 'Ganesh-var' or some variation, a very different name and meaning. I have been considering having my name changed when in India, especially if Bábá were to give it to me, but here He is giving me the answer without me saying anything.

Bábá continues, "And who is your Ácárya?"

"Dádá Dharmavedánanda."

"And where did he initiate you?"

"Perth, Australia, Bábá."

"Yeesss...!", He says exhaling softly and lightly nodding His head. Bábá says this with such emphasis and a knowing look as if He were there at the time. Moreover, Bábá's eyes look into me in such a sweet, consuming way that it leads me to conclude He understands all the events and personal anguish that lead to my sincere spiritual search and eventual initiation. He knows.

“And do you want to be a great person, a great spiritualist?”

“Yes, yes”, I say with a deep yearning of spiritual aspiration. In this simple affirmation I pour all my longing and hope for spiritual advancement, like a deep aching in my heart to be a better person.

“Then you must not delay for a moment. A minute wasted is a minute lost. The time is so short. Do not waste a moment. All your past mistakes, whether conscious or unconscious, forget them and as of this moment start anew”, Bábá instructs me.

Upon arriving in India I have grappled with the notion of how I could come before my Guru, who represents the ideal of all that I held spiritually sacred, when I was obviously still so filled with human weaknesses and failings, even of very recent. But, with this blessed injunction from Bábá, I feel the weight of all these failings, the guilt of my Roman Catholic upbringing, my human weaknesses giving way to a future of hope and the brightness of a new day dawning for me where I need not fear my failures, but rather concentrate on starting anew from this moment and at every moment. There is no time to waste on recriminating myself about any failure, lack of discipline or mistake. I am to take this moment, now and every new moment, to start anew, learning from my mistakes, but not worrying over them or using them as an excuse for not applying myself towards a life of greatness. I say this with a humbleness of not wanting to be great from an egotistical standpoint, but in a way that allows me to contribute to society and to my own spiritual progress with one hundred per cent of my potential.

Bábá leans forward, bids me to meditate and touches the top of my head firmly with His fingertips. He blesses me as He recites a long Sanskrit verse in a deep monotone that melodiously goes on and on. With my eyes closed, the Sanskrit seems to ring around and around the room. I do not understand its meaning, but His voice projects deeply into my inner world and seems to resonate into my psyche. This goes on for what seems a long time, until He finishes, punctuating with the statement, “Become an asset to the humanity”. From this moment on, this statement becomes one of the measuring sticks in my life, a guide to all my actions. Am I an asset to humanity, or a burden, or even just a

waste of space? This is my motivation. My measure of greatness in my life is: am I an asset to humanity?

Bábá sits back on His daybed. Clearly my Personal Contact session is finished. I rise, namaskár Bábá, and leave His room, to again sit in my place in the anteroom. Another person is not immediately called in to see Bábá. Ácárya Rámánanda goes into Bábá's room, pokes his head out for a look around, re-enters, and finally emerges to announce that since it is quite late, Personal Contact with Bábá tonight will end now. The last three people are unable to meet with Bábá personally at this time, including Áshrava, to her disappointment.

Thursday 28/2

Next morning, Áshrava and I are late again to Bábá's house to see Him as He goes off for field walk. We meet Gañesh there and he tells us how, when Bábá came down, noticing our absence, He asked the márgiis present, "Wasn't there one more for P.C.?" Gañesh coming to our defence offered Bábá the excuse that we must have got lost on the way, as we were coming this morning. Upon hearing this from Gañesh, Áshrava and I note Bábá's personal attention as a way of motivating us, but no matter how hard we try over the coming days, we always seem to be late for one reason or another.

Áshrava had not slept well the previous night as her asthma is becoming worse. Her room at Didi's residence is in the centre of the apartment, windowless and has very poor airflow. The stuffiness of the room is irritating her lungs, causing her to cough and wheeze all night, and not able to sleep. This asthma is exhausting her and Áshrava will have to rest a little today.

Come evening, Áshrava and I make a concerted effort to be at Bábá's residence early and we succeed with plenty of time to spare. As our rickshaw pulls up at the gates, Bábá's car is being driven out of the garage and onto the driveway area in preparation for His field walk for the night. I wander over to inspect the car's sleek grey body with abundant chrome trims and massive front chrome grill and bumper,

common with '50s American cars. It is a Dodge Desota sedan. Inside there is a red and green trim and green curtains fitted to the backseat side and rear windows for privacy. Where Báábá sits in the rear, the seat is covered with an orange and white satin cloth and the backrest with a dark blue cloth emblazoned with the silver *pratika* symbol of Ananda Marga. On the front of the engine bonnet, above a chrome Desota plane emblem is a flag spike flying the saffron flag of Ananda Marga. Báábá's driver, Dilip, keeps the Dodge in immaculate condition, polished to a gleam with sparkling chrome trims.

Parimal, the VSS guard, is moving his Enfield motorbike out of the way of the car and I take the opportunity to ask him a question. "Parimal! I have heard that Báábá has a particular like for this car. Can you tell me anything about it?" I enquire.

"Yes. Báábá has had this Dodge Desota for a very long time. During the Emergency time when Báábá was arrested for several years, this car was garaged. One time there was a huge flood and the car was under water for a few days, maybe a week. Afterwards it was filled with mud and just sat like this in the garage. Because of the State of Emergency, there were no márgiis to take care of such things. When Báábá was acquitted and released, the Dádás suggested to Báábá that He should have a new car, but He insisted that He only wanted the old Desota. Báábá said He did not need a fancy new car, and to just clean up the old one. This turned out to be a big job as the engine was filled with dirt and water and the whole inside and outside of the car had to be cleaned and redone. But Báábá insisted and the work was done."

"It certainly looks very good now," I note. Báábá's driver, Dilip, is sitting on a chair near the gates waiting for Báábá. "Parimal, can you introduce me to the driver?"

"Certainly."

We stroll over and after introductions; I asked Dilip, "How did you get to be Báábá's driver?"

In bright and chirpy broken English he narrates to me:

In 1968 one Dádá came to me in Ranchi and as I was in VSS, he said you go to Bábá's quarters, where you will be Bábá's general security. For three months I was security for Bábá and sometimes as His bodyguard. Then I was requested to be His driver. On my first day as driver for Bábá, I drove Him from Ranchi to Murabadhi. I drove the car to the Military ground there in Murabadhi where Bábá got out of the car and went walking for a while. After this He sat and drank water. Then Bábá requested to be taken back to His quarters in Ranchi. His quarters there were not a full house it was an open area. While going there, one big dog came at the car out of nowhere. It was barking very loudly and attacked Bábá's car. As it did, I had a small accident hitting this vicious dog. I put on the brake and stopped the car. Bábá said, "Go, go, go. No problem." The dog howled loudly when I hit it. My feeling was that it must be dead, but Bábá just said, "Go. Don't stop the car, go, go."

This is the first time I am driving Bábá's car and I have an accident, a very heavy hit. I followed Bábá's instruction and continued to drive Him to His quarters. I was concerned about this accident, so, early the next morning, I went back to that place. I looked all around the area. There was no dog. No dead body. I have taken this road many times before and since and never saw this dog at any time. Where did it come from? This was my *saṁskāra*. For a long time now I have been driving for Bábá and have not had any accident, only this one time. Bábá did not say anything about this.

Even after all this time, Dilip still seems perplexed by these circumstances and Bábá's response. I ask Dilip, "Can you tell me more about what it is like driving for Bábá and any stories you may have?" He continues:

I was Bábá's driver from 1968 onwards. I drove Him everywhere, Ranchi, Patna, Calcutta, all places, including Bábá's All India Tours. Bábá always likes the cold weather. In Ranchi it is very cold in January. Everyone is in a sweater and wrapped in

blankets, but Bábá is only in the shirt. I would see Bábá looking at the sky and saying, it is very hot now. Within 15 minutes, the weather would change and become much cooler. I saw this practically many times, Bábá would say and the weather would change to cooler.

When we were driving, Bábá would sit in the car and give directions, very specific, go here, go there, every street He would give. He would guide me, the driver, and each day, even to the same place, would not be the same route.

I would drive Bábá out and about every day that He requested. Previously when He was staying in Ranchi or Patna, He would go out three times per day. Two times was for general darshan, to márgiis and for office work. Next, nighttime, Bábá went on field walk. This would be three times: morning, evening and night.

In Calcutta, Bábá will only go out two times, morning and night. At the night it will be for field walk. If it is for a short time, Bábá will go to the Lake Gardens to walk, but if there is more time, He will direct me to go to many places around Calcutta. The traffic is not very busy so we will travel a long time, even outside Calcutta. On field walk Bábá is a very fast walker. He is very strong. Any weak márgiis cannot come on field walk because of this. I have seen márgiis running next to Bábá as He walks very fast.

I have also noticed that sometimes when I am driving Bábá and He is sitting in the back by Himself, He is talking and talking, about history and many things. This town we will do this and then that. He gives directions on many things. This road, this plan, this village. Talking, talking. He will be very animated and gesturing. I don't know about what, because He is not talking to me.

One day Bábá told me, many people go in my car, but you do not see them. He said they are luminous bodies. This would also happen on field walk, where Bábá would be talking, but we cannot see anyone. Bábá explained that many people go with

me, but you people will not see. If a márgii says anything at this time, Bábá tells them to be quiet.

Dilip pauses here, pondering his time with Bábá and these mysterious events. In relation to this subject, Bábá has written:

Are ghosts always hallucinations? What is a hallucination? In the case of hallucination, there is no defect in the optics, the defect is in the ocularity, that is, the ocular vision is influenced by different thought waves. This hallucination may be of two types, positive or negative. In positive hallucination there is no physical defect in the ocular vision, but rather one's vision is affected by the thought waves, which want to see something different from what is there. And what is negative hallucination? Here also there is no physical defect in the ocular vision, but due to excessive pressure of thought waves – we say ‘auto-suggestion’ – the ocular vision becomes negative: the thought waves do not want to see something which is actually present in the ocular vision.

Many scholars are of the opinion that so-called ghosts are positive hallucinations, and sometimes people are misguided by negative hallucinations. They say that in this case the ocular vision – the optic nerves – are deceiving them, but actually the main role here is played by the thought waves, not by any physical organ, or psychic cells, or psycho-physical cells (ectoplasm).

It is said, “*Abhibhavanat pretadsrshanam*”. Abhibhavanat means cellular suggestion, that which affects not only the mind, but the nerve cells also, so that due to the defective functioning of the nerve fibres one sees something, which is not present, or does not see something which is actually physically present. This cellular suggestion is also of two types, auto-suggestion and outer-suggestion. Auto-suggestion takes place within the jurisdiction of one's own mind, in the individual mind; whereas outer-suggestion is the transmission of suggestion from another mind, from a stronger mind. When a weaker mind is greatly

influenced by a stronger mind, as a result, something is not seen, or something is seen.

But when people see so-called ghosts and apparitions, are they positive or negative hallucinations? No, they are not. Whatever we observe in this physical world is made of the five fundamental factors (solid, liquid, luminous, aerial, and ethereal), and is created in such a way that it automatically functions. It's inherent capacity for action is derived from the physical world under the inspiration of the Supreme Consciousness.

There may be some entities that do not require food and drink. Any entity composed of solid and liquid factors will certainly require food and drink, because food is mainly composed of the solid factor, and drink is mainly composed of the liquid factor. But, if any entity is composed of the three factors – luminous, aerial and ethereal – without any solid or liquid, then that entity is called a 'luminous body'.

The mind operates the physical body by means of nerve cells: by creating vibrations such as smell, form, touch, taste, etc., the nerve cells either receive *tanmátrás* (inferences) [microscopic particles emanated by an object] or project them externally. But, luminous bodies have no nerves, because, nerve cells and fibres are all physical; thus they cannot function properly. Only, as in autosuggestion, they may create a vibration within, and experience some type of feeling.

These luminous bodies are not ghosts or apparitions; they have nothing to do with them. Neither are they related to autosuggestion or outer-suggestion.

If, under certain circumstances, someone happens to see this kind of luminous body, one may think one is seeing a ghost. But actually, there is no ghost at all, it is a luminous body. It is not possible to see luminous bodies in broad daylight; it may be possible during the darkness of night, but even then not everywhere.

It is said that there are seven kinds of luminous bodies: *yakṣa*, *siddha*, *vidyadhara*, *gandharva*, *kinnara*, *prakṛtiliṇa* and *videhaliṇa*. They are categorized according to their respective psychologies.

Suppose there is an elevated person who often ideates on the Supreme Consciousness, but who has some greed for wealth. He does not, however, express it openly to the Supreme, nor does he even think of it directly. He thinks indirectly, “Oh, since I am a devotee of the Supreme, He will certainly give me enormous wealth and make me immensely rich”. Those who harbour this sort of covert desire are reborn as *yakṣa*. Thus sometimes we refer to ‘the wealth of the *yakṣa*’s.

About *siddhas*, I will explain a bit later.

The third kind is *vidyadhara*. Those who have vanity of knowledge although they do not expressly beseech this from the Supreme, but rather think inwardly that the Supreme should bestow an enormous wealth of knowledge upon them – these types of people are reborn as *vidyadhara*. *Vidyadhara* are also luminous bodies.

The next is *gandharva*. Those who have a great talent for higher music and mentally think, “Oh Parama Puruṣa, I want knowledge of the science of music, not You”, (people should cultivate music to the maximum, but to give pleasure to Supreme Consciousness), are reborn as *gandharvas*. In Saṁskṛta [Sanskrit] the science of music is called ‘*gandharva vidyā*’. They are not visible in daylight either, just as other luminous bodies are invisible.

Next is *kinnara*. Those who are vain about their physical beauty, or those who pray to the Supreme to give them more and more physical charm, are reborn as *kinnaras*. They are also luminous bodies.

Then *siddhas*. Those human beings who are doing *sādhana*, who have great love for Parama Puruṣa, but in their hearts are proud

of their occult powers or pray to Parama Puruṣa to grant them still more occult powers – these people, after death, are reborn as siddhas. Of all the categories of luminous bodies, the siddhas are the most elevated. They often help sādhakas in their sādhanā.

All these luminous bodies are collectively called ‘*devayonis*’. Besides the above, there are *videhaliina* and *prakṛtiliina*. Those who worship Parama Puruṣa in the form of clay, iron or other material substances, are ultimately transformed into *prakṛtiliinas*. And *videhaliinas* are those who run after occult powers and think, “I will attain such great power that with it I will move from place to place.” These are all luminous bodies; they are not ghosts, nor are they positive or negative hallucinations.

Thus, ghosts are not positive hallucinations or negative hallucinations, or siddhas or *devayonis*. Then is there any such thing as ghosts? Yes, there is something similar.

After death, when the mind dissociates from the body, the accumulation of unfulfilled *saṁskāras* remains, although the body with the five fundamental factors is no longer existing.

Thus the mind cannot function, but it remains in potential form. Now if, under certain circumstances, the ectoplasm of a living person is associated with that disembodied mind, then that disembodied mind gets a mental body temporarily, for a short time. Then that mental body can start functioning with the help of the nerve cells and nerve fibres of that living person, but only for about two to four minutes. What is this called? Neither is it positive hallucination or negative hallucination, nor is it a luminous body (*devayoni*). Then what is it?

A living person’s ectoplasmic cells become the mental body of a dead person for a few minutes until, after two to four minutes, that mental body again dies. This mental body I will call ‘*presita manas*’ – ‘recreated mind’. Some people may do good works, or get good works done, with the help of these *presita manas*, but only those people who have perfect control over their minds and

over the nerve cells and nerve fibres of their bodies. Those who are bad people can do evil with the help of the presita manas. They can hurl stones into others' houses, throw bones, or overturn tables and cots. All these things can be done for two to four minutes.

So we see that what we call a 'ghost' is not always a positive or negative hallucination, nor is it always a siddha or a presita manas. In fact, we cannot prove the existence of presita manas or siddha, and in so far as positive hallucination is concerned, it does not have any actual existence at all. If you have a positive hallucination, it is a mental disease.

If anything of this sort (presita manas or luminous bodies) appears before you there is only one remedy to remove it: that is, do kiirtana. Do kiirtana for one minute or repeat your Guru Mantra, and that 'ghost' will instantly vanish into thin air. So under no circumstances should you be afraid.”⁷

“Dilip, please continue. I am interested to hear more about Bábá,” I encourage. He adjusts his driver's peak cap and goes on:

Oh, yes. I would see many, many things with Bábá on these drives and field walks. One time, a devotee márgii, a Government Officer, was to see Bábá in Darshan. At that time there was an organisational rule that any márgii or worker had to have permission to come to Darshan. This particular márgii was to have come in the evening for Darshan, but because of work in the Government service he was unable to come. He was so busy that he had no time. He could not come although he wanted to very much. In the morning, I was to drive Bábá to Patna, a distance of four hundred kilometers. Bábá delayed His leaving. I had all His things ready, even His cold water in the car. Nine o'clock, nine-thirty, still Bábá is having bath, not according to His routine. Everybody is ready. Then finally Bábá is ready and He says to me, go to Patna on the Patna road. We go six or seven kilometers and that devotee, the Government officer, he came, even without permission. He sees Bábá in the car. Bábá says stop the car and gets out. He tells Bábá, I was unable to

come last night, when I had the permission, due to work. Bábá says, ok, ok. He sits with this márgii for a short while and talks. I gave Bábá water and some portion I gave to this márgii. Then the devotee leaves. When Bábá gets back into the car He says, today we are late because this márgii was coming. In the nighttime he is sleeping because of working late and then he comes without permission, but I will still see him. So Bábá has lost one hour of His time and gone against His system of permission to see this márgii, this devotee. He was aware that he was coming to see Him. Because this márgii has devotion to God, he gets to see Bábá.

So many stories of Bábá I have. One time Bábá showed me where He stayed during His time in the military and told stories of that time. One such story was during the Muslim-Hindu riots of Jamulpur, Bábá won stick lathi fighting. Two hundred people against Bábá and He won. There are many stories and nobody has written this Bábá's history.

Nodding his head and gazing nostalgically, Dilip came to the end of his recollections. Bábá would soon be coming for field walk and he needed to be alert and ready to go at a moment's notice.

Some of those present at the mini DMC and PC, Púrúa Premá, Gañesh, Áshrava and I, gather on the other side of the Desota singing kiirtana as Bábá leaves for field walk. From now, Púrúa Premá, Áshrava and I, and arriving a little later Shivaprabhá, form the foundation of kiirtana for Bábá every morning and evening. Other márgiis, who come to visit Bábá, bolster our numbers with much appreciated voices and tunes. Bábá is very self-contained this evening, but as He walks past to the car, He shows His appreciation of our kiirtana with an exceptionally blissful smile of approval. I am happy with the opportunity to express my spiritual longings through kiirtana in a heartfelt and joyfully abandoned way. Bábá's smile is enough.



What's in a Word?

Friday 29/2

In the morning, as we finish kiirtana in front of Bábá before He leaves for field walk, He asks us, “Are you singing kiirtana or doing kiirtana?” No one comes up with an answer and Bábá explains, “You are ‘doing kiirtana’ because ‘kiirtana’ implies ‘singing’ and so you would not say, that you were ‘singing singing’. Likewise, when you write a letter, some say ‘herewith enclosed is’, which is incorrect and should be ‘herewith the letter is’ or ‘enclosed is’.”^E

Such is our grammar lesson for the day. Other than a general curiosity at what Bábá says, I wonder why He says what He does, particularly when it comes to so much grammar and pronunciation, but in this instance, I must wait a long time to find the answer.ⁱ

When Bábá leaves, I go to Dádá Akśáyánanda and ask him if there is any drinking water available. He mentions that the water from the back pump is safe to drink. I am unpersuaded until he assures me that Bábá has had the water tested in a laboratory and it was determined that it is safe potable water. This is enough for me. Áshrava and I go out to one of the corner shops with an array of brightly coloured plastic items and find two water bottles that we can now use to fill up from the pump and this water tastes suprisingly fresh and sweet.

Come evening, it's raining. Determined not to be late, Áshrava and I catch a taxi, but the driver gets lost. Again we are late and miss Bábá

ⁱ Over twenty years later, on re-reading these diary notes, I realise that on the previous diary day (Thursday 28.2.80), I had incorrectly written that we were ‘singing’ kiirtana. This is the first and only time in my diary writings that I have used this incorrect grammar and the very next morning Bábá corrects me, even when I am not aware of it myself until revising it years later. If He knows the specifics of grammar in my personal diary, what else does Bábá know?

leaving. Púrña Premá is the only márgii here. As the three of us huddle out of the rain under the eve of the meditation room doorway, Púrña Premá tells us, “Bábá was asking about you. He was very surprised you weren’t here and asked me, ‘No others have come?’”

In the meditation room we do our sádhaná and await His return, by which time the rain has eased. When Bábá gets out of the car He addresses Áshrava and me, “Was I early or were you late? Was it the weather?”

“No, no, Bábá. We were late coming here.”

“Ah, yes, yes. I just thought I might have been early.” Nothing is ever revealed about these comments of Bábá’s, but I speculate that there is something other than that idle chitchat from Him about our lateness.

I take the attitude that Bábá is encouraging us to be aware of time, to be timely, to push past being lax with time and maybe if we do not, without His prompting, we might miss something important. I am aware that part of the role and method of a Guru is to allude to things that you, the disciple, need to pay attention to. The choice is mine; the Guru cannot do it for me. He can point the way and I can move in the direction He indicates, thereby sidestepping some obstacle unobserved by me. Clearly in my Personal Contact meeting with Bábá, He emphasized time for me: “... you must not delay for a moment. A minute wasted is a minute lost. The time is so short. Do not waste a moment.” Time is becoming a re-occurring theme here.

A short while after Bábá has gone upstairs, a VSS guard comes down bearing a message. “Bábá says you are to come up for Darshan”, the guard conveys. Áshrava, Púrña Premá and I, the only ones here tonight due to the inclement weather, race up the stairs flashing each other unabashed grins which we suppress as we enter the alcove of the previous night to be seated at His feet. Bábá, smiling, sits on the daybed and asks us to do kiirtana. We are all in a bit of a blur from our jubilant dash upstairs and mumble between ourselves, “Which kiirtana tune should we do?” Áshrava, always the accomplished singer/songwriter, begins singing a tune, to which Púrña Premá and I join in. Bábá closes

His eyes and listens as we sing on...Bábá náma kevalam...(Bábá is everything)...Bábá náma kevalam...(love is everything)...Bábá náma kevalam...(Consciousness is everything)....

The meanings swirl with the chanted, vibrating mantra. Looking at Bábá as we sing – He becomes the embodiment of this mantra. Who is Bábá? What is Bábá? These thoughts flit through my mind as I try to grasp Bábá náma kevalam embodied before me. Bábá sits there serene, radiating bliss. Waves of love wash over me. I try to concentrate on the sweetness of the tune while I gaze at Bábá, the emotional love and longing for God welling up in me as I pour my heart out in song. I fall into a sense of whirling in the kiirtana. Feeling enveloped in it, as if the entire universe was vibrating Bábá náma kevalam and all was swirling before me.

We sing for some time until Bábá motions us to finish and then He opens the conversation,

“Where do you go for collective kiirtana? Where is your nearest jágrti?”

Áshrava replies, “Not far from where we live, in the same street.”

Púrńa Premá, unsure of the question, inquires, “Do you mean here in Calcutta, Bábá?”

“No, where you come from,” Bábá responds.

“Oh”, comprehends Púrńa Premá, “Copenhagen WWD Office.”

“Do you have a jágrti in every place?” Bábá asks.

“Not everywhere”, I reply.

“Do you own them?”

“No! They are rented, Bábá.”

“We should own all of our jágrtis. Every one should be owned. Do you know the Global Jágrti being built here in Calcutta? You should get the details of the plans from Dádá Girijánanda, the Construction Secretary, and build likewise. Jágrti can be used for many purposes: cheap kitchen; school in the daytime; sádhaná at night.”

Púrña Premá comments, “We have a cheap kitchen starting in the jágrti in Copenhagen”.

“Very Good.”

Púrña Premá further adds, “To feed the poor”.

“Not just the poor,” Bábá elucidates, “but everyone. In underdeveloped countries, developing countries and even developed countries, we should have cheap kitchens. And even in the future when we don’t have any food, we will still have cheap kitchens. You understand the sentiment? Cheap kitchens?” Bábá then explains in an example, “Book banks that have cheap books for students. Whether in developed countries like America or in undeveloped countries like Latin America, wherever you are, you should start these programmes. Australia is a developed country, but the Maoris of Australia need much help [Bábá is here referring to the Aboriginal people of Australia]. The countries of Latin America, Mexico; Guatemala; Honduras; Panama and Colombia are all underdeveloped, except Venezuela and this is because of its oil. Scandinavian countries are developed countries. Is Denmark Scandinavian?”

Púrña Premá loudly and emphatically replies, “YES, Bábá!”

To which Bábá jovially adds, “This little girl, when she is saying yes, it is certainly yes!”

As Bábá finishes, we all do *pranáma* at His feet and He blesses us with hands outstretched over us, saying, “May you be successful in all the stratum of life – physical, mental and spiritual. Be great by your sádhana, your service, and your sacrifice.”



Festival of Colours

Saturday 1/3

Today it is *púrñimá*, full moon. Being first full moon of the month of March, it is the holy day of Vasantotsava in India, celebrated as the Festival of Colours or Holi. We arrive extra early in a taxi to Bábá's house. This is not only to arrive on time for once, but mainly to try and avoid the common Holi practice of bombarding people with coloured powder and water during this celebration of colours. Unfortunately, Holi has lost some of its spiritual meaning and become a free-for-all amongst the rowdy youth of India in some cities, including Calcutta. We have been warned by an Ácárya, "Don't go out in any good clothes. You will be pelted from the rooftops and the corners, not only with water and coloured powder, but nowadays, even with paint. Don't even take a rickshaw. Make sure you take a taxi and leave early."

We arrive unscathed and stand with a few others in line to greet Bábá. When He approaches, He stops for Didi Ánandabratatii to garland Him. She has purchased particular flowers to her liking from the local market to make an unusually colourful garland. Bábá asks her about these flowers and then comments explaining the origins of the names and their Latin derivation on two that it contains, the China Rose (Hibiscus) and the Chinese Rose (Camellia). Before getting into the car, Bábá turns, looks up over our heads, and calls out *namaste*. I look behind me to see a small boy of four or five leaning over his balcony in the house next door. Bábá has greeted him and the boy shouts out the return *namaste* to Bábá. This seems to be a regular greeting between them.

For Vasantotsava, Bábá will hold Darshan in the meditation room in His residence. Áshrava and I take our positions seated on carpets

especially laid out for the day along with only fifteen other márgiis who have arrived. The meditation room is decorated with flowers. Threaded strings of small, bright-orange marigold flowers line the walls and windows. Tuberose and red rose flowers decorate the altar and Baba's couch is placed near this for Him to sit on. I enjoy this room, with its combinations of white and bright orange themes.

While we are doing kiirtana, Bábá comes into the room and sits on the couch in meditation. The Ácárya leading the kiirtana on his harmonium slows the tune to bring it to an end. Bábá opens His eyes and adjusts His glasses. He surveys the audience and then begins His Darshan, speaking in Bengali, but interspersing this with short English phrases and explanations.

Dolyátrá festivalⁱⁱ

Today being Vasantotsava, Bábá explains, began as a festival of the Aryan people of the cold Central Asia area, where they would jubilantly welcome in the coming spring. Gripping His arms around His body, shaking and shivering, Bábá dramatically expresses the bitter cold of winter the Aryan experienced saying, "For old people life is like one long winter. The Aryan would celebrate the passing of winter by burning an image of an old woman seated on a sheep, a ram. Did you not see the fires on the street corners last night?" Áshrava and I nod, as do several others. We had indeed seen a number of bonfires on different street corners while travelling home the previous evening. People were gathered around the fires, stoking them up and having a celebratory time. Áshrava and I remarked to each other about these gatherings and wondered what they were for. Now we find out.

ii All the formal, public Darshans in this book are a paraphrasing of the original Darshan. Those Darshans in the proceeding Yajña series have not yet been translated from the Bengali at the time of printing this book. What is contained here is only for the purposes of giving the reader a sense of Bábá's presentation and the subjects He spoke about during this time. This writing is my own translation and rendering of part of what Bábá said. Only what is in quotation marks is to be considered either what I directly heard Bábá say or is quoted from His book where the Darshan is reproduced in English. I have tried my best to be accurate to the original in essence. I urge the interested reader to refer to the primary source of the Darshan in Bábá's books for a full account of what He said.

Bábá continues, saying another facet of current day Holi celebrations stem from a story in Indo-Aryan mythology where a king's sister, Holiká, was a feared cannibal. One night, before the full moon, the people rose up out of anger and burnt her alive. The next day, in celebration, they held a festival of joy, which was called *Holikádahana* (the burning of Holiká), later shortened to Holi. These two events are the origin of the festival of Holi celebrated over most of India today, particularly the north.

In Bengal the history behind the festival is different. The people of Bengal knew of, but did not celebrate the Holi spring festival because they did not have the very cold weather of the north of India and consequently did not have a noticeable beginning of spring. Bábá continues, "About 500 years ago Mahaprabhu Shrii Caetanya went to visit Vrindávana, where he observed the Holi festival. After his return to Bengal, Mahaprabhu pondered deeply and decided to introduce the festival but, of course, in a different form. He said to his followers, "Go to the Krśña temple on that day, and apply red powder and red colour to Krśña. Then you should play with the red-powder and colour amongst yourselves." The festival in Bengal is more accurately called the Dolyátrá of Shrii Krśña, a religious festival, rather than Holi, a social festival. Bábá states, "In our Ananda Marga Caryácárya, this festival is celebrated as a spring festival."

This applying of coloured powder in the Dolyátrá festival is a practice of bhakti [devotion]. The intellect cannot know the secrets of the Supreme, but through devotion and love of the Supreme, the devotee will be able to know every secret and have every question answered as you move towards and eventually attain Parama Puruśa. It is the ideation in the practice that is important. Bábá goes on to explain some of the philosophy behind Tantra, particularly the Vaeśnviya Tantra cult that has expression in the Dolyátrá festival, "The inner idea of the Vaeśnaviyya Tantra is that there is form and colour (both rāga

and varña) in the rhythmic expressions of Parama Puruṣa [Supreme Consciousness], and those cosmic rhythms also have a sweet sonic vibration. This sonic vibration is instrumental in giving expression to various other forms in this universe as well. The resonance of the collective vibrations of the universe is called the flute sound of Kṛṣṇa, another name for oṃkāra, and the cosmic sound (Aum), which reaches the ears of spiritual aspirants in various ways. When human beings attain spiritual progress step by step, they will also hear this sound with their own ears.”

Bábá explains that the highest stage of devotion, stemming from this philosophical approach of Vaeśṇvīya Tantra, is a kind of rágásádhana as can be expressed by the devotee in the words, “I will do exactly as He wants, I will colour my mind with His colour, and I will not think whether that will bring joy to me or not. Let Him be pleased ... that is my only wish.”

Concluding, Bábá says, “When Mahaprabhu first introduced the Dolyátrá festival, the psychology behind this festival was to give one’s mental colour to Parama Puruṣa. The inner idea was, “Let my mind vibrate in the same way as Kṛṣṇa’s mind is vibrating” ... The inner significance of Dolyátrá is, in the swinging vibration in which the entire universe is vibrating, I will also be vibrated.”⁸

Having finished His Darshan, Bábá consecrates the expression of Vasantotsava as part of our spiritual devotion in Ananda Marga by allowing each devotee to sprinkle coloured powders onto His feet. He sits on the edge of the couch with His feet on the floor. I join the line of márgiis proceeding towards Him. From a small bowl, I put some coloured powder into my hand. As I move slowly forward in the line, I reflect on this special *guru pújá* and what Bábá had just said in His Darshan.

The essence of this practice is in the ideation that the mind has many colours according to your mental tendencies and your particular train of thoughts. These colours are being offered to the Divine, surrendering the small self to the Cosmic Self. The cupped hands are imagined to

hold the colours of your mind or previous thoughts and actions, good and bad, as in the colour that comes to your attention. This can be imagined as a coloured lotus flower. If no colour appears to you, then you can imagine white. The ideation is to represent your current mental colour, especially if it is not positive, as a beautiful lotus flower to be offered to the Guru. This is the challenge of the spiritual practice and may take some time to ideate. The thought is that everything is the property of the Supreme, even your mistakes and impure thoughts.

I remembered what had been said to me about the practice of guru pújá, done at the end of meditation, as an overview of the spiritual path. There are two types of *saṁskāras* (potential mental reaction, commonly referred to as karma) - *pratyamulaka* and unborn *saṁskāras*. Unborn *saṁskāra* is carried over from previous lives and is difficult to remove. During *dikṣā*, initiation into spiritual practice, it is said that the Guru takes the responsibility of your unborn *saṁskāras*, but may use you to work off some part of them. *Pratyamulaka* *saṁskāras* are accumulated in this life as you live and act. The use of a *Gurumantra* (a mantra given to a spiritual aspirant in the second lesson of Ananda Marga) to ascribe *Brahma-hood* (treating all entities with which one comes in contact as different expressions of *Brahma*, God or Supreme Consciousness, and not as their apparent crude forms) to every action is said to remove half of the momentum of *pratyamulaka* *saṁskāras*. Even though, there is still a root idea (*saṁskāra*) of the interaction with the crude object embedded in the mind. In Ananda Marga, the offering of colours is a spiritual practice of giving the colour of your mind to the Supreme and this accomplishes the uprooting of the remaining part of *pratyamulaka* *saṁskāra*.

In Bengali the dry powdered colours used as an offering are called *Abiira*. Caetanya Mahaprabhu encouraged everyone to go to the Kṛṣṇa temple and put colours on the feet of the Kṛṣṇa statue as an offering. Only a small part of the powder is offered to Kṛṣṇa in this way. The remainder, after being touched at his feet, is brought back home as sanctified *Abiira*, considered *prasād*, a holy substance. It is respectfully placed on the faces of family members, friends and neighbours.

Another deep devotional aspect of Vasantotsava that Caetanya Mahaprabhu wove into the festival was the concept of Dolayátrá (*dola* means ‘swinging’ and *yatra* is ‘the occasion of’). With this concept, Caetanya Mahaprabhu referred to the time in Vrindavana when Kṛṣṇa and Rádhá would sit on a large swing and the Gopis would swing them to and fro in divine bliss at the sight of them. The swinging is symbolic of everything in the universe being vibrational. The entire creation is like an enormous ocean of vibrations. This is like waves rising and falling, rippling through the universe. Every being is dancing in this movement of waves, like swinging. This is also represented as Kṛṣṇa in the centre of the universe playing his flute, his music creating waves that ripple throughout the universe. Every devotee is dancing in the rhythm and tune of the flow of Kṛṣṇa’s flute. Caetanya Mahaprabhu was a follower of the higher stage of Bhakti and so he emphasized this deep devotion as part of Vasantotsava. In Vasantotsava, you want to make the individual mind swing in rhythm with the divine rhythm.

Slowly, as the line progresses, I draw closer to Bábá. Each márgii offers his or her colours at Bábá’s feet and then moves on. Jivánii, who is in front of me in the line, stops before Bábá. She becomes absorbed in her devotion and just stands staring at Bábá’s feet for some time, oblivious to the process at hand. Is she in the devotion of Dola-Yatra, her individual mind swinging in rhythm with the Divine Rhythm. Finally she comes to awareness of the process, completes the action and moves on. I approach with all the reverence I can muster, shaping my life’s desires into this small handful of coloured powder and offering it to the Almighty in this simple gesture onto Bábá’s feet. I visualise my hopes, dreams, ambitions, pains, service, and all that I may intuit. The power of this spiritual practice flows through me as the powder tumbles from my hands and dusts across Bábá’s feet. My mind swirls with the significance of what I am offering.

I go back to my place and meditate. Soon the final people in line complete their offerings and sit down. Bábá lifts His feet and the rainbow of coloured powders is lightly brushed off by an attendant Ácárya. He rises, namaskárs the group, and quietly leaves. Upon Bábá’s

departure, the solemnity of the first part of the event changes. Now it is time for everyone to join in the further festive practice of Holi, respectfully dousing each other in the colours. The mood is joyous. Eventually, everyone's hair and clothes become motley-coloured, with streaks of vibrant colour. Then we sit down to a meal finished with luscious Bengali sweets.

In the evening, the meditation room fills to capacity with about fifty people for four hours of kiirtana, bhajans and Dharmacakra. At least half of the crowd are Ācāryas and most are Indian, so when Bábá comes in again for Darshan, He speaks only in Bengali. We have sat next to Ācārya Kṛṣṇapriya and he explains to Āshrava and me that Bábá is elaborating on higher social philosophy. I find the essence encapsulated in this extract from His book *Idea and Ideology*:

Thus the social philosophy of Ananda Marga advocates the development of the integrated personality of the individual and also the establishment of a world fraternity by inculcating a cosmic sentiment in human psychology. The Marga advocates progressive utilization of the mundane and supramundane factors of the cosmos. Society needs an impetus for life, vigour and progress and for this Ananda Marga advocates the 'Progressive Utilization Theory' (PROUT), which calls for progressive utilization of all factors of the universe.⁹

Later in the evening, after Bábá has left for His field walk, Āshrava and I, still elevated from the evening's events, are waiting down the road from Bábá's residence for a taxi. As we look down the street, we are surprised to see Bábá's car approaching on His way home. As it passes, we both give Him a reverent namaskár.

Next morning, unbelievably, Āshrava and I are running late again. We are not normally like this in Australia, well not with this frequency. Āshrava and I race off just making it before Bábá leaves for His morning field walk. Entering the gateway, we see Bábá talking with Didi Ānandabratatī. He turns and upon seeing us, gestures happily in our direction while saying something to Didi in Bengali. He then drives off for field walk. Didi comes over to tell us what Bábá had expressed

to her. “Bábá was delighted when He saw you arriving. He said, ‘These people have come.’ He was obviously pleased you were here.” Bábá’s attention makes me determined to be early or at least on time.

In the evening, we make it on good time for Bábá’s evening field walk. Before leaving, Bábá says to us, “I think you all enjoyed yesterday’s Vasantotsava Festival of colours?”

All the márgiis enthusiastically reply, “Yes Bábá.” When He returns Bábá stops to speak with the VSS guard at the stairs door. Now understanding the procedure, Áshrava and I casually meander our way up there also, hoping that we will not be shooed away or be intruding on a private conversation. Bábá is speaking in Bengali, and then says in English for our benefit, “Merge the microcosm in the Macrocosm.” He speaks more in Bengali and then says in English, “There is only one entity – the Macrocosm. You must have extreme love for this Macrocosm. Do you think it is possible to read all the books of the world?”

“No, Bábá” we reply in a chorus of unison.

More Bengali from Bábá and then an English phrase referring to book knowledge, “The mystery of chemistry – easy to learn, easy to forget. All the little microcosms can only know so much, but Macrocosm is omniscient. This word is Latin. And what does it mean?”

I boldly attempt a reply with, “All pervading?”

Bábá continues, “It means ‘all knowing’. So, all the microcosm can do is to have extreme love for this Macrocosm. Through this love for the Macrocosm you too can become omniscient.”^F



In the Full Mood

Monday 3/3

Bábá comes down for His morning field walk and gives us blissful smiles. He is just beaming and radiating love. He is Ánandamúrti, ‘the personification of bliss who attracts all’.

Later in the day, while we are at a shop in the city, Áshrava and I meet two European women who have been travelling in India for six months and are on their last day. One of the women was initiated into Ananda Marga just before she left home, but failed to get any Ananda Marga contacts for India. All during her six-month travel in India, she had been inquiring about Ananda Marga wherever she went without success until she met us today, her last day. We give them the address in Lake Gardens and encourage them to come and see Bábá before leaving India, even if they have only a little time.

In the evening we arrive at Bábá’s house early, direct from the city. Áshrava begins to sing a kiirtana she made up from the tune of a Chilean revolutionary song that we found very inspiring. We had used this Chilean song in Australia as the basis for a theatrical production about the Pinochet dictatorship in Chile and the heroic people who opposed it. Áshrava and I sing for a long time joined by a couple of other people and we are loud and very energised. It is the rousing tempo of this song that initially inspired us so much and Áshrava and I give it our all and sing on for some time with the same kiirtana tune.

Coming down to the driveway, Bábá stops before us, listening intently to our kiirtana and slightly nodding His head. When we come to a finish He earnestly says to us, “I very much enjoyed your kiirtana tune”. He namaskárs and leaves for field walk. A Didi who

had accompanied Bábá from upstairs, Ácárya Ánandakaruná, comes over to us. “Bábá liked your kiirtana tune very much”, says Didi. “He commented to me when we were descending the stairs, ‘There are only four or five of them down there doing kiirtana and yet it sounds as though there are many. It is because they are in the full mood.’ Bábá enjoys kiirtana from His márgiis very much.”

Áshrava and I accompany Didi Ánandakaruná over to the meditation hall veranda steps to sit and talk while awaiting Bábá’s return. Didi explains that she does work around Bábá’s residence helping with cooking food for Bábá and also with the many plants. “Do you know that Bábá is collecting the plants?” says Didi.

“Yes, we have heard Didi.”

“And have you brought any plants from your Sector?”

“Yes Didi,” Áshrava replies, “We brought Australian orchids.”

“Very good, very good.”

“When did Bábá start collecting the plants Didi?” enquires Áshrava. Didi settles back and narrowing her eyes a little to recall, commences explaining in her rapid fire Bengali-English:

One day Bábá called us and He told us, the West Bengal Government is going to clear the forest. Then Bábá says if there are no plants, people will not get oxygen, fresh air will not be there, water will not come. Many, many problems will come. We will not get food. Without plants, survival in the universe will not be possible. At this time, Bábá begins to collect the different plant species to protect them from becoming extinct across the world. If there are less plants there will be problems with the air, increased pollution and lack of water in India. All of these difficulties would start if the plants were cleared. So immediately we need to save all the species of plants.

This is when Bábá began to collect plants from different communities. Where any márgii went they would bring back the plants and every day we will show Bábá 315 plants and 150

plants in summer as a gift we were giving to Bábá and He will give plans as to how the plant will grow, how it will survive. Bábá knows everything.

“What does Bábá do with all the plants Didi?” interrupts Áshrava.

Even the plants will have a posting, a posting order. This plant will go to Madhu Málaiṇca [Lake Gardens] and that plant to Madhu Karníká [Ánanda Nagar]. Bábá has many gardens. A different plant will be sent to a different garden. Then He will give them to different márgiis in Bihar and elsewhere and also to different countries. Bábá made the system, if one plant dies then two plants are needed to replace it. And another is, if any one does not do their organizational work, then as the atonement they will have to give the plants. So many people are bringing plants to Bábá. They will buy them at a nursery or bring them from whichever country they were posted in to give to Bábá.

One time Bábá told me here in Lake Gardens, that I must send some plants to Ánanda Nagar. At that time Ánanda Nagar had only a few types of trees and was very dry. He said if you plant there, then there will be clouds and rain will come and more plants will grow. So I took from here five bundles of plants, Bábá said the names were Puranika and Ponipoppln, both types of ferns. If we planted all these, then they will create the clouds and rain will come. The next time Bábá told me we must plant Silver Oak, American Ash or Red Wood. They all have the power to attract clouds.

“What work do you do with the plants Didi?” inquires Áshrava.

Like this, one day some plants came from your Sector, Suva Sector, from Australia. A note with them said they were Jasmine with a yellow flower. I said to Bábá, one kind of plant has arrived, it is Jasmine with a yellow colour. Bábá said, ‘Yellow colour, generally Jasmine has the white colour, but if it is yellow it is a rare variety. We must use grafting to give lots of roots and flowers.’ Bábá asked could I do it. I replied, ‘yes Bábá, no problem.’ I did what is called root grafting. He asked how

big they were. I said they were very small like ladies fingers. He asked to look at them and I placed them in His hand.

In root grafting you need to cut the main root. I showed this part to Bábá. Suddenly Bábá cut the whole root. I said, 'Bábá what have you done? The whole root is already cut so how can we grow this plant?' Bábá replied, 'If it is your grace, then the plant will survive.'

'It is not my grace, it is Your grace, Bábá.'

Bábá was a little bit playing with me. 'It is your grace' He said.

'No it is Your grace, Your grace.' Then Bábá put the roots in the water. Later Bábá Himself made a pot of soil and planted the roots to grow. He told me to keep them in one shaded place, in the nursery.

From then Bábá requested that I give Him a report on the plant every ten minutes. Yes every ten minutes Bábá would take the report on how is that plant. After two or three days, Bábá went to Ánanda Nagar. From there, through someone, He told me, give me every two minutes a report on the plants. This was very difficult, from here to Ánanda Nagar. At that time the phone was too far. So I must obey and I brought postcards and would write, the plant is ok, no problem. This is Bábá's order. I sent so many postcards saying, the plants are straight, no bending right or left, no yellow colour has come, the plant is ok.

Then information comes that I must come to Ánanda Nagar and give the report. There I submit it to Bábá that the plants are ok in every detail as He requested. At this meeting Bábá leant over to an ácárya and commented that the plants are ok, and they have survived. Then Bábá gave me order to go back to Calcutta and plant the plants in such and such a place. After I have done this, again I get word to come back to Ánanda Nagar and report on the plants' condition. In this way Bábá looked after the welfare of the plants and also gave me karma yoga.

Another time one brother sent plants. That plant's name is Laghe Kamini. Then we planted it into Bábá's house and every day, four times, Bábá took the report. After two or three days we saw that the plant had one black spot. Lunchtime, Bábá asked me how is the plant and I said, 'Bábá, I saw that on the branch there is one black spot.'

Bábá said, 'After my lunch, I will go and see that plant.' Bábá came down and He looked and noticed one kind of sore on the plant. Then Bábá said, 'Immediately we need to do an operation.' He said bring a knife and He cut the branch and took the black out. Bábá asked for a bandage. He used some sort of plant medicine and wrapped the cut with the bandage and watered the plant. Every day in the morning Bábá would come and see how was the plant, some times after lunch also. This plant survived and grew up very well.

Didi pauses for a breath and I ask, "Didi, does Bábá inspect His garden every day?" She continues, with a wealth of information:

Most days He does and Bábá has also started doing demonstrations of His garden here at Madhu Málaĩṇca, Lake Gardens. One day He informed me that people had been invited and that He would be the guide. Twenty-four people would be attending, Twenty-two márgiis and two non-márgiis. One of the non-márgiis that day was a student from the Jabu Core University. Bábá gave the garden demonstration for three and a half hours. They went from the rooftop down and around the garden. Bábá explained everything about the plants and the meteorological requirements, the soil, every aspect of each plant. During this time, after maybe ten minutes, Bábá asked this boy, this student, 'How are you? Do you understand? Do you follow me?' Bábá continued this throughout the demonstration, always pointing and asking to this young boy. Some people were thinking, oh Bábá is so much loving and caring for people, because He is always noting this young boy and caring for him. Bábá completed the garden demonstration and He went to His room.

After some few minutes He called the General Secretary and said, ‘Can you call that boy to my room?’ G.S. brought him up and explained to him the proper procedure, that he must do prañāma and not to ask Bábá anything unless prompted. He entered Bábá’s room and did prañāma and Bábá asked, ‘How are you my boy? Are you fine?’ Bábá then motioned to GS, now he can go out. Then we were all thinking, why has Bábá called him? He is a non-márgii, why Bábá call him? And just for that, how are you? The whole garden demonstration He is always asking him. Why is He calling him like this now?

Then Bábá spoke to G.S. and we could all hear, ‘You people are thinking why did Bábá call him, and just for that, how are you, are you fine, only for that. Actually do you know what is happening? For three and a half hours he is only thinking: how is Bábá having so much knowledge? Maybe He reads a lot of books. His room must have a library, books are there and He studies lots and for that He has so much knowledge.’ Bábá continued, ‘Why should I keep in his mind one question mark? That time I have shown him, in my room, that I have no books; there is nothing there.’ Now I understood, in this way Bábá has shown him. He has given the young boy a realization of what is Bábá.

Didi Ánandakaruná wound up her stories at this point, saying that she must go upstairs and do some preparations for Bábá’s return which should be some time soon. We say our goodbyes and Áshrava and I wait, sitting on the verandah steps, enjoying the warm evening air.

On returning from field walk, Bábá leaves His car, walks up the alleyway and stops at the stairway to talk with the VSS guard in Bengali. Again the group of márgiis in the driveway approach to listen. At this Bábá changes to English and begins to explain about the Bengali language. Bengali is 92% Sanskrit and the rest is Indigenous, English, Portuguese and Persian.^G He then asks for any Bengali word and He will give its origin. Several Bengali márgiis present their enquiry and He answers. At one point Bábá answers someone and continues with,

“Is that correct? Yes, I am always correct!” As He continues talking in Bengali, Áshrava, who does not understand Bengali, is intently listening and feeling somehow that she does understand the essence of what Bábá is saying. Right at this point, Bábá turns to Áshrava, inclines His head inquiringly and says, “Is that correct?” Áshrava, as if comprehending fully, replies unhesitatingly, “Yes Bábá.”



A Spanish Song

Tuesday 4/3

Next morning the two European women turn up at the time we suggested and wait for Báábá to come down for field walk. We chat with them for a while and do some kiirtana, but Báábá seems to be taking longer than usual. Eventually, the márgii woman's friend becomes quite impatient, as she has no direct interest in seeing Báábá. She is also concerned that they get going as they have a flight to catch. The márgii woman is adamant that she sees Báábá before leaving India. Frustrated, her friend wanders off into the meditation room to look around. No sooner has she left, than Báábá quickly comes down radiating very blissful smiles and namaskárs for all, hops into His car and is driven off. The other woman comes out of the meditation room unaware that Báábá had even passed by. Her initiated friend is thrilled even at this brief meeting with her Guru. Everything is in the timing. The Guru appears when the disciple is ready.

In the evening, we do kiirtana for Báábá as is our usual routine now. While passing, on the way to the car, Báábá respectfully namaskárs all márgiis present. The Desota pulls away, then stops just outside the gates. The gate VSS run up to Báábá's car. There is some small commotion at the car window as Báábá conveys something to the guard. The VSS motions Dádá Akśayánanda to come to the car. He quickly responds and is given some instruction by Báábá. We watch all this from a distance with interest. The car drives away and Dádá walks over to us. He conveys Báábá's request, "Do they know a Spanish song?" We are all a little perplexed as to what Báábá means and wrack our brains for a Spanish song. But no one knows Spanish or a Spanish song. What to do!

Then, Áshrava and I realise, although we had told no one, that Bábá must mean the kiirtana He had liked so much the night before. This is based on the tune of a Chilean song ‘Todos Juntos’, the singers, Los Jaivas, speaking in their native tongue, Chilean, which is Spanish. Áshrava and I sing the Chilean song and teach everyone the words and the kiirtana tune, so that when Bábá returns, we are full flight in song, singing it with gusto and roaring out the driving, victorious beat with the Spanish words and then we continue the tune using the Bábá náma kevalam mantra.

Hace mucho tiempo que yo vivo preguntandome

For a long time I have been asking myself

Para que la tierra es tan redonda y una sola no mas

Why the Earth is round and there is only one?

Si vivomos todos separados

If we all live separated and alone

Para que son el cielo y el mar

Why do the sky and the sea exist?

Para que es el sol que nos alumbra

Why does the sun illuminate us?

Si no nos queremos ni mirar

If we do not want to see each other or come together

Tantas penas que nos van llevando a todos al final

In the end, this is creating so much pain

Cuantas noches, cada noche, de ternura tendremos que dar

Every night we will have to give so much tenderness

Para que vivir tan separados

Why do we live separated?

Si la tierra nos quiere juntar

If the Earth wants us to be united

Si este mundo es uno y para todos

If this world is one and for all

Todos juntos vamos a vivir ¹⁰

Then all together we are going to live as one

Am	C	G	Am	
Bábá náma	kevalam	Bábá náma	kevalam	(×2)
Am	C	G	Am	
Bábá náma	Bábá náma keva....	lam Bábá	Bábá náma	Bábá náma kevalam (×2)

Bábá stands before us beaming with enjoyment of the Spanish song and the kiirtana. We continue the same tune round after round, each rising in tempo from the previous, before slowing to a gentle end. Bábá is obviously pleased and commends us with a fervent, “Very good” and then continues on to repeat ‘very good’ in several languages, increasing His enthusiasm, “...*muy bueno*,...*très bon*,...*khub bhalo*,...*molto buono*,...*sehr gut*”, rounding up with a beaming and expressive, “*muito bom*” and concluding, “I think you know Portuguese and Spanish are close sister languages.” Bábá had said ‘very good’ in Spanish, French, Bengali, Italian, German, and finished with Portuguese.

As Bábá continues up the pathway to the house, Áshrava and I quietly begin the Spanish kiirtana again. With the other margiis, we sing on into the night, overjoyed at pleasing Bábá’ and receiving His compliment.



Garden Dramas

Wednesday 5/3

Bábá inspects the garden this morning with Ácárya Akśayánanda in tow as He has the last few days, then enters His car from the opposite side from where I stand. I am at the back of a small group of Indian devotees crowding in to give Him their namaskárs. As the car begins to move forward, I tactically edge towards the gate and Bábá, seeing me, gives an acknowledging namaskár.

A little later in the morning, I talk with Ácárya Akśayánanda about the plants he attends to in Bábá's garden. He generously shows me around, pointing out different plants of interest and permitting me to take some photographs. I ask him how he came to be the garden attendant. Addressing this, Dádá points out that the house is only newly finished and as I can see in the meditation room, the shlokas painted on the walls have yet to be finished. He continues his story for me:

While Bábá's residence here in Lake Gardens was under construction, He was staying at the Saptarshi Hotel in Gol Park nearby. The construction was very slow and Bábá expressed His displeasure at Dádá Prañavánanda, who was in charge, saying, 'Until my building is finalized, I will stay in Saptarshi.' Unfortunately, the construction dragged on despite Dádá's best efforts.

Eventually, because Dádá Prañavánanda was not able to complete the construction on time, Bábá told him to hand over charge to me. At that time, I was Personal Assistant (PA) to Bábá. If I took this new posting, I realised that I would not be with Bábá, that I would not be in the Central Office and would

not be able to enjoy Bábá's Darshan or programme. Even so, what could I do? It was Bábá's direction.

When I took charge of the construction, there was a problem of finance and because of this, it was slow to arrange the paperwork from the owner. The landowner had a tax matter and a litigation problem and had to dispose of his assets at the right price. Both parties were in a hurry to settle. If it were at 300,000 rupees, then he would do it. The ground floor was not completed at this stage and until it was finalized, Bábá would not live here. After much diligent work and some time, the house was finished and registered in Bábá's name and He moved in.

Although we took possession of the building, the grounds were still incomplete. I said to Bábá I want to plant flowers, seasonal flowers and trees. Bábá told me, 'No, no, no, if you plant nearby the building, the building foundations will be spoilt due to the plant roots.' Bábá did not give permission. I later realised that Bábá's psychology was to get more enthusiasm from me by refusing permission. Then I said that I wanted to do a roof garden. Bábá again replied, 'No, no, no, if the flowerpots are there, then water will fall on the roof and the building will be spoilt.' I also wanted to paint the building, but was not allowed.

Then, at the backside of the building I did some vegetable garden and chilli. One day, when Bábá was going on field walk, I approached Him and said come and see the garden Bábá. He reluctantly agreed saying, 'Ok, ok, let me see what garden you have done. Not near the building?'

'No some distance Bábá.'

'Ok, ok.' There I showed Bábá a *palong* [spinach] that I had planted and a chilli bush. Bábá commented on how they were high in vitamins and iron. He said, 'You have to give me at least one chilli per day.' On the next day, I gave him one chilli and every day thereafter. Bábá would mix it with *wole* [Bengali] from the root plant zimikond. Bábá would take boiled wole and

mix a very small cut chilli and a little rice. He said, very nice, very nice. Then He would have his other food. Bábá did not allow other planting. But when Bábá went to Taiwan, I could not get a passport from the Indian Government and had to stay behind in the quarters. Then I took this opportunity and started other planting in Bábá's absence.

On the ground floor of the house, there were many small rooms. Bábá and I planned to make a hall. He said, 'You have no money how are you to do it? Do not go to the office today at Jodhpur Park. Take one labourer and break all the small partitions and rooms. You keep working until I come back from the office. When I come back, I will hear all this noise of you breaking the walls and I will be very angry with you. You will tell how you have made a plan to build a hall for márgiis to do *pújá*, meditation and Dharmacakra, as per our plan, but do not mention this.' Bábá left and I proceeded to demolish all the interior walls to create one large space. When Bábá returned He immediately began, 'What is he doing? Akśáyánanda what are you doing?' Everyone was present there, G.S. [General Secretary] and Office Secretary. I repeated what Bábá had instructed me to, that I had a plan to build a hall for márgiis to do meditation and Dharmacakra. Bábá said, 'What do you say GS? His plan is not bad. Ok Akśáyánanda, you can continue it and whatever expense can be provided by GS and GFS [General Finance Secretary]. You should help him, he is doing a very good thing.' All work was done according to Bábá's plan, the floor in marble chips, Ánanda Súttram *shlokas* painted around the top of the walls. Bábá even designed the photo and pratika stand. When the hall was opened, Bábá said, 'You have to invite the general public in the surrounding neighbourhood. Make a packet of four items of sweets and give this to everyone.'

For everything, Bábá used to provide guidance, but He was not overly interested in the garden at that time. Next to the hall, I planted flowers in two small boxes. When Bábá came, He said,

‘This looks very nice. Oh, my boy this is very nice, looking very nice.’ Gradually over time He started to say, you do this side, then this side, then the other, on and on. When the driveway was being completed, Bábá gave direction for all parts of the garden. I was getting very much interested in the garden. Bábá would say, ‘Your interest is so much. You are doing so much work without any money.’ But still Bábá would tell me to bring more plants for the garden. Then I had to do a roof garden and Bábá said, ‘Ok, Akśayánanda, put flowerpots there.’ When I had finished, I asked Bábá to come to the roof. Bábá said, ‘Very nice, very nice.’ Now, whatever I liked I could plant. Bábá and I were both planting. Both of us would be squatting together in the garden and I would hand Bábá a small plant. Bábá would trim the roots, hand it to me and I would plant it. These were very nice days spent with Bábá.

Bábá started saying bring this particular plant and this one. There were so many plants. He requested many different varieties of orchids. Bábá appreciates that with orchid plants the flower will remain for a very long time. Orchids are not so common in India and Bábá is interested to show everyone all these many varieties. Many márgiis and Ácáryas have started bringing plants from the Indian regions and from around the world. All plants are registered in a very large ledger. If a plant dies I am told that I have to bring a new one. I have to go to so many nurseries to get plants according to Bábá’s wishes. When I bring the plants I confer with Bábá that I have brought this and that plant. Bábá will say exactly where each plant will go in the garden.

At that time, in the nighttime I would do the planting because I was so busy during the day with other work. Sometimes, at around 3.30am, in the middle of the night, Bábá would get up and see me working in the garden. He would call out to me, ‘When will you sleep. Go and sleep.’ I had no sense of difference between day and night. Both were the same for me. I would just keep on working.

Although Báábá has a cook, many times I will help. In particular, I am serving and feeding Báábá four time a day. There will be light refreshment at 6.30am; breakfast at 8.30–9am; lunch at 2.30–3pm; refreshments again at 6–7pm; and dinner at 11pm till midnight.

For breakfast, Báábá will take fruits and *luci*, like a pancake *puri*, made of fine wheat flour and curd. He will take only small portions. For lunch, He will take three to four items of vegetables and rice. At 6–7pm, He may take beaten cracked rice fried. At night, Báábá can take *luci* then vegetables and *paneer* [a fresh unaged vegetarian cheese]. He also sometimes has bean sprouts, just a small amount in the morning time. Indians do not eat this very much. Báábá had to instruct us what to do. He always would just eat small portions of whatever meal.

Báábá will always have a massage before sleep and it must be just right. One time, in 1967 when Báábá had moved to Calcutta, I was having the desire to massage His feet, but Báábá already had a Dádá to massage Him. This Dádá was giving Báábá a head massage. Báábá complained, that he was massaging too hard. ‘You are giving me more of a headache’, He said.

I quickly stated, ‘I will come and do the massage Báábá.’

To my surprise and pleasure, Báábá said, ‘Ok you come.’ Then to everyone present He commented, ‘Oh, he is doing very nice.’ From then, I massaged Báábá all the time.

There are so many plants and problems with plants dying. If I do not maintain all correctly and according to Báábá’s directions exactly, He will give me punishment with His stick. Everyone, all the Ácáryas, will witness this. Báábá may comment, ‘How do you like this now? How is your interest?’ Slowly He has been bringing out my deep desire, my *saṁskára*, through the work and the punishment. In the beginning, Báábá never asked anything, and then He started asking everything about everything. I had to know all about the plants, where a particular plant was in the garden, how it was doing and what its

full botanical name was. There are hundreds of plants from all over the world. If a plant dies Bábá will instruct me that I must replace it within say three, eight or twenty-four hours, according to the region it came from.

Bábá has a particular approach with me. He and I will enact so many dramas between us. Bábá may pretend to be the owner of a nursery or I may be the owner of the nursery and Bábá would be the customer. I begin my sales talk. ‘See my nursery, see what plants I have, I can give them to you so cheap, please buy this and this.’

Bábá would counter with, ‘Ok, ok; do you have any rare plants? Yes. Do you have such and such a plant?’ Bábá would describe an unusually rare plant that I did not know.

‘No, no, I don’t have that one.’

Bábá would become very animated, saying, ‘You are telling me that you have some rare plants. Where are they?’ We would continue the dramas for a long time in many different forms. I think that it was just for my benefit. Bábá was working on my deep-seated sañskáras. In this way, I was blessed to be with Him.

One day I was running after so many plants all day and said that I would not be back until late that day. I went everywhere to many nurseries. I did not take food. I returned very late and Bábá said, ‘What plants have you got?’ I replied that I was only able to get some of the required plants. ‘You do not have all’, Bábá yelled at me. I started weeping, as I was very tired. Bábá commanded me, ‘Now we play some drama! I am the owner of the nursery. You tell me what plants you want.’

‘Bábá, I am not ready to play the drama.’

‘Why do you not want to play?’

I told Bábá, ‘My mind is disturbed.’

Bábá explained, ‘I am playing the drama to make your mind ok.

Why do you not play? You play the drama Akśayánanda!’ , Bábá again commanded.

‘No, I will not play this drama, I said.

We were quarrelling. Bábá was very angry. He scowled at me and said, ‘I will punish you now. You come here.’ I was weeping. He began punishing me with the stick. He told me, ‘You have disobeyed me. Now I will not see your face. You can go.’

Through my tears I cried, ‘No! I will not go!’ I leant forward and caught Bábá’s waist. He was sitting higher than me on the bed. ‘You have to see me Bábá. You have to see my face.’ Bábá turned away and I kept moving in front of where He had turned. I kept saying, ‘You see my face Bábá.’ But He was turning away from side to side, saying, ‘No, no.’

Finally, as I persisted, He relented and said, ‘My small boy, I excuse you.’ Then he smiled and showed His love. I was overwhelmed.

Dádá Akśayánanda paused. His reminiscences of Bábá had touched me deeply and also brought up feelings for himself. His eyes were moist and I could see and feel his great love for Bábá. He had talked for a long time and there was work to be done. This was the first of a number of talks I would have with Dádá Akśayánanda about his life with Bábá and it opened up a whole new understanding of Bábá’s activities and interactions with devotees. The love, caring and direction a Guru has for His devotees.

In the evening, Bábá greets everyone with a rousing, “Namaskár, namaskár, namaskár. Namaskár to all,” as He goes for His walk. On returning from His field walk Bábá addresses us, “Did you sing in Spanish, Portuguese, English or French?”

“English Bábá.”

Bábá begins walking towards the stairs saying, “*Anglais*. What is ‘English’ in French?”

Áshrava knowing a smattering of French from school replies, “Anglais” with the ‘s’ accentuated on the end.

“No, you do not pronounce the ‘s’. It is not spoken when at the end of the word. It is mute. What is French for ‘India’? This is ‘The India’ – ‘*Le India*’ – ‘*L’Inde*’. Plural is *Les*. ‘*Le*’ masculine, ‘*La*’ feminine. Paris is ‘*Pari*’. They know so much and their Bábá knows nothing.”

While Bábá is indicating how much He knows, He is also expressing humility. Bábá reverses this arrangement at other times. I have heard that this is particular to people who have a Cosmic outlook. They at one time associate themselves with the Infinite and at others they are simple, humble people. I also wonder if Bábá is saying that we should be more conversant in our social etiquette? Would it have been better etiquette if I had said, ‘Bábá knows so much and we know so little. You are an ocean of knowledge Bábá. We are blessed to hear your every word’ Are we taking Him for granted? Of course, He does not seek personal aggrandisement – rather He shuns it. This is a very personal *liilá* [divine play] with the particular people present, that I see played out time and again in different ways with different people. I am not sure whether this play is somehow dealing with our unborn saṁskáras that Bábá is bringing to the surface to work themselves out. The Guru often works in mysterious ways and it is not necessarily clear to the devotee what is actually happening.

Bábá walks away to the house entrance and continues talking with the VSS guard accompanying Him. Not wanting to infract on the etiquette surrounding Bábá, but eager to be near Him, our small group, one by one, gradually shuffles up to hear Him continuing the language lesson. “What is ‘seven elephants’ in French? It is, ‘*sept d’e’le’phants*’. What is ‘my uncle’?”

Áshrava replies, “*mon uncle* [sic].”

Bábá corrects her saying, “*mon onc*”. Bábá repeats this, but to further express the intonation He presses His nose while saying ‘uncle’ such that He produces a honking sound on the ‘onc’. The gesture immediately induces a laugh in us. “*Onc, onc, onc*”, Bábá repeats, until

we are all laughing loudly. This comic side, the clown, is new to us. I had heard that Bá bá was a master of character and emotion as suited His purposes, not being tied to any particular type and now I see it. Bá bá finishes, commenting, “They are laughing. They know so much and their Bá bá knows nothing. Bye-bye. *Au revior.*”



Aunty

Thursday 6/3

As usual we are doing kiirtana when Bábá comes down for field walk and He enquires of us, “Are you all happy? Your health is good? Everything is running properly, running smoothly? Are you enjoying health and jollity – much jollity? Life should be joy. Your tune is very sweet.”

Later in the day, Áshrava has arranged that we can go over to the Women’s Welfare Department (WWD) of Ananda Marga to visit the respected Ácáryá in charge, Aunty. We catch a rickshaw as it is not too far from the Central Office, but the day is getting very hot. Áshrava knocks on the battered double wooden door at the entrance and Didi Ánandakaruná opens up and greets us. “Please come on up, Aunty is expecting you”, says Didi. We follow her up a narrow dark staircase. I guide myself with a hand upon the wall and as my eyes adjust from the bright of the outside sun, I can see scuffed pale green walls with peeling paint along the lower edges.

Didi leads us in through another door on the first floor. Down one end of a large room, sitting on a daybed, is Avadhútiká Ánandabháratii Didi, affectionately called ‘Aunty’ as the senior female Ácáryá of Ananda Marga. She is smiling with a large cheeky grin and jovially calls to us, “Namaskár, come in, come in”. Aunty wears large square-shaped glasses, through which her eyes also smile welcomingly.

We sit and talk for a while. Aunty is interested to know where we have come from and what we are doing. She motions us to move and sit down on a straw mat on the floor. She will join us. With much difficulty and the assistance of Didi Ánandakaruná, Aunty moves to the edge of

the daybed and lowers herself onto the mat to sit with us. Aunty has not been well for some time and finds moving very painful, so is restricted to the house for most of the time, but she never complains and is always in a cheerful frame of mind.

Drinks are brought in, as is a plate of *bhaji*, an Indian savory snack. Aunty wants an outline from Áshrava of what work is being done in Suva Sector with WWD and women márgiis. Áshrava gives a general report of activities and then turns the conversation to Aunty, inquiring, “Are you from Calcutta Aunty and how did you meet Bábá?”

“No, I am not originally from Calcutta. I grew up near Bombay and I already had a Guru from when I was young. I was doing the meditation and practices from this teacher.” Surprised, we lean in a little to hear more. Aunty is laughing and joking throughout her conversation and seems to have a glow about her. Aunty continues:

One night I had a vivid dream where this man dressed in white, approached me. Such a white, glowing shirt. He did not say anything. He just stood there in my dream. I had never seen Him before. This dream kept repeating itself night after night. One day I was at a friend’s house and I happened to see a photo she had in her bedroom. It was the man in my dreams. I couldn’t believe it. ‘Who is this? Who is the man in this photo?’ I asked. He was exactly like in my dream, even the white shirt. I was told this was my friend’s Guru, Shrii Shrii Ánandamúrtiji. ‘I must meet this Guru, I must see Him’, I said. Eventually I met Bábá. I was immediately drawn to Him. I became initiated and He became my Guru.

This is an intriguing story and Áshrava and I would like to know more of Aunty’s association with Bábá, but we have taken up much of her time and she is becoming a little tired and needing to take rest. I have been energised just sitting in her presence. Aunty is a joy to be around. She has a cheeky humour about her and is an inspiration. I think that she is the closest that I have ever come to meeting a saint. We say our goodbyes and Didi Ánandakaruná leads us down to the front door.

My only other saintly encounter was at about the age of eight when my mother arranged for my brother, Wayne and me to have training as altar boys in the Catholic Church. Wayne's and my experience up until then was of bitter, nasty nuns and priests who would have no hesitation in beating you with a cane if one hair of your head were out of place. Pain, suffering, discipline and punishment were the guiding mottos for their religious path and the only way to keep children from succumbing to evil. At first we shuddered when mum explained, I'm taking you to a convent where the Mother Superior will personally train you as altar boys. "Won't that be nice?" With trepidation we followed mum up the leafy back streets of Victoria Park where we lived. Our childhood had been difficult and this was mum's good intention to bring a strong religious sentiment into our sometimes unruly lives.

Mum stopped in front of a large single-storey wooden house in the lovely ornate Federation style. It was all painted white and surrounded with beautiful gardens. We walked up the tile-inlaid path and mum knocked on the stain glass panelled door. This was a Convent? The nun who answered the door was dressed in a white habit. Her face glowed. She was the Mother Superior. Mum left us in her care to return home by ourselves after a few hours instruction.

This Mother Superior was of the Order of Saint Francis of Assisi. Wayne and I went back day after day, at the end of school, to spend time with the Mother Superior. She was a holy person who radiated unconditional love. She had no investment in making us feel wrong, bad or sinful. I loved spending time in this beautiful house that was so serene, so quiet. The Mother Superior instructed us in religious matters and the requirements of becoming an altar boy, but this was all done in such a gentle, normal way and with such caring on her part that this time in my life sticks in my mind as one of the most precious times of my childhood. Saint Francis was also my Patron Saint and through the Mother Superior's stories of him, I came to understand and appreciate another side to religion, the spiritual.

In the evening Bábá comments, "Last night your song was very sweet. I learnt so much from you about French." Bábá walks to His car

and gets in, but before driving off He leans out of the window and says to us, “Last night I learnt so much from you about French grammar. What was the subject?”

We reply, “French grammar”, but, I think, miss the point. Bábá politely keeps reminding us, but we continually forget our manners while in awe of Him. What else are we missing that He is bringing to our attention. Perhaps I completely misunderstood the previous night. It seemed as if He had everything to teach and not anyone else. We should be thanking Him for teaching us so much about grammar. It seems that Bábá is mildly rebuking us on our poor social etiquette. It is we who should be thanking Him, but we stand there mute once again. What naive devotees. I should be saying, “Oh Bábá, thank you from the depths of my heart. You have given me so much, that I cannot even fathom what You have graced me with.”



To the Office

Friday 7/3

In the morning, Bábá comes down and walks around the garden inspecting the plants and giving Dádá Akśayánanda instructions on how to care for them. He calls out to Dádá Rámánanda from the far side of the garden, “I am going to the Office.” Then again in a rather loud voice such that Áshrava and I, the only márgiis here, can hear Him very clearly from where we are, “I am going.”

When Bábá gets into His car He says to us directly, “From today onwards I will be going to the Office.” Having heard that Bábá was not well, Áshrava asks Him, “How are you today Bábá?” He rocks His head from side to side as in ‘so-so’. She continues, “How is your health Bábá?”

He replies, “It is comparatively alright. It is superlative.” Bábá drives off for field walk before going to the Office. He has not been to the Office for the whole time we have been in Calcutta. Áshrava and I, taking Bábá’s cue, race out and hire a rickshaw to the Jodpur Park Central Office to be there and greet Him when He arrives.

Rolling up at the office, we excitedly jump out of the rickshaw. A Dádá at the entrance, seeing our excitement, asks us why we are here. “Because Bábá is coming.”

In disbelief, he says, “Come and tell Prañavánandaji.” Dádá Prañavánanda, the Office Secretary, questions us closely. None of the Ácáryas are aware that Bábá is coming to the office. Apparently, He has been so disappointed with their work that He has refused to come to the office for some time until they improve their performance. We explain to Dádá Prañavánanda that Bábá has personally told us He is coming

to the office today, probably very soon. When it dawns on them that Bábá is definitely coming, Dádá Prañavánanda barks out orders to all present and the Dádás race around frantically cleaning and tidying all the office in preparation for Bábá's arrival. Shortly after, Bábá drives up and Áshrava and I are waiting for Him at the front entrance of the office. He gets out and gives Áshrava and me a mischievous knowing smile, almost a chuckle at the game being played out.

Later that evening, before Bábá leaves for field walk, Áshrava and I do a kiirtana to an Australian tune, singing very loud and energised. When Bábá comes down He comments, "They are singing a new kiirtana in a different style. Good." On His return Bábá comments about the walk, "Tonight we did not talk about English grammar or French. We spoke about...what was the subject?"

This is directed to Dádá Krśñapriya, who had gone with Bábá and he replies, "Training programme and also English phonetics."

Bábá then proceeds up to His quarters. I ask Dádá Krśñapriya, "What is Bábá's training programme?"

Dádá explains, "On field walk, we went to a nearby park, called Lake Gardens, where Bábá paced very rapidly up and down from one end to the other for about fifty minutes. He said that each night He is increasing this by five minutes. I asked Bábá is He in training. He said yes. He explained that diagnosis is to find a solution after the problem has occurred and prognosis was before the problem had occurred. Therefore, He was applying prognosis in His training."

Saturday 8/3

Bábá comes down and enters His car to go on His morning field walk. Áshrava and I, the only ones here, stand at His open window. Bábá turns to us and says, with a cheeky smile, "I am going there", indicating to the Office and then drives off. We quickly go to the corner of the street and flag down a rickshaw and race over to Central Office. This time when we alert the Dádás, they quickly prepare everything for Bábá's arrival

and thank us again for notifying them. Dádá Prañavánanda is extremely pleased with our assistance and says, “If there is anything that I can help you with or you would like, please ask.”

Not one to miss an opportunity I come up with a small request, “Can we have a look in Bábá’s personal office?”

“Yes, yes.”

“May I take some photos?” I say, pushing my luck.

“Mmmm, yes, but don’t touch anything.” I can tell that I’m wearing Dádá’s hospitality thin and leave it at that for the moment. Dádá leads us over to Bábá’s office and opens the door. I tentatively peer in and then enter. The room is cool, with soft yellow striped curtains drawn across the window and the air smells fragrant. Bábá’s desk faces me, large, marble topped, neatly laid out with empty in/out trays and His famous pointing stick resting at the top of the writing blotter, in handy reach. This pointer is what Bábá uses to touch cakras of selected devotees during demonstrations of yogic states; transmit energy through; and also to administer punishments, thus lessening people’s saṁskáras, although He doesn’t need to use the stick to make such transmissions. To the left of the desk is a couch, where Bábá rests or conducts workers meetings from. I quickly take a few photos and we leave, knowing Bábá is on His way.

Eventually Bábá drives up to the Office and we are waiting there with smiles from ear to ear and namaskárs to greet Him. When He alights, Bábá gives Áshrava and me a knowing sweet smile and namaskár. He is pleased to see that we are taking His cue and we were pleased to be part of His little play.

When lunch is dished out on the rooftop, I sit down next to Dádá Keshavánanda who was involved in the cleanup preparations for Bábá’s ‘unannounced’ arrival. “Dádá,” I enquire, “When Bábá is normally coming to the Office, what does He do?” Dádá Keshavánanda gladly fills us in on Bábá’s office routine:

First He will go on field walk at Lake Gardens with three or four people to talk and then come to the office. He arrives about 10 or

11am after His walk. In Báábá's office there is a cot where He can sit or He can sit at His office table. We put all our reports before Báábá and according to the merit of the report Báábá will mark, with a red pen, one or more 'P'. This is for punishable. After He would say, 'how many Ps are there?'

'Fifteen Ps, Báábá.' On the particular day Báábá will decide the meaning of the 'P'. On one day one 'P' will mean fifteen caning, on another day it would be different, according to His desire. Then He will do office work. He will call the Office Secretary and the General Secretary to arrange transfers or postings of workers, of Ácáryas. If there is any official programme, then He will discuss. Afterwards He will call all the workers for reporting. Báábá will take reports by department-wise, in my case ERAWS (Education, Relief and Welfare Services), Báábá will ask how many new schools, new committees and what work has been done. Things like this.

During reporting, Báábá will see a worker's intention, their sincerity. If the Ácárya is sincere, Báábá will accept what work he has been able to accomplish. Báábá would say, 'I can take any work from any worker, if he is sincere and disciplined.' We workers always enjoy reporting. Say if Báábá is taking the reports, in the meantime, He will also start telling stories or some jokes. Báábá will interrupt the reporting saying, 'Wait, wait, wait. Do you know...?' Then He will tell some joke. Sometimes if the report is very serious, then Báábá will lighten with some jokes.

If Báábá is not satisfied with our progress or work, then He might not allow a worker to come to His residence at Lake Gardens or His office or He might not come to the Central Office, as He has done just recently. This is how He might reprimand us or encourage us to improve.

During Dádá Keshavánanda's explanation of Báábá's office routine and Ácárya reporting, he has eaten all of his rice and I am still struggling to get through even half of mine, but that is enough for me. The serving cook does not believe me when I say only a little rice. In India, a meal

is not a meal without a substantial serving of rice. Thanking Dádá and excusing myself, I take the remnants of my meal over to the wash-up area.

Come evening and Áshrava and I, along with several márgiis, are waiting for Bábá as He comes down for field walk. He stops and with deliberate slowness, Bábá namaskárs each person in turn while looking piercingly at them. It is like He is running an auric scanner across that person to check out his or her spiritual health. Bábá never does a rushed or flippant namaskár, but always embodies the ideation clearly, touching the forehead then chest with palms together while thinking, I recognise the divinity within you with all my mind and all my heart. On His return He simply says, “Your kiirtana tune tonight is very sweet, but less sweet than you boys and girls.” Jiivánii returns the complement with, “But not as sweet as you Bábá.”



Darshans Begin Again

Sunday 9/3

Bábá is quiet as He goes for His field walk this morning, but namaskárs us and indicates that He is going to the Office. When Áshrava and I arrive there, our friends from Australia, Ainjalii (Ańshumálinii) and Bháratii (Bhávashrii) are there, having just arrived to complete their training to become Ácáryas. It is a happy reunion, but we also cannot help noticing that there are also many other Indian márgiis at the Office. Word has gone out on the márgii-grapevine and many people have arrived to experience Bábá's Darshan, the first in some time at the Central Office.

Everyone crowds into the hall and sits in readiness, some meditating. Bábá arrives and takes His place at the front of the hall seated on a daybed. He begins this Darshan with what will be a series directly related to the ritual of sacrifice, Yajiṇa, begun over fifteen thousand years ago by the Aryans. When Aryans entered India they brought Yajiṇa with them and it is still widely performed today. These Darshans cover the creation and significance of the Vedas (four compositions creating a religious school of thought emphasising the use of ritual to gain the intercession of the gods) and the effect indigenous Indian Tantra has had on them. Bábá also speaks about the emergence of various languages and scripts in India over this time. Many practices of the immigrating Aryans have been mixed up with Tantra practices of the indigenous Dravidians, resulting in these topics being mired in controversy, misunderstanding and debate within Indian history/archaeological circles and the spiritual community.

Yajiṇa – The Beginnings

Bábá describes how, fifteen thousand years ago, the nomadic Aryan people passed through Iran and Afghanistan and started

entering India from the north-west. When they proceeded further east, they came to an area of abundant green vegetation. As they proceeded they also saw rice paddies. Further east they ultimately arrived where the two rivers Ganga and Yamuna meet, known now as the modern day Allalabad.

Bábá continued, saying that the Aryans arrived at the extreme junction where the rivers merged. With plenty of water and very fertile land for cultivation, they thought it was a good place to stay and continue their religious practices, the rituals of Yajiṇa. They named the place Pra-yag. The meaning of Prayag is the place where all the mundane actions (eating, bathing, etc.) could be done in the very proper way.

He goes on to say that the people of those days depended on the rain. To ensure this they wanted to invoke and please the Rain God. Ghee would be offered into a fire, creating enough smoke that looked like clouds, which they believed would make rain. These were the rituals of Yajiṇa.

Bábá outlines how the Aryan people came from a cold place where they drank intoxicating drinks to keep warm. In India, they found some herbs in the forest and they prepared a form of wine called Somarasa. They would drink this during the Yajiṇa. They realised that if everybody drank wine during the ritual, then the Yajiṇa rituals may not be appropriately performed and therefore disturb the God.

Bábá concludes by detailing how this prompted them to appoint some people who would not drink during the ritual to see that all was done appropriately. So that others could recognise the performers of Yajiṇa, they would wear a deerskin on their right shoulder. This person became elevated in the society because of this position.¹¹

At the end of His Darshan, Bábá requests that *tándava* and *kaosikii* dance be done. These are vigorous dance exercises that develop the endocrine glands in a way that encourages the practitioner to overcome

psychological complexes and strengthens the body and nerves. While some margiis dance, the rest of the group chant Bábá náma kevalam in the prescribed rhythm metered out by a drum and the call of a lead Ácárya. Bábá has sat sternly during this procedure. Now He namaskárs the gathering, slips to the edge of His couch and leaves.

Come evening, it is pouring with rain. Maybe someone has been pouring a lot of ghee into the Yajña fire because it is pelting down. Áshrava, Púrña Premá and I are crowded under the small guard's shelter at the front next to the gate doing kiirtana. Bábá comes downstairs, protected by an oversized black umbrella carried by His assistant and calls out over the din of the rain, "Aren't you getting drenched?"

Áshrava replies, "No Bábá," but He apparently does not hear and again queries about us singing in the rain. In our camaradrie we are happy here singing. We reply in unison, "No, Bábá" and I cheekily add, "We are drenched only with your sweetness Bábá." At this, He throws His head back and gives a hearty laugh before leaving.



Strange Experiences

Monday 10/3

Bábá comes out the next morning and we greet Him with another of Áshrava's kiirtanas. He stops and comments, "Your kiirtana tune is very sweet". Accompanying this complement Bábá gestures His enjoyment with a small kiss to His fingertips and throws it up into the air.

Áshrava has been suffering from asthma repeatedly in the nighttime. Last night it was very bad. She has not slept and despite her inhaler, has had repeated episodes. She is becoming very tired to the point of being exhausted. We conclude that the room Áshrava sleeps in at the women's jágrti, having no windows and very poor ventilation, is exasperating her asthma. There is no other Ananda Marga residence for her to stay. Our only other recourse is to seek a hotel. None of the Ácáryas have any suggestions as everyone visiting stays at the women's jágrti or Central Office.

Áshrava and I catch a bus to the city centre to look at hotels. We wander through the cheap backpacker tourist area around Sudder Street looking at one unsuitable place after another. These won't do and they are a long way from Bábá's house and the Office. Everything else around the city centre is way out of our price range.

We wait at the city bus stop for a mini bus back to Jodhpur Park. A massive double decker bus arrives already packed with people, but stops for more to get on. A couple of passengers push their way off through the back door and ten or fifteen more try to get on. When a few have squeezed their way into the interior of the bus, someothers try to stand on the entrance step area. One hapless lad is only on by the toes of one foot and one hand gripping the outside boarding rail. Because there

are so many people using the pavement-side front and rear doors of the bus, it has an unsettling lean to that side. The bus lurches forward with its load out into the surging traffic.

Our mini bus arrives soon and we step up into it, standing in the aisle with head bent under the low roof. These sixteen seater mini buses were introduced at triple the fare to provide comfortable seating-only transport. Under the swell of commuters this regulation has been lost and the conductors allow as many people as possible onto these mini buses.

Coming along Gariahat road, we arrive at the big roundabout where the Ramakrishna Mission Ashram is and decide to get off and look in this area as it is relatively close to Jodhpur Park. On the corner we find a Chinese restaurant where we have a bit of lunch and refreshed from that we begin our search. There is nothing apparent in the roundabout area so Áshrava suggests we follow the tramline going west. We find a few mixed results along this road. One with aircon is a bit pricey.

A good way on we spy a small, rundown looking place, the Asia hotel, on Rash Behari Avenue. A smiley young lad shows us a large airy double room. The bed has a good mosquito net hanging from a post framework. The room has a fan and open barred window areas all along one side that will give plenty of ventilation. Additionally we have a large veranda with table and chairs and our own bathroom across a long catwalk from the veranda. At forty-five rupees per night, this is very suitable, but none-the-less will cut heftily into our savings. Áshrava breathes easy just at the thought of a fresh, ventilated night's sleep. I can almost visibly see her shoulders relax and the tight tendons in her neck ease off their death grip. There are only Indians travellers staying here. I think we are the first foreigners to venture into this part of town. The manager and staff are pleased to have us and we feel welcomed. We gather our things from the other accommodation and bring them to the Asia hotel to settle in immediately. Noting the time it takes us to travel across from Jodhpur Park, I reinforce my previous resolve by saying to Áshrava that since we are further away from Bábá's house, we will have to be even more vigilant about arriving on time.

In the evening we do just that and as Bábá leaves for field walk, He enquires of Áshrava, “Your health is OK?” She replies, “Very OK Bábá.” Áshrava is so relieved to have a place where she can breathe easy and get a good night’s sleep.

On returning, Bábá stops in front of us and speaks to the gathered group, “Do you know about illusionary figures? Ghosts? Do you know ghosts are nonexistent? I have narrated a book about it. Do you know? We were just talking about it.” Bábá indicates to the Dádá who accompanied Him on field walk. “I have handed it to the Publications Department and it will soon be translated if not already published. You may enquire. I have written many stories about ghosts, things that have happened to me. These stories have a psychological reason.”ⁱⁱ

Bábá continues telling a story:

“I went to my brothers house. He knew that I was coming, but for some reason he went out. It was dark and raining profusely. I was very hungry, but the food storeroom was locked and I didn’t know where the key was. I was feeling very sleepy and lay down. Then I was in that state where you are neither in the conscious or dream state, but in-between. Do you know? A lady appeared in the room and said you are in a distressed state and I’d like to help you, I know much about food and how to cook, but I am not in the living body. But there is one thing I can do for you. Behind the dresser you will find the key to unlock the door. I awoke and when I looked it was there.”

With a mischievous smile, Bábá ends the story and begins to walk away, but Jivánii asks, “What was the reason Bábá?”

He turns and replies, “I did not narrate that part in the book.” He begins to walk off to the stairs while saying, “It is very interesting.” Then just before He walks up the stairs, Bábá turns and addresses us, “The reason I did not narrate the underlying psychological reason is because it would spoil the charm of the story. I have given only the title of the reason and if I get the time I will write the full details.”ⁱⁱⁱ

iii *Strange Experiences* (originally in Bengali as *Vicitra Abhijñāta*) was published in English in

Tuesday 11/3

In the morning we are somehow extra early to Bábá's residence, I guess trying hard does help. The sound of beautiful bhajan singing is floating from the meditation hall under Bábá's house. We enter to find Púrńa Premá and Jiivánii there singing. Áshrava joins in and I sit in meditation, being peacefully lulled by the girls' singing. A while later, in my stillness, despite the volume of the bhajans, I hear talking coming from outside and realise that it is Bábá and He has already come downstairs. I get up, look out of the window and there He is in the garden talking with the VSS guard and Dádá Akśáyánanda about the plants. I call the girls and as we come out onto the front porch, Bábá turns to us and in greeting says, "My boys and girls are making good utilisation of the meditation room. Is it a good room?"

"Yes Bábá", we reply and Jiivánii adds, "It's perfect Bábá, no?"

Agreeing, He responds with a simple, "Yes", then goes to His car and is driven off to field walk.

Parimal, the VSS guard, tells us that Bábá is going south to the seaside town of Digha for a holiday for a few days from tomorrow. Áshrava and I talk about this and decide that we will not go there as we prefer not to disturb Bábá's much-needed break from His busy schedule. Also Bábá has not indicated this directly or encouraged us to come.

With Bábá gone on field walk, I decide to go back into the meditation hall. Strolling quietly around inside there, I look up at the writing neatly painted in Sanskrit and bordered by two vivid glossy orange lines, ringing around the top section of the walls. Bábá had requested that the aphorisms from His Ánanda Sútram book be displayed in this way. I can make out the Sanskrit number one in the top left corner of the room.

Sutra #1: *Shivashaktyátmakaṁ Brahma*

[*Brahma is the composite of Shiva and Shakti*]

2001. The story Bábá quotes is number four. The reason given for the experience was *Jīḡánaja svapna* (Literally, 'A dream arising from deep knowledge').

The purport to this explains that the Cosmic Entity is the composite of Consciousness (*Shiva*) and the Operative Principle (*Shakti*). The Sanskrit script continues for eighty-five sutras giving a concise framework for Bábá's ideology, both spiritual and social all contained in these tight packets of philosophical statement. In the book *Ánanda Sútram*, the sutras are elaborated on to give the full import of what is being conveyed. It was this concise theory and explanation in *Ánanda Sútram* and one of Bábá's other books, *Idea and Ideology*, that opened up my understanding of the spiritual practice of yoga and meditation in a way that appealed to my western scientific mind and that I have not found explained anywhere else with such clarity.

Central to the room is a small, unostentatious altar, stepped up on either side to a point that makes it look a little like an orange Christmas tree to me. It is topped by the Ananda Marga starred symbol, the *pratika* and decked out in cheery light orange marigold flowers strung into garland threads around the edges. In the middle of this altar is a picture of Bábá in black and white, looking directly at the viewer with the hint of an enigmatic smile brushed across His plump lips. His eyes are steady and clear through His large black edged glasses and draw me in as I stare into them. The point of light in the pupils glows and the blackness around looks like deep, deep wells. Behind me the door creaks and the spell is broken. I turn to see Áshrava entering the meditation room.

Áshrava had just been talking to an older márgii about what musical instruments might be available to use during our kiirtanas for Bábá. Beside the altar lays a scruffy harmonium and a long, double-sided Indian Khol drum. Neither of us can play these. Áshrava has been told to look inside the small storage room through the green doors on the left to see what percussion instruments there might be. We go over and gingerly pull the snug double doors apart to reveal a dark storage chamber of random items. At the front on the floor there is a set of small brass cymbals and an Indian Kartal, a pair of carved wooden sticks with four brass jingles. These will come in handy for pacing a nice rhythm to our tunes. I rummage a little further through the jumbled piles and lifting a dusty cloth, made a serendipitous find of sorts. My initial 'ahh'

turns to a groaning ‘ooh’ as I spy the body of a guitar, but realise the neck is extensively damaged. I pull it out and Áshrava and I examine it. She strokes its body like a small pet found injured, “What happened to you?” To me it looks like someone has stepped fair and square on the middle of the neck and broken it completely in two. Only the strings hold the two parts together. It is a ragged snap of sharp pointy pieces.

Although I can strum out a tune when required, Áshrava is the guitarist in the family. She has already produced a beautiful album of her own songs called ‘*Scarlet Roses*’. When Bábá had listened to one tape of Áshrava’s in Europe, He commented to the presenting Ácárya, “She knows the secret of music,” It is heart breaking for her to see what was once a fine acoustic guitar smashed so devastatingly. We lay it back to rest in its little coffin of a cupboard. I didn’t think that there is any hope for a resurrection. Thankfully, we take the percussive pieces and close the doors, but our little disabled musical friend is not forgotten.

In the evening, while doing kiirtana, Bábá approaches us and exclaims, “Everything is alright?” We all intone a “Yes, Bábá. Jiivánii then steps forward and presents Bábá with a garland, which He takes and touches to His forehead. He then asks, “What is your name?”

“Jiivánii, Bábá.”

“That is a good name. Isn’t there a newsletter called ‘Jiivánii’?”

“Yes, Bábá. For G.V., Girl’s Volunteers department.”

“Very good. I am such a little boy, but I know so much.” GV is the women’s equivalent of the men’s VSS, both providing security for Ananda Marga projects and engaging in difficult and sometimes dangerous social service work, such as rescuing people or disposing of dead bodies after natural disasters.

On returning from field walk, Bábá stops and greets us. Áshrava steps forward and presents Bábá with her cassette ‘*Scarlet Roses*’, songs written and performed by her. “And what is this?” Bábá exclaims.

“Revolutionary songs, Bábá.”

“Who is it by?”

“Women’s RAWA.”

“RAWA performers of where?”

“Suva Sector. It is for you to listen to on your holiday Bábá.”

“Certainly I will listen to it.”

Bábá then moves on up to the stairs where He begins speaking to the VSS guard and the Dádás in Bengali. Not to miss anything we amble on up the side of the house to listen. Halfway through His sentence, Bábá turns to us and says in English, “Excuse me, but I am speaking in Bengali instead of English, because it is a very juicy subject”. Then He continues in Bengali to the rapt attention of those who understand Him. Their grins and laughter intrigue us.

After Bábá has gone, we pull one of the Dádás aside for a translation. He explains that Bábá was telling how, in the past, any Indian who left India for overseas was considered an outcaste upon returning. They would be shunned by the higher castes, especially the highest, the *Brahmins*. A doctor, who in this way was outcaste, fooled all the caste-conscious Brahmins by secretly offering a monetary reward to those who would visit his darkened house for a *Shráddhá* ceremony (last rites) at night. Many people, greedy for the money, gathered in the doctor’s house, hiding in the shadows of the darkened room so none could identify them. Then the doctor turned on all the lights, and exposed the hypocrites who had excommunicated him from the society.



A Little Holiday

Wednesday 12/3

While Bába is away over the next three days, Áshrava and I give ourselves a change of pace, our attempt at being a little like tourists. We have arranged to visit Ánanda Sambodhi, the WWD Global Master Unit, a farm property managed by the Didis where they also run an orphanage and school. Early in the morning we go to Howrah train station. It looks like everyone else in Calcutta has had the same idea. The station is crowded and people are everywhere, proceeding on their journeys. Red-shirted baggage handlers with three or four suitcases balanced upon their heads and trailed by a line of their customers, pick their way through swirling throngs of travellers. Families group together. Some sit in a circle on the platform with tiffin boxes laid out having breakfast, others sleep, wrapped in a blanket from head to foot. We find our platform and board the train for the town of Asansol on the far west of West Bengal State, almost on the border with the next State, Bihar. Arriving there some hours later, an autorickshaw takes us out to the Master Unit. There are a few simple concrete buildings forming the school and orphanage, some still in the process of being finished. Although very basic in its facilities, this property has all the feel of a spiritual sanctuary. The Didis are very pleased to see us and take every effort to make us at home.

Later in the day, Áshrava and I wander around the property. The land here is sparse, rocky and dry. Áshrava says, “Let’s climb a small hill nearby to get a view over the property.” The sun is just beginning to set in a brilliant red smearing right across the skyline. A lone tree dots the side of the hill, leafless and naked against the darkening red. I figure that up in that tree is the place to get a spectacular photo of

the Master Unit. I clamber up and Áshrava hands me the camera. I can easily go up a few more branches until I'm perched mid point in the tree and take a few stunningly coloured shots with the orange ball of the sun skimming the horizon. Breaking the sunset quiet, Áshrava yells out, "Quick, get out of the tree!" Perplexed, I look around to see a huge bird zooming in towards me from high up in the sky. It's massive, ugly and scary. This bird's wing-span seems to be a couple of meters across and it has a huge glinting beak. Worst of all, it's coming straight for me. Slightly panicked I dive down from branch to branch and swing clumsily to the ground, thinking that at any moment my scalp is going to be picked right off the top of my head. The bird alights in the top branches a little above where I was sitting. It's a vulture. This ugly carrion feeder ignores us, but still, we warily walk back down the hill. Áshrava and I stay the night at the Master Unit and in the morning catch the train back.

Rather than going straight to Calcutta, we make the most of our time by changing trains halfway to go to Shantiniketan, the open air University established by Rabindranath Tagore, India's Poet Laureate. It is a place of great tranquillity and a centre of art, music and dance. Áshrava and I spend an interesting day walking around the campus listening in on practice sessions of tabla, singing or harmonium. Some studio rooms are training Indian traditional dance and we sit entranced while students go through their movements. In Tagore's preferred style of communing with nature, some classes are held outside under great Banyan trees. In the late afternoon we catch a train back to Howrah station in Calcutta.

Taxis in India often have their dashboard decorated as if it is a fancy altar. Orange and yellow marigold flowers are strung around the window. Vivid orange *tilak* is dotted on the dash. Scented smoke curls up from incense *dhoop* sticks. Various *murtis* (religious icons) are displayed along the length of the dash. Predominant in Calcutta are murtis of three of its lauded citizens, Rabindranath Tagore, the poet and artist; Sri Ramakrishna, the mystical Saint and Subash Chandra Bose, the Independence Freedom Fighting revolutionary.

On the third day of our break, Áshrava and I notch up number two on this list and walk up from our hotel to the Ramakrishna Mission at Gol Park Circle, not far from the park and lakes of Lake Gardens. Sri Ramakrishna was a famous nineteenth century mystic, his chief disciple being Swami Vivekananda who popularised the Ramakrishna Mission all over India and the world. We wander around the tranquil ashram corridors. Besides the beautiful rose gardens in the centre of the Mission buildings, we discover a well-presented library with airconditioning. Here we are able to spend a couple of hours relaxing in the cool and reading different spiritual texts. I earmark this as a place for later to get a break from the slowly increasing heat of summer steadily marching on.

From the Ramakrishna Mission it's a short rickshaw ride to the suburb of Kalighat and another iconic site of Calcutta, the Kali Temple. This is a temple dedicated to the goddess Kali. Although depicted as a terrifying form, Kali is also considered a benevolent mother goddess, one aspect of Parvati, consort of Shiva. We wander around the bazaars selling religious paraphernalia associated with Kali and take a short tour of the temple making sure we time our visit to leave in time to be at Bábá's house for field walk. On arriving we find He is not going tonight and does not come downstairs.



Back in Calcutta

Saturday 15/3

Up early, Áshrava and I are there to greet Bábá with kiirtana in the morning, the only márgiis to arrive. He immediately exclaims, “Were you there? Did you go to Digha?”

Áshrava replies, “No, Bábá. We wanted to give you a rest. We went to Asansol.”

Nodding His head, Bábá continues, “Where is the other lady? The one who came?” As we don’t know, we shrug and shake our heads, but find out later that Púrña Premá had followed Bábá down to Digha and had the good fortune of going on field walk with Him, being the first sister, with one other, to go on field walk in India with Bábá, so we are told.

Later in the day as we stroll down P.A. Shah road on the way back to our accommodation, it occurs to Áshrava that maybe we can buy some simple musical instruments to augment what we have. Áshrava looks around and, momentarily distracted by the incredible array of brilliantly coloured bangles in a jewellery shop, asks there and they direct us around the corner to a music store. Indian shopkeepers make great utilisation of space. This music store is no exception. Although it barely measures three metres across the front, the window is choc-a-block with a range of beautifully crafted instruments such that we can hardly see inside. Upon entering, it is a maze of sitars, sarods, drums and other instruments hanging from a grid across the ceiling and the floor is piled with harmoniums and tablas. We duck and weave our way to the counter.

On a raised daybed platform behind the counter, absorbed in stringing a beautiful ivory inlaid sitar, is an old man with flowing grey

beard. Further back in the long rectangular shop I can see a work area with wood shavings, tools of trade and cut out wood frameworks for instruments.

The old man looks up from his task and in clear, Bengali-accented English asks, “What have you good people come here for?” Initially there for percussion hand instruments, my mind starts ticking over. Áshrava asks for percussion and looks through a small array the old man proffers, picking out a dainty set of brass ankle bells with orange ribbon and a heavy pair of cymbals. Nothing ventured, nothing gained, I tell him about the guitar in the off-chance he can do something with it sufficient to strum out a rough tune. I describe it graphically, but he seems unperturbed by my damage description and encourages me to bring it in to be examined.

With a faint glimmer of hope, we go back to Bábá’s house, retrieve the damaged guitar and take it to the old instrument maker. As an appreciator of fine instruments, he shakes his head in dismay at the damage. I didn’t know whether he has ever seen a guitar before. I thought maybe he can put a steel joiner on the back of the neck or chop out the offending part and replace it with another piece or even replace the entire neck. Whatever, I’ll leave it up to Bábá and the old man. The instrument maker says he will take a closer look to see what might be done. We didn’t even think to get a quote, but the old man assured us it will not cost much. He asks us to come back in one week.

In the evening Bábá comes down and I am waiting for Him with a garland of Tuberose flowers. He stops and asks, “A mala for me?” “Yes, Bábá.” He lowers His head and for a second I pause focusing my attention to this very moment of garlanding Bábá and then, I do so. It is an extraordinary experience. Beforehand I had ideated on the offering of my mind in the form of this garland and doing so was a pújá for me. There seems to be an energy flow and an expansion at touching Bábá. This simple action catapults me into a state of presentness and awareness. He looks up at me with an enigmatic smile and I do namaskár. Bábá enters His car and drives off for field walk.

When Bábá comes back and gets out of the car, He greets everyone there with a namaskár while slowly turning on the spot. Then He sees me and an instant of recognition spreads across His face as He namaskárs to me in such a sweet way that seems to say ‘here is the little boy who gave me the garland’. It is such a look that I think how I would like to garland Him all the time or how I would like to do many little things for Him personally. Seeing how everyone around Bábá would like to do this, but it is not practically possible, I remember Bábá’s saying, ‘I and my mission are one. If you want to serve me do my work’. Using this example of Guru-disciple relationship to look for the Supreme expression in everyday actions in work and people is how to make my life a constant pújá to the Supreme, an offering to God in every action I do. This is Sevá, service to the Divine as a way of spiritual practice.



In the Heat of the Day

Sunday 16/3

Running late again. Áshrava and I have to get over to the Central Office in a hurry. We have been at Bábá's house and missed Him going on field walk and then hung around talking for some time until one of the VSS guards inquired if we are going to Bábá's Darshan at the Central Office as He would be giving it some time very soon. Off we go at a trot, but it's quite late and we may not make it in time. Áshrava and I briskly go a couple of streets from Bábá's house to where there is a row of slightly dilapidated rickshaws parked up against a brick wall. Rickshaw drivers are the poorest of the poor, working long hard hours and often holding two or more of the lowest paid jobs, if they can get the employment, to survive and feed their family.

It is the middle of the day by now and at this time of year the sun is becoming quite intense, such that we now always walk looking for the shady side of the street to give us some respite from the burning rays of the Indian sun. At this time of day no-one is on the streets, the shops are closed and most people are taking a rest from the fierce midday heat. The rickshaw wallahs are taking a well-earned rest in the steamy heat. Some are stretched across the seat of their rickshaw; others lay underneath them on a blanket spread out on the ground. All are resting as best as they can in this dead part of the day, the height of heat siesta.

In my eagerness to get to the Darshan, I call out, "Rickshaw to Jodhpur Park?" Hardly a person stirs. One curious wallah slides the cloth covering his face down to stare at me incredulously and slowly shaking his head, goes back to rest. Not thinking of the time of day, I reiterate my previous request and add an extra rupee price to entice

someone out of his siesta. This time a few of the rickshaw wallahs perk up, but more in annoyance at being again disturbed from their well deserved rest, especially given that they possibly work nights as well.

I naively implore them about our task and eventually one man struggles to his feet enticed by my offer. He pulls his rickshaw out of the line and onto the road. It is surely the most dilapidated rickshaw of the lineup, a grey-black all over, with no brightly coloured edgings or painted panels remaining.

Áshrava and I gingerly climb onto the high-set seat. The wallah puts his full weight on one pedal and slowly moves off with us in tow. I watch his muscular body rapidly bead with sweat as he peddles us towards Jodhpur Park. This rickshaw wallah is probably the most desperate of the bunch; themost poverty stricken and he could not pass up such a good offer, even if it was in the exhausting heat. As we ride off to the Central Office, I console my guilt with the thought that at least I am supplying him with employment and add onto the agreed amount an appreciative tip for his service.

We arrive a little late and sneak into the back of the room for Bábá's Darshan, but it is all in Bengali. Still it is good to be in His presence and we do meditation while listening to the melody of His voice.

In the evening Bábá inquires of the small group of foreign márgiis present to greet Him, "Has today's Darshan been translated into English?" As He says this, He pricks His leg on a palm frond sticking out of the garden and jumps forward with a little surprised start and then talks in Bengali about the plant to one of the Indians. Bábá then returns to us again inquiring as to whether there had been a translation yet.

"No, Bábá", we reply.

"Have you inquired?"

"No, Bábá."

"Then you should press them. Maybe they are busy today. They have so much office work."

In hindsight, I think, if I maybe had taken Bábá's urging to seek a translation of all these Darshans, then this particular one would have survived, as it is no longer to be found in Bengali, English or any language. Many Darshans have been lost or so badly recorded that they cannot be understood.

A sister from the USA, Shiva Prabhá, steps forward and respectfully presents Bábá with some packets of seeds for His garden. Bábá says in jovial surprise, "What are these? Seeds! How did you know to bring these? Perhaps someone whispered in your ear? I think now everyone in the world knows I want to start a botanical museum."

On returning from His walk Bábá passes along a row of márgiis while holding His hands in namaskár position to His chest. When He reaches me, He stops, projects His head a little and stares at me knowingly for some time. He stares with intensity, His eyes looking deeply into mine. It is as if He is reading me. What does He see? Breaking this build-up of intensity, I give Him a namaskár, which Bábá returns and then He moves on. These moments with Bábá seem to make me centre myself with a fervent concentration. His focussed attention is like my doing an intense and long meditation session. Bábá chooses different márgiis at different times to stop at or acknowledge. I am told that this is some internal need of that márgiis which Bábá responds to. On the other hand, I have heard of márgiis who, insincere in their devotion or wanting Bábá's attention for an ego boost, do not get His attention and events even arrange themselves so that Bábá is drawn elsewhere at that moment.

Monday 17/3

In the morning Áshrava is unwell and unable to come to Bábá's house so I go alone and find that I am the only one there. I do kiirtana happily by my solitary self until Bábá comes down with a couple of Indian márgiis who are there to go on field walk. When He gets into His car, I am the only one standing there at His window and continue to do kiirtana. Bábá turns and looks out at me. He does namaskár and returns to talking with the márgiis inside. He again turns to me, this time to

encourage me in the kiirtana with a nod of His head. When everyone is settled in their seats and the VSS guard is seated in the front passenger seat with Bábá's drinks basket on his lap, the car drives off.

I spend some more time during the day talking with Ācārya Akśayānanda about his experiences. "Dádā, I enquire, what are some of the other things you remember about being with Bábá?"

Dádā Akśayānanda tells me:

I was always busy with gardening work; planting, caring for each plant, ordering more from the nursery. One day, a garden contractor, a non-mārgii, came to deliver plants to the house, a very educated young man. He had been here before and heard Bábá speaking about the plants. He was thinking that Bábá must have so many books because He knows many things about all the different plants. Bábá never took anyone into His room without any special work to be done or for PC. In this instance, Bábá called the gardener to follow Him to His room to look at two or three cacti He was keeping there. While the gardener was looking at the cacti, Bábá made a point of telling this gardener that He had no library or books. 'Look around. Do you see any library?'

The gardener queried Bábá, 'But how do you know so much about plants if you do not have any books?' The young man was greatly surprised that Bábá could have so much knowledge without them. In this way, because Bábá knew the gardener's thoughts, Bábá was stretching his thinking beyond book knowledge to consider other sources of knowledge. This was leading the gardener towards the spiritual path.

Bábá was always giving me so much instruction regarding the care of the plants. One day I carried a bag with tape recorder and microphone inside. I was recording Bábá surreptitiously so as not to disturb Him. I needed to remember to carry out His instructions regarding their care and all the information He gave me about them. There was a click from the recorder.

Bábá asked if I was recording and I said no, but I stopped the tape. Bábá knew and was angry with me about the recording. Then, for my mistake, I asked for punishment. Any punishment He gave I would accept. I had felt that it would be good to keep a record of what Bábá spoke, but he did not want me recording.

The gardening work took much of my time now, but still, after coming back from this, I would massage Bábá and give Him light refreshments. At nighttime, I would be massaging Bábá. One time I found that Bábá's hands and legs had become cold. After a few days, I was feeling that they were very cold, just like ice. I asked Bábá why has your body, especially your legs become so cold. Bábá said that so many luminous bodies were coming along and massaging Him along with me and they have very cold hands. A luminous body can become any form and help the spiritualist in many ways. Luminous bodies help us in many ways. Several times luminous bodies have helped me, when all of a sudden a person was there to assist me when I needed it. I found when I was doing massage at times there would be many luminous bodies. Sometimes Bábá would ask me to wait for a while, as luminous bodies were working on Him. Sometimes Bábá's legs would move as if He were being massaged. The luminous bodies were helping.

One time I was massaging Bábá when He suddenly shook His head from side to side and uttered, 'Tsk, ts, ts.'

I asked, 'What has happened Bábá?'

He replied, 'A good man has just died.' Sometimes Bábá would say things like; there was a fire in such and such a place. Many times, He would express when someone had just died. I never questioned these things. At the same time, He was very happy due to my service and because of this He once said, 'I want to give you something.'

I said, 'No Bábá, I don't want anything.'

‘Okay, then one thing I will do. I can bestow on you such that, just sitting here in Calcutta, you can see the whole world. If you want this, I can teach you.’

I declined the offer. I massaged Bábá during both day and night, as He required.

Anyhow, it was going on like this. Sometimes after massaging, I would go to sleep in Bábá’s room. I would go to sleep when I could get it. When Bábá told me to go to sleep I would, otherwise I would not. Here at Lake Gardens once I was about sixteen hours continuously with Bábá. At other times, I would be with Him for six hours, other times less. I enjoyed this time with Bábá very much.

There was one young Dádá appointed to assist me. I had gone away for the day and left him to take care of any of Bábá’s needs. In Bábá’s room, a very nice scent permeates everything there. This comes from Bábá. The Dádá said to Bábá, he wanted this scent in his hand to smell it all the time. Bábá questioned his reason, but he still said he wanted it. Bábá said, ‘Okay, you will have it for three hours.’ When I came back, the Dádá began telling me that Bábá had given him some scent in his hands. He presented his hands for me to smell. He was showing this to the other Dádás saying see what Bábá has given me. This young Dádá was a very foolish boy. He was not correct in his actions. You do not need to ask the Guru for what you need. He knows what you need. If you do you may lose other more important things in its place. Do not ask for material objects or any other thing, except devotion or liberation.

In the evening, when Bábá comes downstairs to his car, Púrñá Premá presents Him with a garland. Another visiting Dádá steps forward, also with a garland. At this, Bábá exclaims with jovial excitement, “Another garland,” and after having them placed over His head He hands them to Ācárya Akśáyánanda and says, “I will smell them in the night”. Garlands presented to Bábá are later placed in His room and release their scent during the night hours.

Tuesday 18/3

Running late again this morning, Áshrava and I just miss Bábá going on field walk by only a few minutes. How does this keep happening? We are duly disappointed. Among the small group of márgiis there to see Bábá is Didi Ánandabratatii who this morning had presented Bábá with some tomatoes from Ánanda Sambodhi Women's Global Master Unit. She tells us how Bábá commented to her, "I have seen them there, but was unable to eat them", presumably referring to visiting the Master Unit, but not tasting the tomatoes growing there at the time.

Áshrava leaves with Didi Ánandabratatii and I wander over to chat with Dádá Kṛṣṇapriya for a while. As we are both going over to the Central Office, he asks me to walk with him. "Let's go this way," he says, "I'll show you a short cut." Off we go down Bábá's street, left at the end, across the road and down a small alleyway through the back of houses. After several twists and turns, I have no idea where we are, except I wouldn't go here by myself for fear of never finding my way out again.

Still, it is interesting seeing how local people live here. The long expanse of saris draped in brilliant brightness across bushes and lines to dry. Little kids rolling old bicycle tyres around their dirt backyard, whipping their backs with a small stick to keep them in motion. Scared, mangy cats stopping in their tracks in a crouch to look at me, then hurrying on their way. Rickshaw wallahs, their transport turned upside down as they replace their grimy bent and broken spokes with shiny new silver coloured ones.

The housing gradually tumbles down upon itself until we are walking on the edge of slums made up of dirty ripped plastic, woven bamboo sheeting and rusty corrugated iron. It is no longer an alley, but a dirt track traversing a plastics strewn wasteland bordering a body of water that seems to bubble with a black and green. We amble down a soggy dip in the path, picking our way on the dryer high points and as we come up I can see some more tatty bamboo shelters and the bitumen street ahead a couple of hundred meters away.

Walking towards us on the same path are three sadhus. Travelling *Shivites* it seems to me with tridents, faded dirty pale orange lungis and dreaded hair tied up in turban swirls of orange cloth. I immediately feel uneasy. Dádá is in front, I'm following. It will be a close pass on the narrow pathway. In my head my mantra starts pounding away keeping my mind from running crazy. What is this?

I look up as we draw close, each group giving a little to pass, straight into the eyes of the middle sadhu. It is like someone who hates you with a contempt that runs back generations of bad blood. His face is impassive, but his eyes sneer and I catch that small narrowing of the eyelids that signal the edge of an attack. I hold my breath and meter out my mantra. This passes in a matter of seconds, but is drawn into slow motion where I count every step, every breath.

As Dádá and I come up out of the swamp and on to the bitumen roadway amongst the suburban housing again, I blurt out, "What was that?"

Dádá, almost nonchalantly, with a mischievous smile on his lips replies, "*Avidyámáyá Tántrikas!*"

"What was going on?" I question again.

"They were just trying to psyche you out. Don't worry, just keep your mantra going, then they can't do anything."

Avidyámáyá Tántrikas are practitioners of the dark arts. They frequent graveyards and burning ghats and specialise in occult powers. They see yogis on the light path, called *Vidyámáyá Tántrikas*, such as Ananda Marga practitioners, as their adversaries.

A classic example of an *Avidyámáyá Tántrika* is seen in the story of Millarepa, Tibet's greatest Yogi. Millarepa, while a young child lost his father and his family fell under the care of an unscrupulous uncle, who confiscated the family land and placed Millarepa's mother and siblings into his servitude.

Millarepa, unable to tolerate this cruelty to his family, set upon vengeance. He had heard of great sorcerers who could do miraculous

things and were greatly feared. Millarepa snuck away to find such a master and learn the black arts, occult powers, with which to seek revenge upon his cruel and powerful uncle. Although his motives were freedom of his family and return of what was rightfully theirs, he also had a burning hatred of his uncle that drove him in his diligence to acquire occult powers.

Eventually he returned a consummate Avidyámáyá Tántrika. Sitting upon a hill overlooking his uncle's property, Millarepa called upon his power over the natural elements. He conjured up a storm that lashed his uncle's house, then hail rained down shattering everything and finally thunder boomed out and lightning struck the ground, trees and buildings. The uncle was terrified and beaten into submission having seen Millarepa command the elements against him. He returned all property and released the family.

Till this point Millarepa had been single pointed in his revenge. Now that he had completed this goal, he felt despondent. He had achieved his aim of freeing his family, but within himself he still burned with anger and hatred. What to do? What would become of him? What was his purpose now? Within this despondency rose another desire, fuelled with the same drive previously directed to Avidyámáyá, to find the answers to his reason for being, a greater purpose. Millarepa committed himself to finding a real Master, a great Guru, who could reveal to him the secrets of existence. He was now on the path of Vidyámáyá Tantra. He scoured all of Tibet until he found such a Guru, or really literally in Millarepa's case, such a Guru found him. For when the disciple is ready, the Guru appears.

In the evening Áshrava and I are back at Bábá's to greet Him when He returns from evening field walk. As His car pulls up, márgiis gather around. Bábá steps out amongst us and immediately says as if it is a pronouncement, "There was an incident in the time of King Louis of France that a large crowd gathered at the royal palace. What is French for 'royal'?" Bábá pronounced it as, 'roy-yal'. As no-one answers in a beat, He continues, "In French royal means king. The king called the Prime Minister and said, 'Why have so many people gathered

outside the palace?’ The Prime Minister replied, ‘They want bread.’ The King said, ‘Let them eat cake’.” As Bábá has been very comical and grandiosely gesturing during all this, we all laugh. Bábá walks off and He repeats, “Give them cake”. He is in a jovial mood tonight. When He gets half way to the door, He turns and says, “And what is the French for bread?”

Áshrava answers ‘paan’ in an Australian accent giving a long nasal ‘a’.

Bábá complements her on the correct answer, but then pronounces it accurately with a short ‘a’, as in ‘pan’. As Bábá leaves to go upstairs, we start doing kiirtana. With a big grin on His face, Bábá leans out over the window railing half way up the stairwell to look at us below. The four of us, seeing Bábá, but still doing kiirtana, have to lean backwards and look around the corner to see Him and nearly fall over. This funny pose of everyone leaning over backwards leads to peals of laughter on both sides and somehow we manage to continue doing kiirtana as Bábá proceeds up the stairs.



A Day of Darshans

Wednesday 19/3

During the morning, Bábá continues His Darshans on Yajña at the Central Office and is in a very jovial mood. He speaks only in Bengali.

Yajña – Languages and Scripts

Bábá explains that when the Aryans first entered India, they spoke Vedic languages. Vedic came from the word Veda, which came from the root word vid meaning to know. In every one thousand years, language will be transformed. He gives one example, the word jña (to know), previously vid, and changed over a five thousand year period, eventually became keno in the Latin. From this came the present word know.

Over time Vedic language gradually transformed and came to be called Prakṛta. This language evolved into several languages, in different parts of old India. Baba explains at length the languages and where they developed in India. He describes how the Aryans did not have scripts to write their language down and clarifies that script generally takes about two thousand years to change.

The Vedas are the ancient religious scriptures of Hinduism. There is much controversy and debate about these and Bábá sheds light on their history and how using the scripts they were written in can be used to determine their age. He says the first Veda was the Rig Veda, fifteen thousand years ago. Later, came Yajur Veda, five thousand years later, and then came Atharva Veda, ten to five thousand years ago.

Concluding, Baba goes back to the previous Darshan's subject, Prayag, the main city for the Aryans, and how it became very famous for the cultivation of knowledge. There were many conferences of scholars held there. One time, Bábá says, there was a conference to establish the prominence of ten Brahmin castes that were to be considered the very highest castes. These high Brahmin castes eventually ruled and exploited India.¹²

Bábá finishes this Darshan and all the márgiis are very pleased that He has once again decided to give these presentations. We hear that He will also give a Darshan later in the day and so go off to our lunch. After eating, we come back a little early to try and get a seat closer to the front. When Baba comes out and sits down, we are happily seated in close proximity.

Yajiṇa – The Three Vedas

In this afternoon session Bábá continues on from the previous Darshan topic on the Vedas. He explains that the three Vedic languages changed between fifteen thousand years to later than five thousand years ago. The language of Rig Veda was extremely hard to understand. Here Bábá quotes a long shloka and makes clear that almost every word in this shloka is virtually impossible to understand today as it has very few links with today's Sanskrit. The language of the Yajur Veda is comparatively easier to understand, being closer to present day Sanskrit. Atharva Veda is even easier to understand.

Around four thousand five hundred ago, there was a very great person in Prayag and his name was Krśṇa Dvaepayanvyas. For the first time, he divided the three Vedas, according to the ancientness of the language used in them, into the three Vedas. Later on, Sama Veda, comprising of the song portion of the three Vedas was created. Those people who performed the Yajiṇa had to be well versed in all the four Vedas.

Bábá clarifies that there were five jobs associated with the performance of the Yajiṇa ritual. One for each of the Vedas, and an overall supervisor. Although Yajiṇa was based on the

defective science that rain would develop from ghee smoke, it had a positive side. The perseverance and sincerity in those rituals related to Yajña evolved a systematic form of living and a development of music. The negative side of Yajña was its role in the beginning of the compartmentalisation of society.

Bábá then goes on to shed light on the influence of indigenous Tantra on the Vedas. He explains how the Atharva Veda was influenced by Tantra in the adoption of Brahma, Vishnu and Maheshvara, the three Tantric gods, as Vedic gods. This was the mythic adoption of the Tantric understanding of these three as three emanations of the one Parama Puruṣa.

Another area, Bábá explains, is Tantra's influence in the creation of a particular Brahmin caste title of Misra, meaning mixed. This title referred to those who were living in the daytime according to the Vedic system of performing Yajña, but at night were performing inner Tantra sādhaná, which had nothing to do with external ritualism.¹³

At the beginning of evening field walk, Āshrava offers a garland to Bábá, but the garland has been made a little smaller than usual at the markets. As Bábá tries to get it over His head, the garland gets caught on His glasses. Trying not to knock off the glasses, both Bábá and Āshrava struggle through a little comedy of extricating the garland and completing the process. This little drama puts a smile on everyone's face and even produces a few chuckles. A visiting márgii has brought along a small guitar, so Āshrava plays some kiirtana tunes in the meditation room while we wait for Bábá to come back.

When Bábá returns from field walk, everyone is doing kiirtana. While He walks up next to Āshrava and I, Bábá steps back with a little jump of surprise and amusement. Āshrava has swung around while dancing and doing kiirtana and her guitar neck has protruded out into His way, almost colliding with Him. Bábá deftly dodges it with a jumping sidestep, producing a few stifled laughs. Bábá then remarks on how her guitar seems to be suspended in mid air by itself. Her hands are above the guitar, together in namaskár while she dances, so the guitar

seems to be suspended by itself on her body. This is due to a very small neck-strap, which is hidden from view and holding the guitar from the middle of its body. What a funny evening this has been with both Bábá and Áshrava playing the clowns for us all.

Thursday 20/3

A small group of half a dozen márgiis including Áshrava and me are doing kiirtana while Bábá looks at the plants on His morning stroll around the garden. When He finishes, Bábá comes over to the left side of His car in the driveway, steps in and slides across to the opposite window. At this point our small group gathers around this side of the car, Púrña Premá, Áshrava and I in the front. Bábá leans to the opened window and says, “The water out the back is good”. Over the noise of the car motor being revved by the driver, we cannot hear clearly what Bábá is saying and shake our heads in response. He repeats this phrase a couple of times, but still we are not sure what Bábá means as we only catch partial words above the noise. The driver puts the car in a quieter idle and Bábá changes tack, “What is the Latin for water?” He inquires.

Clearly hearing this, Púrña Premá answers, “*Aqua*.”

“And in French?” Bábá answers himself, “*Eau*” and then spells it out, E...A...U, so that we cannot misconstrue what He is talking about. He continues with, “*l’eau de cologne*” and again “cologne”. He has now clearly brought our attention to the issue of water and continues, “I have tested the water and it is full of minerals. It is good for digestion.”

Púrña Premá asks, “Is this the water here, out the back Bábá?” referring to the well pump in the garden out the back of Bábá’s house.

“Yes. Have you tried any?”

“Yes Bábá”, Áshrava exclaims.

“We have it all the time,” I chip in.

“Good. They are doing a good thing” He expresses this to the other márgiis standing around in encouragement that they should also emulate our actions. With His point made, Bábá tells the driver to go.



Devotees waiting for Bábá in the Driveway. Áshrava is playing the guitar



Doing kiirtana while waiting for Baba to arrive



The backseat of Bába's car



The author surveying the garden. Behind is the water pump



Ācārya Akṣayānanda Avadhūta showing an orchid



Avadhūtikā Ānandabhāratī Ācārya (Aunty)



Kiirtana in the night-time



Bábá's car at the Central Office at Jodpur Park



Bábá's desk in the Central Office



Ácáryas in the Central Office



Boarding the buses for a trip to the Global Jágriti, Tiljala



Ácáryas arriving at the Global Jágriti, Tiljala



Bharata (Dr Burt Roberts) lays the foundation stone for the Global Jágriti



Ácáryas at the Global Jágriti, Tiljala



Bábá's residence at Lake Gardens



The meditation hall in Bábá's house

At this time in India, there is no bottled water available. I looked into using chlorine tablets, but heard that the taste was horrible. I have been told that urban tap water in India that is not boiled is to be considered as unsafe. Restaurants usually provide a glass of water, but we are reluctant to drink this, as it might not be boiled or they often wash the glass and leave plenty of untreated tap water in when they fill up with room temperature pre-boiled water. Our hotel is supplying us a safe jug of boiled water each day and in the morning for breakfast, they also give us a bottle of boiled milk from a supplier who comes to the front door of the hotel and milks the cow on the steps.

Only one time, did I let my guard down and drink a glass of suspect water when I stopped into a little sweet shop. Bengal is known for its wonderful array of sweets, lined up in little stainless steel trays stacked in long glass cabinets to view and choose from. I'm always partial to a *gulab jamun* or two, fluffy milk balls floating in a rich syrup of saffron and rosewater. There is also a staggering display of *halvah*, *laddu*, *rasmalai*, *burfi* and *sandesh*, each in a variety of flavours and colours. This day my water bottle was empty. The plate of super sweet pistachio burfi with a micro-thin sheet of real silver crowned on top (eaten as part of the dessert) had parched my throat and befuddled my mind. I grabbed the glass of water supplied with the sweets and downed it. Later that night the delhi-belly set in. Next day I was still at it, but on Ácárya recommendation I fasted, only taking the juice of the green coconut. Being merely a mild case of diarrhoea, the soothing green coconut juice worked wonders on my upset stomach in one day. This was the only time I ran into health problems in India. Motto – watch the water on and in anything not cooked.

Before evening field walk I am at the back garden of Bábá's house filling my water bottle from the pump and I look up to see Bábá at an open window brushing His hair while looking in a mirror. It is strange and intriguing to share a private, although stolen, moment in the life of this most public person, but I don't dwell on my voyeurism and go back to filling my water bottle. Later, when Bábá comes down for field walk, I am at the front of a line awaiting Him. He stops before me and

gives one of His all-knowing smiles, then proceeds on down the line namaskáring everyone. Bábá gets in the car, and is driven off.

I had heard that Bábá recommends márgiis wear a pratika, the Ananda Marga symbol, around their neck, hanging at the heart (*anáhata cakra*). This yantra emblem or symbol, the pratika, visually encapsulates the essence of the Ananda Marga ideology. It is made up of three ancient Indian symbols. The six-pointed star is composed of two overlaid equilateral triangles. The triangle pointing upwards represents action, or the outward flow of energy through selfless service to humanity. The triangle pointing downwards represents knowledge, the inward search for spiritual realisation through meditation. The rising sun in the centre of the triangles represents advancement and all-round progress. Positioned within the rising sun is the goal of the aspirant's spiritual life, represented by the swastika, an ancient symbol of spiritual victory, utilised in India and other countries for thousands of years. Thus, the star represents balancing the inner and outer aspects of your life, resulting in the rising sun of spiritual advancement and the swastika of victory on the horizon.

Parimal had told me how he has a day job as a jeweller and then will come to Bábá's house in the evening to do the VSS guard duty. "Parimal! With your jewellery business can you make a pratika for Áshrava and me to go around our neck?"

"Yes, certainly. How would you like it to be?"

"Can you do it in silver," Áshrava chimes in.

"Do you want it like a disk or medallion?" queries Parimal.

"No, make it like the star is cut out with the six points around the outside, but don't make the points too sharp," I add. Parimal pulls out a scrap of paper, rests on the black seat of his Enfield motorbike and draws up a pattern of the pratika to be made.

"I can put some colour where the rising sun is in the centre. How about red?"

“OK.” He will make the pratikas from silver with a thin silver chain looped through a hoop at the top point of the upward facing triangle.

“They should be ready in about one week,” he assures us.

While waiting, the electricity is suddenly cut off in our suburb as the power overload sweeps the city and is doled out to some and cut off to others. The Dádás run around frantically with torches to start the house generator, which always seems to have its own schedule for starting. Just as the generator kicks in with a cough and a chug, Bábá’s car approaches the gates. He seems to have impeccable timing to avoid all the chaos of the blackout and arrives just as light is once more established to the household. Bábá steps out of the car, does namaskár to everyone and exclaims, “I do much exercise, that is why I am perspiring.” The back of His shirt is soaking with perspiration from vigorous walking in the park.



In Search of a Guru

Friday 21/3

In the morning a Didi from France presents Bábá with a tin of chestnut puree as a gift. I notice that while greeting everyone gathered, Bábá also namastes the little boy next door. This boy shouts out his return namaste to Bábá with much glee. It is like this is the highlight of the boy's day. When Bábá is gone, Didi Ánandakaruná brings down a plate of *prasáda* for all the devotees. It is a mix of fruit slices and sprouted beans and seeds. This is food left over after being offered to Bábá. He has blessed it, turning it into *prasáda* and giving the food something more than its nutritional content. This food is considered holy. We eat it respectfully and reflectively, thinking of Bábá. Later, Didi, under Bábá's instructions, also takes a portion over to the small boy next door.

I am standing next to Dádá Akśayánanda while I eat and he says to me, "One-day this little boy had ran through the gates and jumped at Bábá, grabbing Him around the feet. Later he followed Bábá upstairs to His room and went to sleep in Bábá's bed. This child sees the attraction of Bábá without inhibition."

I had heard from Suviiir, another of the VSS guards, that in the past, some márgiis would dive at Bábá's feet in saśfaunga prañáma with the express purpose of grabbing hold of Bábá's feet firmly. This was for the misguided, some might say selfish, purpose of reducing their own saṁskáras. It is said that while holding the feet of the Guru, He will inadvertently absorb some portion of the devotee's latent karma. In some way the Guru is unable to refuse this effect. Hence it was resulting in Bábá having to experience that portion of saṁskára and was therefore becoming ill on a regular basis. The senior Dádás took

the step of instructing the VSS guards to be on the lookout for such behaviour from devotees and to prevent them from grabbing hold of Bábá's feet in such circumstances where it was not directly agreed to by Bábá. However, in this case, the small boy next door would have only grabbed hold of Bábá out of love as a small child would. He did not have this complex thinking about *saṁskáras*.

I follow Dádá Akśayánanda out to the back of the house where he is re-potting some orchids. Beside him is a small pile of broken brick chips, which he uses to pack around the orchid base to hold them into the ceramic pot. I sit down next to him in the shade and he narrates to me:

When I was very young I also had an innate attraction like that little boy next door, but I was a devotee of Kṛṣṇa before becoming a *márgii*. I was so much attached to Kṛṣṇa that whenever I wanted to see Him I could visualise Him in front of me as if He were there. That was the state of my mind at that time. Sometimes I would go to the burial ground at midnight for worshipping Kṛṣṇa. This would be under a banyan tree and it would be as if to play with Kṛṣṇa. I would try and catch Him and then He would run away, try to catch Him again and He'd run away. He would disappear and then appear again. Later I understood that this was a part of the subconscious mind. That was the state of my mind. I could never catch Him. At night-time, sleep did not come easily. I was always thinking of Kṛṣṇa, and I was not very interested in sleeping. I would sit and think and see Kṛṣṇa while I sat in meditation.

I was very interested to get initiation into spiritual practices, because without it one cannot progress in spiritual life. I was interested in seeking a Guru. I went to see several *tántrikas* and other gurus, but I did not find anything right for me, so I was not able to get initiation.

Every Friday I used to visit my maternal uncle. There, in the evening time, I would go to the burial ground nearby. I would keep a piece of iron in my book to keep away the ghosts. This was my dogmatic belief, my superstition. One night while in

the cemetery, I saw an old man wearing a very white uniform, dhoti and shirt in the Punjabi style, standing near some graves. This man called to me, 'Boy come, come.' I thought maybe that it was a ghost. He continued, 'My boy, you come; do not be afraid, I want to help you. You come; you come.' Putting my fear aside, I went to him. He told me, 'I will teach you something, some meditation.' At that time, I was about 12 years old. He taught me meditation. He told me I should do it always and to use the mantra he had taught me. I did not give it that much importance because my mind was always towards Krśña. I was not too much interested in it, and I practised it sometimes and not others. I was so attached to Krśña. There was so much pleasure for me to think of Krśña and imagine Him with me so intensely that it was as if He was really there.

I continued searching for gurus and tántrikas. However, when I went to these tántrikas, they were not willing to teach me and said that I had a Guru already, so I did not need their assistance. They would say, 'You do not need a Guru.'

I thought, 'Who is my Guru? Where is this Guru?'

One tántrika told me, 'A *Mahátántrika*, a great one, has initiated you. Whoever taught you, he is the Guru of all the tántrikas.' Then this tántrika said, 'He taught you in the burial ground.' I didn't understand what he meant at that time, but later this would all be revealed to me.

In 1962, in the month of December, a sádhu, an Avadhúta (senior yogic monk), came to my school. I was running an *Ajadin Club* for students and teachers at this time. The Avadhúta came in the early morning, at about 7am. As I saw him approaching from a distance, my mind was thinking, he could give me something. I touched his feet and did the prañáma. The only other time I had done this was to the old man in the burial ground after initiation.

This Avadhúta asked me to arrange a meeting at the school, but I asked him who would come at such short notice. Still, at his

insistence, I contacted as many people as I could to come and hear the Avadhúta talk. By 10am he was sitting doing meditation and the class was started by him. People were asking questions and he was answering them: ‘Concentration is very important; it is needed to develop spiritually. The mind must be concentrated, otherwise it will be scattered and your spiritual practice will not be successful.’

I thought, ‘I have to concentrate my mind and then call for God.’ Still, I didn’t give it as much importance as I should have. When the time came, this Avadhúta was not willing to teach me, he was initiating everybody else, but he did not wish to initiate me. Why not me? By this time, I was doing lots of work for him.

Finally, one day he decided to teach me, and gave me mantra initiation. To my surprise, the mantra was the same as the one the man in the graveyard had given me and I was thinking, ‘Who was that man?’ I had started sádhaná sincerely now and did as much as I could. Mentally I started a competition with the Avadhúta. If he did one hour of meditation, I would do two. Before, Krśńa occupied me. But after I started this sádhaná, Krśńa was not coming to me so much. I was mentally disturbed by this situation. I thought, ‘Was Krśńa angry with me? Was he not happy with this meditation?’ I would talk to Krśńa in front of His picture and weep. In my mind, there was an internal fight going on. Should I worship Krśńa, or do this sádhaná? Should I give up this sádhaná? After some time, I saw a man in white clothes in my mind. I was mentally upset, and this man would come in my mind now, and not Krśńa. I had a lot of conflict going on in my mind for about six months because of this.

One day another Dádá, an Avadhúta from Tripura State, came to the school to give a lecture to the meditation class. As he sat, he kept a picture standing in front of him. After the lecture, he asked me, ‘Do you know who is in this picture?’

‘Oh yes Dádá, I have been seeing him every day.’

‘How?’ he said, ‘The person in this picture has never been to this place.’

I told him, ‘In place of Kṛṣṇa, the man in the photo is coming in my meditation.’

He asked me, ‘Do you know who He is?’

I said, ‘No.’

Dádá explained, ‘This is our Guru, Bábá, and the Guru of the meditation class.’ Because at that time there were very few pictures available of Bábá, I had not seen one. I was previously thinking that the Guru of this sádhaná would be an old man with long hair and a beard. After seeing the picture, I thought, ‘Now I have my Guru.’ Then, it occurred to me, who is superior, Bábá or Kṛṣṇa. Nevertheless, I continued doing my sádhaná. Now I was interested to do the sádhaná and I was thinking that I wanted to see Bábá in the form of Kṛṣṇa; this was my desire.

Time passed. 1965, on the 15th of February, Bábá was supposed to fly to the town of Silchar for a programme of DMC. On the way, there was a stop for forty-five minutes at the Agartala airport in my town. This was the first time we were going to see Bábá physically. I was very interested. Students, teachers, professors, were all contacted and there were about 150 márgiis by this time. However, on this day, there was a strike declared by the bus owners in the city. From the city to the airport was about 13km. We were wondering how to get to the airport. It was not an easily walkable distance in the time.

Those that could get there by bike or scooter went. For many there was no way to get there. I was with 15 students. My mind was always that I have to see Bábá. I made a deal with God, that the plane would not land until the flag I was holding was also at the airport. I began running. Other boys also started running, but many could not keep up. I did not have a watch, so I did not know the time. All I knew was that I must keep running, no matter how tired or exhausted I became. Running, running,

running. Somehow, I reached the airport with only two other boys with me. I asked those already there if Bábá had arrived and they said He is just coming. I was so happy, He is landing now; I was so very happy. Somehow, I had made it on time.

The plane landed and Bábá disembarked. He met the márgiis present and then said to Dádá Vijayánanda, who was His PA accompanying Him at this time, ‘Let us go for a morning walk.’ The general márgiis and others who did not know Bábá or the procedure were unsure and concerned about the correct process, so stayed in the airport. I followed, but well behind, driven by much desire to do saśfaunga prańáma to Bábá. He was walking and walking. Bábá noticed me behind and remarked to Dádá Vijayánanda, ‘What is this little boy doing? What does he want?’

Dádá Vijayánanda inquired of me and I timidly replied that I wanted to do saśfaunga prańáma.

Not hearing, Bábá asked, ‘What is he saying Vijayánanda, what is he telling you?’

Dádá repeated, ‘Saśfaunga prańáma, Bábá.’

Bábá motioned His approval and said, ‘Okay, okay, come, come.’ First, offering the flower in my hands, I then prostrated myself before Bábá in saśfaunga prańáma.

As I rose, Bábá was telling Vijayánanda, ‘Do you know why our flight was late?’

He said, ‘No, I don’t know Bábá.’

Bábá continued, ‘Due to him our flight was late.’

I was thinking, ‘What does He mean?’

Bábá then narrated to Vijayánanda what I had been thinking – the plane would not land until the flag I was holding was also at the airport and how I was so determined to get to the airport. He narrated everything that had been in my mind. I was weeping and thinking He knows everything. Bábá continued, ‘Due to the

fog the planes could not take off or land at this airport. It is due to this little boy's determination the fog had come.' Bábá was explaining, 'My boy was coming running and he has so much pain in the legs that he is now not able to walk easily.' Although I was a young man of 20 or 21, I was wearing half pants, as was the custom at this time. Bábá bent down and touched me on my legs where I was experiencing pain, rubbing them up and down. As He touched these areas, the pain just disappeared. I was very pleased. I now knew I had the proper Guru.

Back in the airport, Bábá was narrating to the assembled márgiis about the concept of speed and pause : 'In society and missionary life, speed and pause is there.' At the same time, one old man was behind me. He kept interrupting telling me, 'You are very, very lucky, you have the Sadguru, so you should not leave Him.' He continued talking into my ear, 'Guru may leave you, but you should not give up on Him; you should always keep Him.' It was so much, I had trouble listening to the talk. Afterwards, when Bábá finished His talk, I turned around to see who this old man was. I could not find him anywhere. He had disappeared.

Dádá Akśáyánanda finished potting his orchids. The shade had shifted and the day's sun was becoming a little too hot to bear. Dádá said he would continue later about what happened next and how he became an Ácárya. I thanked him as he went into the house to continue his duties. Before I left to go to the Central Office, I went into the garage bathroom and washed with cool water from the tap. Although I was wet from head to toe, I just put my cotton shirt and trouser back on. A towel was not necessary. A walk to the Office in the intense heat and I would be nearly dry by the time I reached the end of the street.

In the early evening, giving myself plenty of time, I set off for the local markets to select a garland of flowers to present to Bábá. In the relative cool of the evening, the markets are bustling with locals shopping for everything from vegetables to plastic buckets, áyurvedic medicinal herbs to gulab jamun sweets (yum). The flower section of the markets is quite large with row upon row of stalls stacked with

a myriad of flowers and garlands hanging all over their roof rafters making a strikingly colourful display. Walking through, I browse the different garlands available, rich red-yellow marigold, soft waxy-white camellias, and fragrant frangipanis. Then I see a stall filled with tuberose and ask the stall owner if she can make a garland from these for me. I wait as she threads the flowers one by one, creating a circle of the subtly scented tiny trumpets of tuberose flowers. I make my way to Bábá's house where I stand with a few others and do kiirtana until Bábá descends for His evening activities. As He walks along the line of devotees, I step forward holding the garland up between my hands presenting it to Him. Bábá puts His hands out to me and I place the garland in His open hands. He accepts this reverently and places the garland to His forehead, holding it there for a moment, eyes shut, before handing it aside to Dádá Akśayánanda.

When Bábá returns from field walk He moves unhurriedly along a line of people in a slow shuffle so as to stop at each person and do an intense namaskár while looking deeply at each devotee. His intent is riveting. The simple gesture of palms together raised to the forehead and then to the heart repeated with each person in turn, done every time with the full weight of meaning. This is how namaskár is meant to be. Bábá is such a perfect example. No matter what He has been doing, how long or arduous the previous period of time, Bábá is always fully present, aware and engaged with the person or task before Him.

Saturday 22/3

Áshrava and I are walking up the road in the early morning heat headed to Bábá's house when we see His car, the old, but immaculate Dodge Desota, rounding the corner. Bábá has left early for His field walk. We stand on the roadside greeting Him with a namaskár. As His car approaches, a whisper escapes my lips, "Bábá!" and He turns around to look directly at us at that moment, smiling and returning our namaskár. Did He hear my whisper? Once He passes, we race off in the opposite direction towards the Central Office where Bábá will undoubtedly be going after field walk. When Bábá arrives there, He seems to be

containing a playful smile as He greets us. We follow closely behind Him up the stairs and into the Office, where we spend the morning talking with other márgiis while Bábá is attending to office duties in His room.

After lunch on the roof, Áshrava and I go walking down to P.A. Shah Road. The day has arrived to check out the state of our musical friend. Although we do not have high hopes, we have a little wish for something that can produce a melodious sound to the ear. But I am unattached and fully expect to find the same broken piece. We enter the music store bobbing and weaving our way through the hanging instruments to the counter where the old man sits as if he has never left his daybed. Smiling to see his foreign customers, he reaches down beside himself and pulls up the guitar. It is like there should be a ceremonial score to its rising from the dead – a blast of Shivite conch shells followed by horns and a stringed crescendo. The old man is a craftsman par excellence – he has joined the neck. No metal attachments. No added pieces of wood. He has fitted all the jagged splinters of wood on either side of the break perfectly back into alignment. Glued, sealed, sanded, varnished and restrung, I can hardly see the join.

It is a miracle, but the real miracle is when Áshrava picks up the guitar and starts to play. The sound is superb. This is a fine guitar. The old instrument maker beams to hear his work come to life. This is what he laboured for. We gladly pay the man for his skilled work and he asks only 150 rupees or the equivalent of \$12.50 Australian, an amazingly small amount for such masterly work. Intrigued by this astonishing refurbishment, I ask him more about himself and his shop. To our amazement this old man with his three metre wide shop is instrument maker to the likes of world-renowned sitar virtuoso Ravi Shankar and Ali Akbar Khan, master of the sarod. This is what I call Bábá's grace.

In the evening, our kiirtana bolstered by the new guitar, we are in fine form. Áshrava strums out a beautiful kiirtana tune and this musical background encourages everyone to sing with gusto, putting our hearts

fully into the kiirtana. Bábá walks down and generously smiles and nods His appreciation to our kiirtana before driving off.

Upon returning from the evening walk Bábá steps out of His car and states to the four of us gathered, “I have said many times that your kiirtana tune is very sweet. Is it on tape? You have made a tape?”

Áshrava replies, “Some of it Bábá.”

“You should put it on tape. I would like to listen to it at least once a week while I am in Calcutta. And in other countries I will listen by the physical cord [headphones].”

“Yes Bábá, we will make a tape.”

Bábá then walks a couple of steps further and addresses Púrña Premá; “You are drinking jol [Bengali for water] from the well? It is full of minerals. You are drinking from the well, the subterranean?”

“Yes, Bábá, all the time.”

“And I think it is a little...sweet, sweet tasting?”

“Yes, Bábá.” This now has me thinking there might be more to this jol than just clean drinking water. I think of it now as definitely Prasáda, holy water.

As Bábá walks off to go upstairs, I ponder the new project He has requested of us. “You should put it on tape. I would like to listen to it at least once a week ...” We are excited and overjoyed, but how to record this tape?



Dance of the Spiritual Warrior

Sunday 23/3

Bábá again leaves early for His morning field walk and we miss Him, so I race off to the Office by myself. Hurrying down the road a sensation grips me and I turn around to see Bábá's car approaching from behind. Reverently I stand and offer my namaskár. Bábá returns it with a smile.

Later when I reach the Office, a Dádá approaches me outside. He tells me that he was in the car with Bábá when they earlier passed me on the road. After Bábá had namaskáred, He said to the Dádá, "Is this boy late?"

The Dádá obligingly replied, "Yes, he is late Bábá."

Bábá countered with, "No, he is not late, I am early."

Bábá is already here and beginning the proceedings. I quickly take my seat at the back of the crowd. Bábá is beginning an early Darshan today. First He requests all the males to do the *táńđava* dance for Him. I line up with the other márgiis, facing Bábá at the front. Our arms are spread out to the side. I imagine holding a skull in my left hand representing death and destruction, in my right a sword expressing struggle and the spirit to fight death and defeatism.

The great Yogi Shiva created this exercise several thousand years ago as a warriors' dance. Its' representation is seen all over India in the dancing Shiva Nańarája statues. Shiva is depicted one leg raised in a jumping dance position surrounded by a verticle circle of flames. This táńđava Shiva created is a physico-psycho-spiritual exercise acting on all these three spheres – fortifying the body, strengthening the mind with courage and drawing the practitioner towards the spiritual. Bábá

has expressed the ideation of tándava as, “I must keep on fighting against destruction through struggle itself.”¹⁴

As the *tá, tá, dhin, tá* rhythm is called out, we all kick our right leg high sideways and up to the left while hopping on the left foot. I now bounce a change of feet, kicking my left foot and knee high and continue this alternating jump as the crowd rumbles with shouts of *Bábá náma kevalam*. The tempo slowly increases and I summon all my stamina, determined to push my body into unflagging high jumps for as long as the dance is called for. This represents my struggle, internally against all that might oppose my determination to be victorious in my spiritual pursuits and externally in the cause of justice and human rights in the world. I pound the floor with my feet and jump flying in the air. It seems at times that I am not even touching the ground at all as I bounce from one foot to the other. In the heat, sweat is pouring from me and I grab my breath in short gasps, concentrating on keeping on going. On the ending command we all jump in unison high in the air to land in a squatting position. There is silence. I shakily rise, invigorated by this powerful dance, not unlike the New Zealand Maori *Haka* in its intensity. Done in Bábá’s presence, tándava is a fierce experience I will take with me. I settle down, hot and profusely sweating from the tándava and after a few minutes Bábá begins His Darshan continuing on with another area of Yajña.

Yajña – The Fire

Bábá describes that Yajña is of two types, temporary, after which the sacrificial fire would be extinguished and permanent, where the fire would be maintained twenty-four hours a day. In those days, to create fire was a difficult task and to maintain it permanently gave that person a very high position within the highest caste of Brahmins. These people were given the name of Ekarsii Rśi and considered a highly blessed person.

In the process of maintaining the fire, the Ekarsii Rśi would recite mantras constantly. This association of the fire and the mouth reciting developed a system that when that Ekarsii Rśi died, the same fire, which had been carefully maintained by him,

would be touched at the mouth of that person at the time of last rites. People still follow this in India today, but Ananda Marga doesn't support this practice, as it is simply tradition without the meaning and an ugly sight.

Bábá goes on to reveal how the social injustice system was perpetuated with the development of further caste positions in association with the Yajña rituals. If someone did not maintain the many rituals, they could even be demoted into the untouchable class at the very bottom.¹⁵

In the afternoon Āshrava and I go with Dádá Kṛṣṇapriya to Dakshineswar Kali Temple, the site where Calcutta's mystic saint Ramakrishna spent his time and gained his enlightenment. We take the train to the far north of the city, on the rural outskirts by the eastern banks of the Hoogly River, as the Ganges is called as it passes through Calcutta. The temple complex consists of a nine-spired main temple and a huge courtyard bordered on the far side by twelve smaller Shiva temples. While we wander through these temples I contemplate that they were built based on a dream of Kali requesting this temple and dedicated to an aspect of Kali, Bhavatarini, which means, 'She who takes Her devotees across the ocean of existence'. Ramakrishna, a tántrika practitioner, was steeped in bhakti, in devotion to Kali, as his path and was often at loggerheads with the traditional Brahmin priests who managed the temple complex. He was frequently in deep states of contemplation. When once asked by his devotees what samádhi was like, he replied, as he tried to express the inexpressible, "It's like...It's like...like..." and then he fell into a deep samadhi. We go down to the riverbank, outside the temple area to an old Banyan tree to sit and meditate. This is regarded as the spot that Ramakrishna spent his time doing his sádhaná and where he attained nirvikalpa samádhi.

Although we are late coming back, Bábá has still not left for evening field walk. He comes out and gets into the car. As there is only one other márgii with Bábá, Dádá Rámánanda quickly indicates that I should also go. Surprised, I quickly scoot onto the middle of the front seat and am given Bábá's drink box to hold on my lap. As the box is open, I take the

opportunity to peek in, noting that it contains green coconuts, ice water and a white towel. Suviir, the VSS guard, sits next to me. Báábá sits behind the driver and an Indian márgii sits next to Him. Báábá inquires, “Is there any other boy?”

Dádá Rámánanda replies, “No Báábá.” and we drive off to Gol Park and the Lake area near to Báábá’s house.

After a short drive around some of the suburban area, Dilip, the driver, pulls up outside the gates to Lake Gardens Park. It is dark and quiet. The immediate trees are illuminated by a solitary park streetlight. Everyone, except Dilip, gets out of the car and with Báábá in the lead we march off through the gates at a stiff pace right from the beginning. We walk along bitumen-paved walkways wide enough for a car, with one VSS guard riding a motorbike slowly in front of the group and another walking on Báábá’s right. The other márgii is to Báábá’s left holding an umbrella over Him, I am told later, to protect Báábá from the droppings of any night creatures in the trees or the air. I walk just behind Báábá.

Báábá is setting a brisk stride that would these days be called a power walk. His short, rotund body is pumping along at a pace that is a challenge to keep up with. I had heard and Báábá has also commented, that He does vigorous walking exercise. The thought occurs to me as to how much He will do. Discreetly, as we start out, I look at my watch under the streetlight to time His walk. He is so intent on the walk, up and down the park’s bitumen walkways, that there is no conversation. When we reach what I think is the halfway point of His walk, Báábá just spins around on the spot and begins walking at full pace back again. I quickly jump to the side out of Báábá’s way then follow on again, this time walking to the side of the márgii with the umbrella so I don’t get caught out again and inadvertently bump into Báábá as He turns. I glance at my watch. It is dark in the park at this point. There is no streetlight to see the time and no light on my old watch. I think that I will just check when we arrive back at the car. This process of a quick walk up a pathway and a spin around to come back happens a few times.

The VSS guard always has to be on Báábá’s right and the márgii with the umbrella to the left. So when Báábá, unannounced, spins around on

the spot, these two people have to cross over behind Bábá. This changing places is a quick comedic shuffle. Often they bump into each other and tangle in the umbrella as they struggle to change places and match stride with Bábá. By this time, Bábá is ten paces ahead in the other direction and we have to swiftly catch up and get back into position.

It is very pleasant walking along the lakeside on a warm Indian summer night, glow-worms winking near the lake edge, moon reflected in the water. I am walking now to the side of the márgii with the umbrella, four of us abreast. My only wish, as I trail along beside or behind the trio, is that I can walk next to Bábá. This thought keeps dancing around in my mind, distracting me from the beauty around me and being in the present moment with my Guru. Finally, I conclude that I need to give up this desire. To cease the chattering of my mind. To be here with what I have. In appreciation of what I do have – the incredible blessing of walking with Bábá on a glorious summer night next to the lakes – walking with the Master.

Immediately as I embrace this realisation and spread the calmness of my attention about me, the márgii with the umbrella sidesteps some object in his path. At this opening, Bábá, almost imperceptibly, uses the opportunity to shift His gait and move so that He is walking next to me. How did He do that? Again it is brought home to me, that when I release my desire and become unattached, when I no longer crave for something, it automatically comes to me. Give up what you want and you can have it, if that is what you need.

Finally, we arrived back at the gates to the park. Dilip has everything ready. Bábá sits on the edge of the open back seat facing out of the car and is handed a cloth to wipe the sweat off His brow and face. The other márgii and I stand at a little distance either side of Bábá and fan Him with two small bamboo fans. He sits catching His breath while we waft cool breezes across Him. Dilip hands Bábá a cool drink of water. Bábá calls the Indian márgii closer and talks to him in Bengali for a while.

It is then that I realise I have forgotten to look at my watch when we returned so I can calculate Bábá's exercise time. Just then, Bábá finishes talking to the Indian márgii and gestures for him to step away.

Bábá calls me over to Him, talking quietly, “Jiṇáneshvar, it was light training tonight.”

“Yes, Bábá.”

“We have done about two miles tonight. I have been walking for half an hour at about four miles an hour.”

A bit stunned at the answer to my unspoken question, I respond, “You do this every night Bábá?”

“Yes, and sometimes in the morning I run.”

“You run?”

“Yes. Do you do any running?”

“Sometimes, Bábá, but not enough.”

“It is not regular?”

“No, Bábá.”

“Then it is not exercise.”

“I should do more and follow your good example.”

“Often my márgiis are so busy with work that they cannot find time to exercise.”

It’s another one of those ‘Zen slaps to the head’ that awaken the novice disciple. Bábá has just told me, in some detail, what I was curious to know about the extent of His exercise.

Here I am focusing on the trivia of how much time Bábá takes to do exercise and He obliges me with specific details of His regime, unasked. Is this what I really wanted from my Guru? I could have requested anything from Him in knowledge, wisdom or life direction and I end up with the fact that He walks at four miles an hour for half an hour. Never-the-less, in little ways like this, Bábá shows me that He knows what I think or desire. Bábá does this in a discreet manner such that no one else here would realise. From this I learn the lesson to focus my mind on what I really want, to drop unnecessary desires and that God will provide me what I need.

Dilip packs up the drink basket and everyone gets into the car to drive off. Bábá directs the driver to detour and go past the WWD residence to see Aunty. Because of her ill health, Aunty is unable to easily leave the residence, so Bábá often drives by. The car slows down as we approach and the internal light is turned on. As we pass, Aunty can be seen on the upper balcony with some other women. Bábá leans forward to the window and gives a slow, high namaskár in greeting her. Bábá speaks to me, “Jiṇáneshvar...?” followed by something about the Didis. For some reason I cannot understand what He is saying. Bábá repeats the statement, but I’m still in the dark. The VSS guard finally gives an answer to Bábá and later I am told by Suviir that Bábá was commenting to me, “There are the Didi’s on the balcony.”

As we drive on back to Bábá’s residence, He asks me, “Jiṇáneshvar, do you know Jayanta? What is he doing?” Jayanta is a márgii in Australia. “Working for Prout, Bábá.”

“And how is he?”

“He is working hard, Bábá. All the márgiis in Suva Sector are waiting for you to come.” I was referring to the long awaited and planned for visit of Bábá to Australasia, to Suva Sector. I was indicating our desire and also hoping for a positive response from Bábá. He does not comment, but proceeds to do a momentous namaskár with such slow deliberation that it seems to me He is greeting every márgii in that wide section of the world.

We arrive back at the house and as Bábá gets out of the car, He calls one Dádá waiting in the driveway over to Him. Immediately Bábá begins explaining to him as if they had been in a continual conversation, “A person may be an intellectual, but not necessarily a Vipra. An intellectual must be doing their duty to society to be called a Vipra. Do you follow?”^H

“Yes, Bábá.”

“This will be a new appendage to Prout.” It is like Bábá picks what a person’s concern or question is, conscious or unconscious, and responds to it.

Bábá walks along the line of márgiis in the driveway. He stops before Púrńa Premá who has been playing the guitar that Áshrava and I recently had repaired. He says to her, “Your tune this afternoon was very sweet”. Motioning with His head, Bábá queries, “What is its particular name?”

Uncertain, Púrńa Premá mumbles an inconclusive reply, thinking Bábá means the name of the kiirtana tune. Again Bábá asks, “Do you have a name, particular name”, this time pointing to the guitar.

Believing she understands, Púrńa Premá naively answers, “Guitar, Bábá.”

Bábá laughingly replies, “I know it is a guitar, but do you have your own name. It is your pet, your pet guitar.” “Yes, Bábá.”

“You should have a name for your pet guitar.” Bábá says something in Bengali, but we do not understand and Áshrava requests, “Will you give a name, Bábá.”

He seems not to hear and repeats, “You should have a particular name.”

Áshrava replies, “Yes Bábá. We will give it a name.” Bábá nods and turns to leave, apparently not hearing the request for a name. Later Áshrava, Púrńa Premá and I discuss what Bábá has suggested trying to think of possible names for the guitar.

Monday 24/3

Next morning Áshrava and I arrive extra early to make sure that we catch Bábá before He leaves. We sit in the meditation room and consider more ideas for a name for the guitar around the theme of ‘sweet’, as Bábá has always said our kiirtana tunes were so sweet sounding. Púrńa Premá and Shivaprabhá join us to brainstorm a name. Eventually we choose ‘*Madhu Giita*’ as *madhu* is Sanskrit for sweet and *giita*, although meaning song, was a pun on ‘guitar’ giving *Madhu Giita/guitar*. The meaning for us is ‘the guitar that sings the sweetness of God’.

Bábá comes downstairs for field walk and stops amongst the waiting márgiis and looks at everyone. He looks at me for some time and I greet Him with a namaskár. Then Bábá asks me, “Have you received a translation of the speech”, referring to yesterday’s Darshan.

“Maybe today, Bábá”, I reply.

“Are you pressing them?”

“Yes, Bábá.”

“You should have an immediate English translation.”

When Bábá gets into the car, He sits there looking at us and I whisper quietly to Púrña Premá, who is closest to the car window, should we tell Bábá the name we have chosen. Before she can reply, Bábá leans forward to the window and addressing the three of us says, “The guitar, it should have a name. Its name is ‘Madhu’ – sweet.” Amazed we reply, “Yes, Bábá.” but also put the query, “Madhu Giita?” Bábá ignores our punned addition and motions the driver to go. We talk amongst ourselves, thrilled that He has picked up on our thinking about the name, but has suggested the shortened version of ‘Madhu’ rather than our flippant one of ‘Madhu Giita/guitar’. We decided it is always good to go with the Guru’s direction and the guitar is christened with the name of ‘Madhu’ and left in the meditation room as our donation to all who wish to perform kiirtana with a guitar.

Later we travel over to the Central Office where Bábá will be giving a Darshan. I am eager for Him to request tándáva from the brothers in the audience and am disappointed when it is not required. Bábá settles Himself on His raised platform before a full room of márgiis and after meditating for a while, begins the Darshan in Bengali.

Yajña – Atharva Veda Shloka

He begins with reciting a shloka from the Atharva Veda. Bábá then goes on to explain that this shloka has two different interpretations. One, a mundane interpretation and the second, a spiritual interpretation.

Bábá clarifies that the common understanding of the first line is that it is encouraging the caste system in the mention of the caste of untouchables. The spiritual meaning is that the wording ‘untouchable’ is referring to Parama Puruśa who is above everything and He cannot easily be achieved, He is thus untouchable. In this way Bábá goes through the various lines and words in this shloka and expounds upon the commonly held mundane meaning and the harder to understand inner spiritual meaning.¹⁶

We are at our usual post come evening, at the guardhouse near the gate, doing kiirtana, but this time there are many people here to see Bábá. To add to the confusion, one young boy has fallen on the steps and cut his head. There seems to be blood gushing everywhere and no one knows what is happening, with yells, shouts and tussling all around. In the midst of this, Bábá starts coming down the stairs. The boy, who has apparently been lying unconscious on the ground, suddenly briskly gets up and does namaskár to Bábá. Bábá speaks something to the boy and then goes on field walk. What has just happened? It was like a raging storm suddenly dropped to a silent lull when Bábá walked through. He was the eye of the hurricane, the still, serene centre of a turbulent world. On His return and going up the stairs, He turns and says to us pithily, “Kiirtana tune was sweet, melodious”.



Concentrating on the Centre of the Storm

Tuesday 25/3

Next morning, Báábá's house is awash with many márgiis arriving to see Him. In addition, He has called all workers (Ácáryas) for reporting from around the world and they are now flying into Calcutta, many coming this morning to the Lake Gardens residence. The grounds are teeming with people seeking a vantage point to see Báábá or preferably namaskár Him directly. To me this is a little jarring compared to my previous more intimate moments here at Báábá's residence.

After some time Báábá comes downstairs. When He is seen at the doorway Báábá is greeted by a wave of namaskáring and loudly calling márgiis, "Báábá, Báábá, Báábá. Devotees are overcome with excitement at seeing Him. They cry, "Here Báábá. Namaskár Báábá". A few senior Ácáryas and the VSS bodyguards keep people at bay and give Báábá room to move unhindered. He walks past His car and does a circuit of the front garden to admire and check on all the exotic plants that He is growing. The márgiis crowd on the garden side of the driveway to seek His attention with more loud shouts of "Namaskár" and "Báábá, Báábá" as He quietly walks among the plants. Some márgiis have travelled from afar and are overcome with emotion at seeing their Guru, the object of their devotion.

I stand on the other side of the car farthest from the crowd and Báábá, content to observe the márgiis calling for His attention and vying for positions. I have heard it said that devotees should either stay at the back, or attempt to be nearest to the Guru, but not to resent what the other party chooses to do. Either way, hold one pointed to your devotion

and ideation. I prefer to stay back from the crowds when I can, content to hold my ideation from a distance.

As Bábá comes back from His inspection of the garden, VSS make way for Him to reach the car. He steps into the rear and slides across the seat to the other side. I am there at His window to greet Him with hands raised in namaskár. Unexpectedly, the crowd stays on the other side of the car looking through the windows and calling keenly to Bábá. The devotees seek that moment of recognition or opportunity to personally deliver their sincere namaskár to their Guru.

In the evening we are surprised to find that the crowds are completely gone and once again there is just Púrña Premá, Shivaprabhá, Áshrava and I in the forecourt to serenade Bábá with our kiirtana tunes. When Bábá does come down, He stops before us and does a little namaskár to each person in turn. This simple and intimate act underlies why I am here. To express my gratitude to that Supreme Consciousness manifest so beautifully in this man. His namaskár to me has a power and intent that cannot be denied. I am alternately shamed by my own shallowness and buoyed to see His simple, but profound example. Is this enlightenment, to live your life such that simple little acts are charged with meaning and become the foundation for a life of greatness? This man whom millions call their Guru, takes the time to greet me with respect and humility as if I mattered in the scheme of big things and visions. This is the sign of a great person and Bábá is a complete example of the spiritual life He professes. Bábá steps into the back seat of the Desota and waits to leave.

There is no one here designated to go on field walk this evening or they have not arrived. The Ácárya and VSS guard begin a discussion as to what to do. At the same time I am thinking “Me, Bábá, me”. The discussion ends and the Ácárya turns and almost reluctantly motions to me to get into Bábá’s car. Inside myself I am jumping up and down and I cheerfully climb into the back seat next to Bábá. I am His sole passenger, besides the VSS guard and the driver, both in the front. As we drive off, Bábá begins talking to VSS in Bengali for some time

and I just soak up the atmosphere, pleased with this opportunity to be with Bábá. Sitting with Him intensifies my concentration like a deep meditation session and my mind oscillates between stillness and a blankness that borders on just being spaced out.

After a while Bábá asks, “Jiṇāneshvar, you were with me before?” I just look at Bábá, vaguely trying to engage my mind and comprehend what He has said. Bábá continues, “The other night, we went on walk?”

Little cogs whirr in my brain and I lamely reply, “Yes, Bábá.” I can see why the Ácárya was reluctant to send me on field walk. At times like this I’m not much of a conversationalist. I either have a raging mind thinking all the time or it just doesn’t seem to be there. Why can’t I engage Bábá with some intriguing philosophical question or at least something like normal conversation.

“And was it a pleasant trip?”

“Yes, it was very pleasant, Bábá.” I feel a certain unreality to events and it seems that the same person has spoken the questions and the answers. Bábá continues talking in Bengali with the VSS and shortly we arrive at the park and alight for a walk along the lake road. Bábá’s walk is very brisk tonight and I speed alongside Him, holding the umbrella above His head so that no nesting birds in the widespread trees overhead may soil Him.

Upon returning to the car Bábá exclaims to me, “This is like my second bath,” indicating His sweat soaked shirt. I am at a loss for words in His presence and pick up one of the fans as He sits on the outside edge of the car seat. I fan Bábá while He takes a cold drink of water and wipes His sweat-drenched face with a handkerchief. Again, indicating His shirt, He says, “It is soaked right through. And how are you also? I think you are like this also?”

“Yes, Bábá.”

“Walking is good exercise. It was not so light exercise tonight. Did you like it?”

“It was a very nice walk tonight, Bábá. Good exercise.”

“But not as good as in the winter, and summer is coming. It will not be so good.”

I just don’t know what to say. My head just spins. If I could bring it to mind should I ask some question like: “What were my previous lives Bábá?” “What career path would be best suited to me Bábá? When will the world have a just society Bábá?” As my mind broaches the concept of asking Bábá a question it just keeps growing in the enormity of what could be asked and I get a little disassociated, more spaced out. It’s like playing that child’s game, ‘If you had three wishes, what would you wish for’. My friends would say a cricket bat, a car, an icecream or a range of items or experiences. From as young as I can remember, I always replied, “An infinite number of wishes.” Being with Bábá just send my mind in that direction.

We climb back into the car and proceed to Bábá’s house. On the way, He says, “It is good walking when it is cool. In the Alpine areas, France, Germany, and Italy, it is very pleasant to walk.” As Bábá has never been to Australia, I am thinking of asking Him when He will come and that it would be nice walking in the Australian bush or mountain regions. Bábá pre-empts me and asks, “Jīñāneshvar, is it autumn in Australia now?”

“Yes, Bábá”

“And where is the coolest place there?”

“The Snowy Mountains, Bábá. It is very cold.”

“Is it cold, snow, all the year round?”

“Yes,” I say with very little knowledge.

“The summer is coming here and it will be monsoon. It will be rainy season in the summer in Australia?” Thinking of my experience in the south of Australia I reply, “No, Bábá. In the winter is the rain.”

“Oh..., in the winter?” I caught Bábá’s surprised inflection in this last statement and correct what I have told Him, realising that He undoubtedly knows very well more about Australia than I do. “In the north of Australia they have rain in the summer, Bábá.”

“Ah, yes. It is a very big country. In the south, Tasmania is near the South Pole. And in the west, in the deserts, it is very hot in the summer and very cold in the winter.”

When we arrive back and alight from the car, Bábá says, “Jiṇáneshvar, tonight was heavier exercise”. My mind is drifting and I stare blankly at Him without understanding. So He repeats and points with His finger as if at each word, saying, “Tonight ... was ... not ... so ... light ... exercise.” Am I that out of it? Coming to life, I register and quickly answer, “Yes, Bábá. It was heavier than before.” Bábá walks off to the stairwell and I half imagine Him shaking His head. I am not such a brilliant conversationalist for Bábá on His field walks.

I join Áshrava, Púrña Premá and Shivaprabhá to sing the bhajan song, ‘*Oh sweetest Bábá, Divine lover*’. As Bábá reaches the stairway door, He turns and says, “There is only one Divine Love. But there are two wonders in the world. First, one is that all these little girls and boys can sing. The second wonder is that I cannot sing.” Smiling and chuckling to Himself, Bábá then ascends the stairs as we burst forth into full song.



Bábá will Look After You

Wednesday 26/3

When we arrive in the morning to greet Bábá on His way to morning field walk, there is a group of twenty or thirty márgiis in Bábá's front yard, but nothing like the enormous crowd of yesterday. Bábá comes out and spends a lot of time walking around the garden giving instructions to Dádá Akśayánanda about how best to tend the plants. He moves closer to the driveway and points down at the pots. Dádá Akśayánanda squats down and pulls out a small pot. It is a brilliant yellow flowering orchid and he hands it to Bábá. As Bábá stands examining this orchid, the waiting márgiis, in their devotional enthusiasm, surge forward to be closer to Him. VSS guards and an appointed Dádá encourage the devotees to keep to the driveway so they do not inadvertently trample the gardens or crowd upon Bábá.

During this, the car is driven out of the garage up to the large driveway gates to await Bábá. There are no márgiis near the Desota, their attention fully on Bábá, still in the garden area. It is as if Bábá is taking more time today and giving the gathered márgiis plenty of opportunity to gaze upon Him. I can see by their faces that some people come with a burning question or request or problem that they hope may be solved by this visit. Many others are content to look upon Shrii Shrii Ánandamúrti, the Embodiment of Bliss and vocally or silently call out their accumulated devotion and longing for the Supreme embodied before them.

Knowing the procedure, I position myself once again at the back driver's side window of the car to greet Bábá when He gets into the rear. Finished with the garden tour, Bábá indicates that He will come over

to the car now and the guards begin to make a way through the crowd. Seeing this, many devotees run over to Bábá's car and jam-pack around every part.

I was standing alone at the window, now there is a crowd of twenty people pressing around me, hoping to catch a glimpse of Bábá up close. He climbs into the car from the opposite side and slides across to sit at the window where I am stationed, but He is in conversation with Dádá Rámánanda and faced away from where I am waiting. From the back of the crowd behind me I hear a frantic call of someone trying to get through the bunched group with some urgent matter that must be attended to. This márgii squeezes his way through the tightly packed group. When he nudges me, I move left to the rear of the car to let him into my place with what must be an important message for Bábá. I respect the urgency of the matter and releasing any attachment on having the prime position at the window, step aside.

Then it becomes clear to me that this person, overcome by devotional fervor, has used this call as a way to get to the window past everyone else in front. Themárgii raises his hands in namaskár and calls out frantically to Bábá to gain His attention. Bábá is oblivious to the drama and still looking in the opposite direction, talking with Dádá Rámánanda. The guard swings the huge gates open, but realises the driver has parked too close and the gates will not open sufficiently. Dilip is instructed to reverse so this can be done. He reverses just enough for the gates to open fully and this places me again at Bábá's window. Exactly at this moment, Bábá finishes talking and turns around to give me a lovely namaskár just as the car drives off. Such is His grace and His liilá (Divine play).

While the crowd of devotees begin to disperse, I ask Parimal, the VSS guard why there was none of this crowd here last night. He says that all the Indian márgiis and Ácáryas stayed away last night because of a CBI (Indian secret police) investigation that is harassing márgiis at the Central Office for any visa or I.D. irregularities, a leftover from the State of Emergency days. We had not been told to stay away. Luckily we had also not come under the scrutiny of the investigators.

Dádá Akśáyánanda is still tending to the plants and I take the opportunity to ask what were Bábá's directions to him about the garden. "Bábá was indicating which plants needed attention. He never misses anything with the welfare of the plants and always asks me what are their botanical names and specifications. I can never remember them all. Bábá knows all about each and every plant and gives me detailed instructions on each one."

A little concerned about Parimal's revelation of the CBI presence, I check with Dádá, "Should we be careful about the CBI harassment? Is there any problem?"

"No, no. Bábá will look after you."

My slight grimace shows my continued concern and Dádá motions me over to a shady spot where we sit down. He continues:

I have seen so many times how Bábá has looked after márgiis and also myself. There is no serious problem at this time. Do not worry. Not like back when there was the Ranchi problem in 1971 and even then Bábá looked after so many. At that time, CBI had arrested everybody. I was also on the list, but was not arrested. I don't know how I go away with it. I was sitting and doing sádhaná alone and at the same time police came and searched the buildings several times. But they did not find me. They never saw me and in this way, I was saved. It was like I was invisible. I don't know how it happened.

I was upstairs and overheard CBI downstairs talking and then I understood there had been a raid. They were discussing that the police department would raid again the next day. The same night I made my plan to leave the place. So they could not identify me, I covered my saffron robes in an old blanket. In this way, I went to Varanasi on the train and hid with some márgii sympathisers. There was a bogus warrant against me issued in Patna on a charge of attempt to murder. Because of this and on Bábá's instructions, I received directions to move to Maharashtra State and change my name to Akheswar. Under that name

I would come to Patna to see Bábá. CBI was not able to identify me. Then I stayed in the same quarters. That night, police came again, but the main light switch was off at nighttime and they could not see me. From then on, whenever there was news of a pending raid, I would leave the building. Daytime I would go see Bábá, nighttime I would come back. On 29th December 1971 Bábá was arrested on trumped up charges and He would stay in jail until 2nd August 1978.

In 1975, Indian Government declared the State of Emergency. All political leaders, communist leaders, márgiis were all being arrested in raids. This time, I knew how to save myself. CBI came to the office, posted guards and checked the rooms. Then they produced a list and began calling everybody. I quietly positioned myself sitting under a table and began meditation. After everyone was called and CBI left, I came out. Many Ácáryas had been taken. Surprisingly, my name was not listed, but I was still in danger of arrest. Police guards were posted at the front of the building to watch for anyone. The backside of the building was unlocked so I could come and go. Then one day, I had no money left and had to leave the place. I was praying to Bábá to give rain. In the evening time, there was heavy rain. I found a large raincoat and wrapped in it, looking like an old man. Like this I went right out in front of the police and none asked me anything. I called a taxi, but the driver thought maybe I was a beggar and asked did I have money. I checked my pockets and found 5 rupees. This was sufficient for him to take me away. His grace was there, so the rain came. Despite it being so hot, I did not open my raincoat. In the taxi I went to some márgii's house where I changed into street clothes from my Ácárya's uniform. From then on, I was working underground, doing social service and doctoring work, as I am a doctor of Homeopathic medicine. Also I was raising issues of injustice under the Emergency to Members of the Legislative Assembly and other political leaders. There was now a warrant out on me. Police were searching for me. Warrant of thousands of rupees if anyone could identify me.

At a time such as this, during the emergency period, it was the time to realise the Guru and how He helps in times of need. Wherever I went, everyone was very sympathetic to me and I was respected. Police came once to my residence and asked the Didis where I was. The sisters said they did not know. There were five sisters, five Didis and the police took custody of them and prepared to take them to the police station. The local people objected to this, saying, 'They are not thieves. You police are going after good people instead of the real criminals. Let these good sisters go.' The police were intimidated and released the Didis, but they still cautioned the house owners to keep watch of these girls. It fell on deaf ears and they refused to help. Later in the evening, the Didis left that place and went to another secret house, a safer place. Without Bábá's help this could not have been done. There were so many incidents I could recount.

Then in 1977, on 26 February, I was arrested. There was an underground meeting where all of the Dádás were getting together in Maitibhagan. I went from Howrah, then out to Maitibhagan on the train, getting off at Goakpur station. I got down from that train. Some people had been watching my movements and I was seen when I got off the train. I understood later that there was some informer and they could harm me. I got on a bus, but they rang the police, who came. They took me to the police station. I had no idea what would happen to me in a State of Emergency – torture? Anything was possible.

They searched my briefcase and found some circulars inside opposing the Government. The policeman asked me where I got this. I said yesterday I was sleeping in Howrah station, and a boy gave it to me. I told the boy I could use this for padding under me while sleeping. I realized I had some addresses on me, so I told the police I wanted to use the toilet. When I went, I put them in the toilet, but I had trouble getting them to flush away. Police asked me why I was taking so long in the toilet. I honestly told them I was busy flushing all my addresses, phone numbers

and information regarding the other Dádás down the toilet. They banged the door open, but too late to save anything. They asked if I had anything else. I told them I had a diary, and they told me that if I gave them this that I could go free. Just then the CBI officer was called away for something important.

I was left alone and being held in a glass-surrounded room where I could constantly be viewed by the guards outside. Slowly, slowly I opened the brief case and pulled out my diary. I put my head down and started eating the pages of the diary. Almost all of them I had eaten. This was very difficult, as I had no water and no saliva due to the tension. I couldn't eat all of it. First I destroyed the numbers and addresses, but there were some things I couldn't destroy. Soon the CBI officer came to get me. 'What are you eating. What are you eating? Are you taking poison? What is in your mouth?'

'I'm not taking poison. I am destroying some addresses from my diary.'

'Take it out. Now.' So I did and put it on the table in a nice little chewed up package.

They began interrogating me. I decided to demoralize them first and I knew how to do this. I told them, 'I didn't know anything.' They tried to say that I was also implicated in this 'murder'. I shouted back at them saying that they knew it all and they were involved in the murder. I spent the nighttime at the prison, Bábá's grace – it was neat and clean, with nice bathroom and toilet. Then some officials came to me to hear about meditation and spirituality. They were very sympathetic. Next morning officials came from Calcutta, Delhi, and Patna. I was doing sádhaná. I heard the officials come and I didn't move. They were asking 'What is he doing always in meditation.' An official stood up for me suggesting that it was not good to disturb me, maybe out of respect or superstitious fear of a sádhu's occult powers. At 12 midnight they got hungry and tired, they called me to take

breakfast, I said I would wait a few minutes. Finally, I went to roundtable and asked them, 'How can I help you people.'

They asked me, 'Where have you been.'

I said, 'I have been in Bangladesh or wherever I could get shelter, but I don't know any names of people who helped me.' I kept quiet.

I continued my tactic to divide and demoralise them. I commented that I had a high opinion of the official forces, but they were so undisciplined, that they did not ask questions properly, let one person ask a question at one time and let me answer the question before the next person asks one. Until then, I will not answer any questions.

In evening time, I did sáadhaná again. They waited for three hours. It was summer season and very hot. They were so much angry at me. 'Why are you always doing meditation. We are wasting our time.' At 9pm, I came out and asked, 'How can I help you people, I am very sorry.'

Then one CBI official said, 'He is not telling everything.'

I said, 'Whatever I know I tell. I ate the addresses I told, I flushed the addressed down the toilet, I told.' Another officer said, 'Third degree should be applied, and then he will tell everything.' I was thinking of Bábá, and concerned about what would happen to my physical body, but accepted that if this happens, then okay.

Another officer said, 'It will be better to work psychologically on him.' They agreed and did not apply the third degree. Some officials were very sympathetic and interested to seek medical consultation from me, which I gave freely. The senior officials began to be more sympathetic to me too. After one week of this, they moved me to another office. There they interrogated me saying, 'You know everything and you must write it all down.' When I went there, I put paper down, and sat in meditation. This was my principle.

I was interrogated constantly. ‘Do you know this man?’

‘No.’

‘Do you know that man?’

‘No.’

‘What about this man?’

‘No.’

One nasty official said ‘I will throw you from the third floor and shoot you.’

I told them, ‘It does not matter.’ They recounted stories of how they had done this before. I told them, ‘I am one hundred per cent ready to die. In the meantime you do your work, I will do mine.’

An official asked me again, ‘Were you in Bangladesh? Where? Road name?’ I do not remember these sorts of things and could not answer. This official said, ‘You are lying because you do not know anything about that area of Bangladesh.’ He was an official from that area and knew everything about it. I couldn’t answer anything. They then said, ‘Beating is needed.’

But another official intervened and said, ‘No this will not work.’

A senior official, but a young man, arrived. He told me that I had a case in Patna to answer. I was taken to the court. My hands were tied with thick ropes. In court the young CBI official asked me many things, one after the other. I told him, ‘You don’t know how to ask questions properly, so I won’t answer you.’ The court ordered that I be shifted to Patna. In the evening this officer got my bag, he told me that I should be proud that he was getting my bags. I said he was not an official, but a child getting my bag. I said I would only go first class. He agreed to that. I was put in the Howrah lockup near the train station. It was so dirty and smelly I had to sit next to the gate grill keeping my nose out. On leaving Howrah, on the train, I was given a compartment to myself and

so many police were there, that people thought that I must be very dangerous.

After reaching Patna, I was immediately taken before the court. I went before the magistrate, one sister; a lady magistrate was there. After seeing me, her only comment was, ‘You tell me which jail you would like to go to. Where your Guru is or where other Dádás are. Which jail would you like to go?’

‘Okay, I will go to the one where the Dádás are, then I’ll have company.’ Bábá is with me always, and I knew that in the jail where Bábá was there would be many restrictions and I would not be physically near Him.

In Calcutta, the officials were saying that the CBI and jail officials in Patna would not be so sympathetic as they were and would even be brutal. Some of the officials in Calcutta were concerned for me. As it turned out, at the jail in Patna with all the Dádás, we were doing dharmacakra, always meditating, having kiirtana. So many things. We had one whole hall to ourselves. They mostly left us alone and we had a strong morale. We were enjoying and it made little difference whether we were in jail or outside. Eventually we were all released after the State of Emergency ended and Bábá’s case dismissed. So you see there is no case for worry. Bábá will look after you.

Dada’s story was impressive. He picks up his gardening tools and takes his leave to continue his work. I walk around to the back of the house and take out my plastic water container. Filling it requires some dexterity as I have to pump the handle with two hands, then grab the container to position it under the water flow, filling a little before the water stops. I repeat this until the bottle is full. This has become a daily routine now.

In the evening we are all caught unawares with Bábá coming down early due to it being a fasting day. He does namaskár to each person and asks, “Is everything ok? Is everything running smoothly, in the proper order?” He looks to the Dádás for an answer, but their minds are

somewhere else and too slow to answer. From behind Bá bá, Áshrava replies, “Yes, Bá bá.” Surprised, He turns around and gives a funny sniggering chuckle, then gets into the car.

On His return, Bá bá stands amongst us and talks for a very long time to VSS, Dádá and other Indian márgiis. When He first starts, He turns to the four of us, Áshrava, Púrńa Premá, Shivaprabhá and me, and says, “I am speaking in Bengali”. Áshrava, having recognised some of the words she is learning in Bengali, responds with, “I know, Bá bá”. At stages in His long and animated talk, Bá bá explains a little in English to keep us informed. He talks about the origins and development of the Durgá Festival, celebrated on this day, and how the idol of Durgá is taken to the river and dunked in the water. In the past, everyone men and women, wore earrings, bracelets and locketts, but that this has changed over time and now only children wear these. He completed this discourse by telling us; “I am telling them that as a child, I used to wear bangles on my arms.”



Catching Kṛṣṇa

Thursday 27/3

When Bábá comes down in the morning, He inspects the garden for a long while. This morning He is all smiles and laughter. Dádá Akṣayánanda trails after Bábá, listening carefully to all He says about the plants. Bábá notes the condition of each plant and gives specific instructions if they are sagging or in need of improvement, so that Dádá can carry them out later. Eventually Bábá is satisfied and climbs into His car. The small group of us finish our kiirtana as Bábá drives off.

I approach Dádá Akṣayánanda as he adjusts a particularly beautiful orchid and inquire what Bábá has been instructing him about the plants. He says, “Bábá knows so much about every plant. This orchid needs to be held up better with a small wooden stake. He gives me detailed instructions for everything. I must remember all of His instructions in entirety and implement them, then report back to Bábá. I have always enjoyed plants, but when I was young I had no idea that I would be an Ácárya or doing all this gardening.” Prompting him further, I inquired, “How did you eventually become an Ácárya?” Shrugging his shoulders, He obliges me and continues:

In 1965 I went to Wholetimer training to become an Ácárya. I was very short, wearing half pants, and no beard or moustache. I looked very young. People thought I looked fourteen or fifteen, but I was actually twenty-two. In December, Bábá sent me to the training centre in Varanasi. My sádhaná and devotion were so strong that many times I would see Bábá at the training centre as if He were really there. I would go and tell the other trainees and Dádás that Bábá had arrived and everyone would come running

to greet Him. When we arrived back at the same spot, Bábá was not longer there. They thought I was a mad boy. Fortunately or unfortunately, this kept happening. Bábá was gracing me with His vision and in this way constantly keeping me inspired during the rigorous training to become an Ácárya.

In the month of April 1965, I had Personal Contact (PC) with Bábá. There was a long queue. At that time he was punishing everybody, telling them the things they had done wrong and their mistakes in life so as to correct them. Bábá would do it in such a way that people would come to see for themselves the mistakes they had made. I was very much afraid, so I was going through my whole life looking for mistakes. I thought of one small mistake I had made. I was in the queue. Everyone was getting punishment. This was my first PC and I was very afraid. When I came before Bábá, I was prepared for the worst.

Bábá surprised me. He beamed and brightly said, ‘Oh, my boy you have come. My boy, do you remember me? At the airport? You remember the burning ground?’ I was confused and unsure of what Bábá was referring to. I replied that I didn’t understand. Bábá then recounted our airport meeting the year before and of the old man talking to me from behind and asked if I knew this man. I said no, and then in an instant I could see, Bábá and the old man were the same. As if this was not enough, He continued, ‘It was I who taught you sáadhaná and gave you the mantra in the graveyard that night.’ Astonished, my mind in a daze, I foolishly asked how He could be with me there when He lived somewhere else. Bábá laughed heartily and indicated that our time in PC was finished. My mind reeling with the revelations, I prañamed Bábá and took my leave. I realised the depth of the grace He had bestowed upon me over my life.

After Wholetimer training, I was sent to Jamalpur for further training as a teacher in Ananda Marga schools. One night when Bábá visited, I was asked to accompany Him on field walk.

There was a very big hill in Jamalpur. At this place, there had been a fight between a tiger and an Englishman. Both were killed in the struggle and buried there under the soil. Bábá wanted me to accompany Him while He went to sit on what is now called the Tiger's Grave. I went with Bábá to the big hill. There we proceeded into the forest until we came upon a natural spring with much water coming out. He told me to sit there in front of the fountain and do my sádhaná until He came back. Nearby was another place with two hills called Death Valley where there were many tigers and it was dangerous. No one would go there. This was where Bábá was going to meditate on the Tiger's Grave. I was sitting in meditation near the spring, but I was also worried about the tigers. It was a long time and Bábá had not come back.

After another forty-five minutes there was a sound like something coming, walking on dry leaves. I was thinking, 'Tiger is coming. Tiger will kill me.' Ignoring my fear, I focused more on my meditation. Again, I was hearing this slow walking and thinking, 'Tiger is surely coming,' but I continued making more effort at my sádhaná. The slow crunch of footsteps was coming nearer and nearer. As it drew closer, I was thinking, 'It is very nearby,... nearby,... nearby.' I could not contain myself, so I opened my eyes. When I did, I saw Kṛṣṇa standing there. Overwhelmed, I ran to Kṛṣṇa and although he was moving about, I caught hold of him, like I tried to do as a child. I told him, 'I will not let you go, I have been chasing you for so many years.' I held onto Kṛṣṇa and with my eyes shut tight I went into bliss. I don't know how long I was there in that state. A sound aroused me. After that sound, I heard the sound of Bábá's voice. I opened my eyes and there, in my grasp was Bábá. I asked, 'Bábá how is this possible?' He reminded me about my desire to see Him in Kṛṣṇa's form and He had fulfilled this desire. Since then, I have given up my attachment for Kṛṣṇa. Bábá has fulfilled this desire and it is now gone. This also taught me that Bábá knows everything.

With a satisfied smile Dádá concludes, saying, “Excuse me now as I have to carry out Bábá’s morning instructions with the plants.” I wander off and stroll about the garden for a while and then head to the Office. Everyone is busy going about their business here, so I sit in meditation in the hall area. I go into a deep relaxation, but my mind is taken with Dádá Akśayánanda’s story. I imagine myself sitting out there on the Jamalpur hill, near the splashing water of the spring. Could I hear any tigers? I had done graveyard meditation in Australia and it certainly heightened my senses. Every little noise evoked an image of something there. What..., is that Bábá’s voice? He must be approaching along the hall. I jump up from my sitting position and spin around with a namaskár ready. I am startled to find Bábá right next to me returning my namaskár. How did that happen, He was down the hallway? Bábá calmly continues into His office.

When we arrived at Bábá’s residence in the evening, Parimal is waiting with a little parcel for Áshrava and I. “Your pratikas are ready,” he says with a big smile and wobble of his head. Opening the little paper parcel neatly tied with string, I lift up a delicate silver chain to see a sparkly little pratika dangling from the end. Parimal has cut out the triangles to emphasis their shape and daubed the sun in a brilliant red of enamel. We are very happy with our pratikas and immediately put them around our necks, hanging correctly in length at the heart cakra. For this lovely piece of silver work we pay Parimal the very reasonable sum of 100 rupees each. These pratikas will be worn under our shirts as a reminder of our spiritual path and as a protective *yantra*.

Later, while we are all standing around casually talking, Bábá comes down unannounced and even the VSS guards have to rush into position at the door to salute Him. As Bábá comes over to the car, He speaks in Bengali about the plants for a while then, turning to us He exclaims, “*Bhálo!*” in Bengali and then questions “*Bhálo Ácho?* [Are you well?].”

Púrña Premá and Áshrava reply to Bábá, “*Bhálo.*”

To which Bábá asks, “What does ‘*Bhálo*’ mean?”

“Good, well,” is their reply.

“Good, and in French?”

Áshrava answers, “*Bon.*”

“This is masculine, and the feminine?”

Áshrava continues, “*Bonne.*”

“Good, and in Portuguese?”

After a pause, Áshrava cautiously answers, “*Bonno.*”

Bábá wags His finger in emphasis saying, “Very good. You see the depth of knowledge.”

Áshrava knew nothing of Portuguese, but had intuitively guessed. She responds, “Oh no Bábá, you put the word in my mouth.”

Bábá broadly smiles, then goes on to explain the transition of the word ‘good’ in Sanskrit as it changed about every one thousand years from five thousand years ago to the modern Bengali of Bhálo. Finishing, He drives off for evening field walk.

While He is away, as is part of our routine, I commence sádhaná in the meditation room. It is one of those deep and timeless moments, which seem like I have only just sat down, but also been sitting here forever. Suddenly Bábá’s car is coming back through the gates. I jump up out of meditation and race to the driveway. As I stand there with hands raised to my chest in respectful namaskár, I am still deeply ensconced in the mental space of sádhaná. Bábá emerges from the car, looks at me for a moment and then namaskárs with a most blissful smile. He walks over to Áshrava, who is doing kiirtana, looks at her, then at the guitar she is holding and asks, “And what is its’ name?”

“Madhu, Bábá.” He nods His head giving a satisfied smile and walks on.

Friday 28/3

In the morning Áshrava goes to the meditation room to get the guitar and other percussive instruments to do kiirtana for Bábá when He comes

down for morning field walk. They are locked in the small side room and nobody is available with a key. Subsequently we just do a slightly wobbly vocals-only kiirtana. When Bábá arrives, márgiis present Him with three garlands and He gives many namaskárs to everyone present. Later in the day at Central Office for Bábá's Darshan, the kiirtana is a difficult tune and so the singing is not strong and falters in some places, even stopping at one point. We hear that Bábá had commented later, "What happened to kiirtana today?"

Our thoughts now turn to Bábá's request for a tape of our kiirtanas. Áshrava and I start asking around the márgiis we know for a cassette deck, but no-one has access to any kind of recording device. The days have been flying past since Bábá mentioned He would like a tape of our kiirtana and we still had no way of making one. I think that maybe we will have to make one when we go back to Australia. While at the Central Office, I decide to inquire of Dádá Praṇavánanda, again calling on my quota of goodwill from announcing Bábá's office visit, "Bábá has asked us for a tape of our kiirtana tunes so that He can listen to them. Is there any cassette recorder here that I might use?"

With a little uncertainty Dádá responds, "I think there is one on the ground floor, but it is constantly in use for transcription of Bábá's Darshans. Speak to the márgii there, Raghu and tell him that I have sent you."

Raghu is a cheery snowy-haired fellow, happy to see Áshrava and I, and to talk for a while. He sits behind a large desk cluttered with books and papers with a couple of dictionaries thrown on top. A soft light streams in through the window behind him. Sitting on the side of the table is a small black and silver cassette recorder. Raghu is an accountant, but when he can he comes in to the Central Office to spend time pouring over the muffled recordings of Bábá's Darshans on the old cassette deck and transcribing them for publication.

Raghu has known Bábá for a very long time. I think he is an old friend of Bábá's from the railway days. Raghu recounts to us some of this time when Bábá first started Ananda Marga in Jamalpur where He

was working as a clerk in the railway office. At that time, Bábá had been secretly initiating people into the practice of sādhaná, but many thought that they were the only one. One day Bábá sent out invites to come to the Railway Hall to meet Him. As each person arrived they were amazed to see all these other people coming, some whom they knew very well. At this meeting, Bábá pronounced the formation of Ananda Marga and all the people in the hall were invited to join. Consequently, Ananda Marga Pracāraka Saṁgha, the Society for the Propagation of the Path of Bliss, was founded in 1955.

Raghu picks up his shiny stainless steel mug, takes a sip of water and considers his transcription work schedule. “Yes, the cassette deck will be free in a few days time, but not for very long. It could be called back into transcription service at any moment. If Bábá has asked, then you may certainly use it while it is available.” Promising to take good care of the deck, we hurry off to buy new batteries and blank cassettes in preparation for its availability.

In the evening, we have the guitar back out of the closet and produce a rousing kiirtana spurred on by Áshrava’s skilful playing and we give it all our hearts. By the time Bábá comes down the sky is shot with lightning and a light sprinkle of rain is descending, but this does not dampen our spirited kiirtana. As Bábá approaches, we bring our kiirtana to a modulated finish, adopt a namaskár posture and Bábá comments, “When a man does something good, noble, or plans something noble, then it rains, but *Puspa-Brsti* rain, a shower of flowers. And I think that you are experiencing that now?” When Bábá gets into the car He inquiries of Áshrava, “Where was Madhu today?”

Indicating that the guitar was locked in the meditation storeroom, Áshrava replies, “She was locked up, but now she is liberated”. On Bábá return from field walk, we are again producing a vibrated kiirtana. He queries, “Is it raining, or is it raining?” I feel that life is blessed and I am cradled in a benign universe. Everything is right with the world. All happens in it’s own good time and my life is full. What can I say? In my mind, I throw myself at Bábá’s feet in gratitude to an existence so blessed. I think it must be raining *Puspa-Brsti*.



The Biggest Mystery of Mysticism

Saturday 29/3

In the morning, Bábá arrives with big smiles for everyone. He is in a very cheery mood. When He gets into the car Púrña Premá asks Him, “How are you Bábá?” He does not fully hear and leans further towards her with His hand cupped to His ear. She repeats her question, “How are you today, Bábá?”

He comically replies, “I’m OK ...by your grace.”

Bábá’s manners are impeccable and He sets the perfect example. As in this simple statement ending to Púrña Premá, “... by your grace.” Should we be saying the same, adding, “...by Your grace” or “...by Bábá’s grace”, when talking to other people, so as to reflect on Parama Puruśa’s all pervading influence. I have always liked the Arabic phrase, ‘*Inshallah*’ that is added to many sentences by Muslims. As in, “I will see you tomorrow, Inshallah”, meaning Allah willing or God willing. If God wills it, I will see you tomorrow. Unfortunately I have seen some people use Inshallah as an uncertainty or excuse, as in “I will meet you at 8pm, Inshallah”, really meaning, maybe or maybe not or somewhere around that time. Another phrase I prefer is *Mashallah* meaning by the grace of God and tends to be more positive than the uncertainty sometimes proscribed to Inshallah. Inshallah is meant to be used by Muslims all the time in relation to sentences of what they will to do, to remind themselves that it is God’s will that anything comes to pass. Mashallah indicates more something that you wish to actually happen, sometimes a difficult task that you seek God’s blessings for what and are about to do embark on.

Later in the day, Báábá sits to give Darshan at the Central Office and, continuing His humorous mood of the morning, asks of the gathered crowd, “I hope you don’t mind if I sit here for a couple of minutes?” After a round of laughter from the audience He continues, “I will speak in Bengali, because if I speak in English the subject will lose its charm”. He then begins the Darshan, but to everyone’s surprise, in English. Giving a show of humour at the supposed mistake, He stops and begins again in Bengali.

Yajiṇa – The Goal

Talking again about external and internal practices, Báábá says that for most people, who do external rituals the goal is a created form, for the spiritual practitioner the highest Yajiṇa is the internal practices of Dhyána and the goal here is the witnessing entity, Brahma.

Báábá explains that the psychology of the human mind is to give a name to everything. In the beginning a simple name was given to Parama Puruśa, ‘ka’. As people developed psychically they started to give a name with more significance, more complexity. Although the Supreme Entity is infinite, no name is sufficient, and all are limited, but God will hear whatever name He is being called by, know it is for Him and will respond. God will respond to the earnestness of the feeling in which He is being called rather than the name He is given.

Halfway through the Darshan, Báábá elucidates to the English-speaking márgiis, the gist of the talk and then continues again in Bengali.

Each human being, according to one’s own saṁskára, whether according to one’s vibration and rhythm of one’s saṁskára, selects one name to address Parama Puruśa and that particular name is the Íśámantra for that particular person. That is the mantra that is dearest for him or her and that is also the most secret because the vibrational manifestation of that Íśámantra is actually acting as a bridge between the finite and infinite. That is the subtlest and greatest secret of mysticism.¹⁷

When Báábá finishes, He rounds up the talk lyrically in English, stating, “Íśfámantra is the most secret and sacred mystery of the mystic science. It is the biggest mystery of mysticism.”¹⁷

As Báábá leaves the Darshan hall, a western Didi approaches Him, hopefully announcing, “Báábá, I really enjoyed the part of your Darshan that you gave in English.”

Báábá responds, “Would you like me to give all my Darshans in English?”

“Yes, Báábá”, she enthusiastically replies. Báábá walks on chuckling to Himself.

In the evening, I position myself at the front of a line of devotees. As Báábá comes downstairs, I am able to see Him at the doorway talking to VSS in Bengali and bending down pointing to His right leg. What is this I wonder?

Báábá walks on down to the line of márgiis, stops in front of me at the head of the line and for some time gazes intently before giving me a namaskár. He then moves along namaskáring each person in line before getting into His car. Leaning to His window, Báábá inquires of the gathering, now around the car, “Did you like today’s Darshan?”

“Yes, Báábá.”

“But was it intelligible?” He says and drives off.

On His return, Báábá asks a newly arrived Indian márgii his name and if he knows the whereabouts of another márgii from Allahabad. Báábá then walks up to the stairway and begins a conversation with VSS in Bengali where He again points at His leg. All the márgiis have followed behind Báábá and I end up right next to Him. Báábá looks at us and asks, as if to the VSS guard, “And what is their advice?” There is silence, as no one understands any of the Bengali Báábá has spoken. “They are not speaking?”

Then someone asks Báábá, “What is the problem Báábá?”

“I have some pain in the muscle of the leg.”

Áshrava suggests that Jiivánii knows of health matters. Jiivánii steps to the front and begins to explain that she has some healing oils and how they might help. Báábá may accept the oil, but would not allow a sister to massage Him for proprieties sake and the reputation of Ananda Marga. I see the opening and jump to the opportunity, quickly suggesting to Báábá, “Would you like me to massage your leg Báábá?”

Seeing my mischievous grin, Báábá begins laughing and shakes His finger at me jokingly as if to say, ‘Ah... you have the answer, but this little boy is also a little eager to massage Báábá.’ He gives a jovial namaskár to everyone and goes on up the stairs. Undeterred, I wait in anticipation at the front to see if I will be called up to massage Báábá’s leg, but fortunately or unfortunately no call comes.

Sunday 30/3

Áshrava and I do not get to Báábá’s house in the morning, but make it to the Office early in the afternoon for His Darshan. Many márgiis know that Báábá has returned to giving Darshan now and they start arriving at the Office in time to get a good position in the hall. Everyone is sitting on the floor, quietly talking, reading or meditating as they wait. One by one the spaces towards the front are taken up. Áshrava and I position ourselves about a third of the way from the front of the dais where Báábá will sit. Because there are so many márgiis the hall is filling rapidly and a devotee squeezes into every available space, no matter how small. This is all done good-naturedly as everyone shuffles around making room for the person sitting down.

The Dádás indicate to the audience that Báábá will be coming in soon. Everyone quietens and looks expectantly to the front. Báábá enters the hall and walks to the dais. He sits cross-legged on the cushioned platform, closes His eyes and meditates. Everyone follows Báábá’s lead. When Báábá finishes His meditation, He surveys the audience and asks in Bengali, “*Ami ajke Banglay ba Englishe Darshan debo?*” Most of the audience replies loudly to Báábá, “Banglay, Báábá”. I lean over to Dádá Kriśnāpriya and ask, “What has been said.”

“Bábá has asked, ‘Will I give today’s Darshan in Bengali or English?’”, says Dádá. Most of the Indians here are Bengali speakers and Dádá says they all replied, “In Bengali Bábá!” Despite this, Bábá does give some of the Darshan in English as well as Bengali:

Yajiṇa – Dashavatar Stotra

Bábá explains that as people were developing psychically and continually doing Yajiṇa, there was consequently some refinement. In the course of time, their intellect further developed and they realised that instead of addressing Parama Puruṣa as different persons and manifestations, such as Vishnu or Rama, actually only one entity is the cause of all, the Supreme Entity. It is one, but they also gave credence to the different manifestations of Parama Puruṣa.

During that period, people of those days realised something regarding the evolution of creation and human society. Later some seven hundred years ago, Jaydeva, the devotional poet of Bengal, using very lucid language easy to understand by the common people, composed verses known as the Dashavatar Stotra, meaning the ten incarnations or names of God. During that time, some people were worshipping one incarnation or another, but a realised person knows that there is only one.

Bábá reveals how in the Dashavatar Stotra, Jaydev expresses lyrically the process of evolution, well known by the Hindus thousands of years before Darwin’s exposition of it. Incorporated in these verses are also the evolutionary development of mind through the stages of citta (objective mind, mind-stuff), aham (the part of the mind which performs actions, the doer “I” or ego) and mahat (“I exist” feeling); and then the development of society, through the Shúdra (worker), Kśattriya (warrior), Vipra (intellectual) and Vaeshya (merchant) ages.

Bábá shows how Jaydeva expressed the first incarnation of God in the form of a fish, representing the evolution of aquatic beings and the development of the first part of mind, citta. The second

incarnation is a tortoise, where creatures are now moving between the land and the sea with the development of the second part of mind aham. With each incarnation delineated in the Dashavatar Stotra, Bábá goes on to explain the deeper meaning of what Jaydev was expressing in his scriptural verses.

Bábá observes that in the ninth incarnation the verse is regarding the Buddha. He explains that the merchant class did not like conflict, so they promoted the Buddhist non-violence to take full advantage of developing the Vaeshyan society.¹⁸

Bábá concludes His Darshan here. He has explained, clearing up common misunderstandings about the symbols used, how in the Dasháavatar Stotra, Jaydev is expressing lyrically the process of evolution, well known by the Hindus thousands of years before Darwin's exposition of it. Incorporated in this are also the development of mind through its various stages.

Bábá pauses, sitting looking around at the márgiis. He then closes His eyes and draws His hands together at His forehead in a slow ideated namaskár that ends the proceedings. Many márgiis, including Áshrava and me, knowing the routine, proceed Bábá down the stairs to His awaiting car. Eventually Bábá comes down from the hall and with VSS guards shepherding the crowd aside, He enters the car. Bábá leans to the open window and speaks to the Westerners gathered there, reminding us once again to get the English rendition of the Darshan.



Jokes on Field Walk

Monday 31/3

In the morning, three visiting Ácáryas each in turn give Bábá a garland of flowers and prostrate before Him in prañáma. Bábá then discusses with them the meaning and derivation of their Sanskrit names. They listen intently to the explanations.

I stand next to the car door when Bábá approaches to get in and He asks in Bengali, “*Keman Ácho?*” (How are you?). I didn’t understand what Bábá says. I find languages hard to learn or remember and just stand there mute with a perplexed look on my face. As Bábá gets into the car, He answers in my stead with an “OK” in English.^{iv}

In the evening Áshrava is not well and I hop into a rickshaw off to Bábá’s house alone, leaving her resting in bed. The rickshaw pulls up and I step down, paying the driver and walk to the doorway of the gate. As I step inside, I am surprised to find Bábá’s car already in the driveway. I ask Parimal, “What is happening?”

“Oh, this is fasting day and Bábá is leaving early for field walk, you are the only one here tonight, so far.” The effort to arrive early is paying off.

Within a few minutes Bábá comes down to the car. Seeing me, He stops and addresses me, “I did not give Darshan today. Yesterday’s Darshan was fifty per cent Bengali and fifty per cent English. The Bengali should be rendered into English and the English should be rendered into Bengali.” Thus, Bábá had solved the problem of which language for Darshan.

iv Little do I know that nearly 30 years later I will be living and working in Bangladesh and struggling to learn the language, Bangla, that is Bengali.

There is no one here for field walk, except me. Dádá Rámánanda, surprised, quickly looks around to check for anyone else, then ushers me into the back of the car with Bábá and we set off. Just as we reach the end of the street, a few rickshaws filled with Ácáryas round the corner belatedly heading for Bábá's house and their missed appointment. As we drive on Bábá begins speaking to the VSS in Bengali, then turns to me and says, "I am speaking in Bengali."

"Yes, Bábá," I reply, and He continues speaking with the guard.

Again, He turns to me and asks, "And what is your advice? I am telling that little boy how I changed my dhoti, from 1940 to 1945, during the war, for full length trousers and I was asking him if I should do so again, but he said I should keep the dhoti as everyone is accustomed to me wearing it. And what do you think?"

"I think that you would look good in either, Bábá."

"Then, if you give your permission, I will wear the dhoti."

While saying this last piece, He reaches across and places His hand around the back of my neck, cupping it and giving it a light rub, whereupon He laughs lightly. This simple act has a profound effect upon me. His touch seems to evoke in me all the emotions of a caring father towards his son. A warmth spreads around my neck that stays with me. I don't know what Bábá has done, but it is like He has charged me with his shakti, his energy. But more than this is a deep emotional response, hard to explain. It's like I experience the benevolence of the Universe, that I am taken care of and that ultimately everything is ok and right with the world. This sense just stays with me for days, as does the feel of Bábá's hand on the nape of my neck.

As I sit glowing with Bábá's touch, He continues talking with VSS in Bengali, interspersed with lots of laughter and chuckles by both of them. He turns to me and explains, "I am telling a story of a conversation between two deaf people."

I take the moment's break in conversation to say to Bábá, "I very much enjoyed your Darshan in English, Bábá."

“You could understand? It was clear?”

“Yes, Bábá.”

“And does my English have an Indian quality.” Bábá was referring to an Indian accent.

“No, Bábá.” I was able to understand Bábá’s English quite well.

“Yes, that is because I was taught in an English school, not an Indian one.”

Bábá continues talking in Bengali to the VSS guard. I notice that we are driving past the Lake Gardens Park and think that we must be going somewhere else to walk. We continue to drive on and on. Are we going to visit someone? Then I realise that it seems we are going in a big circle. At a space in the conversation I begin to ask Bábá this, but He thinks I am inquiring about His conversation in Bengali with VSS and replies, “I am talking with this little boy [VSS] about lemons.” I try to ask Bábá again, but He interrupts me with the same saying, “We are talking about horticulture. I know a little about horticulture.” Bábá continues in Bengali to VSS and in another break I successfully ask, “You’re not going for field walk tonight, Bábá?”

“No, not on fast days and also I still have a little pain in this leg.”

I can’t resist and ask, “Do you need it massaged, Bábá.”

“It will be all right the day after tomorrow. Also, walk tonight would be over-exercise.”

Bábá continues talking to VSS and amongst the Bengali and English I recognise they are discussing the plum fruit, but pronounced different to my use. I enquire about this, “Bábá, is ‘ploum’ the correct pronunciation, not ‘plumm’?”

“That is right, ‘ploum’. When ‘u’ follows ‘l’, then the intonation is ‘ou’, as in ‘you’” Then, Bábá spells words out for me to pronounce as a school teacher would, “l. u. c. i. d.”

I reply, “Loucid.”

“Ah, yes, and....’d.e.l.u.s.i.o.n’?”

“Delousion.”

“Yes, and ‘s.l.u.m’?”

“Slum.”

“Yes, it is an exception, not ‘sloum’. Remember, you must be sure before you say, that it is incorrect. English has come from many sources: Saxon, Celtic, Anglo, and there are many more varying rules. ‘H.a.l.f’?”

“Half.”

“Yes, the ‘L’ is mute when the last letter is a consonant and the ‘L’ is before it. ‘H.a.l.t’?”

“Halt.”

“Halt. This again is an exception to the general rule. Primary school teachers should teach this to their students.”

“Yes, Bábá.”

“G.l.o.c.h.e.s.t.e.r?” Being a poor speller at the best of times, I don’t grasp the word and ask Bábá to repeat it, but still it alludes me. So Bábá says it Himself, “Gloster. We write the ‘CH’, but we do not pronounce it. Glochester is a county in England.”

“Yes, Bábá.”

“I.s.l.a.n.d?”

“i-land.”

“Yes, we do not say ‘is’. Here is a puzzle. If ‘t’ is like an island, why is that so?”

I wracked my mind for some connection between them, but failed to solve the puzzle. After a few moments of thought I reply, “I don’t know, Bábá.”

“What is an island?” He quizzes me.

“A piece of land in water.”

“Surrounded by water”, He corrects. Then Bábá repeats the puzzle, “If ‘t’ is like an island, why is that so?”, but again I cannot come up with the answer. Finally He gives it, “Wa...t...er, water. The ‘t’ is surrounded by water.” The puzzle complete, we laughed at its simplicity.

Then He asks, “P.a.l.l M.a.l.l?”

“Paul Maul.”

“No, ‘Pal Mal.” Again, we laugh, me shaking my head, at the vagary of the English language. Bábá poses the next puzzle, “What word has ‘t’ at the beginning, ‘t’ at the end, ‘t’ in the middle, and ‘t’ is the charm of the word?” Bábá also tells VSS the puzzle in Bengali and the two of us strive to find an answer, without any result. Bábá keeps on at us to find the answer, but eventually gives up and supplies it Himself, “teapot! And tea is the charm of it.” We all laugh at this whimsical turn of the word. Bábá continues, “English intonation is very hard to master. It is a mystery.”

We drive on further and soon come in a round about way to the Central Office. Pulling up outside, Bábá directs the VSS guard to run inside and get Dádá Yatiishvaránanda. Meanwhile a young boy comes to Bábá’s window and they exchange namaskárs. Soon all the Ácáryas are coming down from the office and Bábá discusses some organisational matters with Dádá Yatiishvaránanda and other Ácáryas. The young boy hangs close to the car despite the throng of eager Ácáryas, themselves becoming like boys in Bábá’s presence. Bábá calls the young boy to the window and explains in English that he should not feel that he is insignificant or that other so-called great people are more worthy. Bábá recites a Bengali poem about the huge date palm and that even though it is such a big tree; still it gives no shade and has no beautiful flowers. Whereas small plants have much fruit and sweet scented flowers and are of great benefit to people. Bábá namaskárs everyone and directs the driver to proceed to His residence. As we round the street to His house, Bábá asks me, “Do you think I am a strong administrator, strong organiser, or a weak administrator?”

“I think you are a very strong administrator Bábá.”

“And who told you?”

“No-one needs to tell me Báábá. I can see by the way you act and conduct the organisation.”

“Then it is, if you say so.”

The car pulls into the driveway and we get out. As Báábá goes to leave, I give Him a namaskár. None of the caravan of Ácáryas we saw on the roadway while leaving has waited. I stay a little while near the meditation room, looking at the garden, enjoying the peace of the evening and write down my time with Báábá on this field walk.



Drenched in the Rain of Divine Bliss

Tuesday 1/4

In the morning as Bábá drives out for field walk, He leans forward to the window and gives me a namaskár and a look of recognition, nodding His head. As Dádá Akṣayánanda passes, he inquires, “Jiṇáneshvar, can you help me with some heavy pots that need moving?” With a yes from me, we head upstairs till we reach the rooftop. Here there are pot plants all around the edges and upon tables. Dádá and I move several to another location, and then sit to talk.

Over a cold drink of water and with my prompting, Dádá continues telling me some more of his time as an Ácárya:

Although I had additional training in Jamalpur for teaching in Ananda Marga schools, in 1966 I was posted to Ánanda Nagar in West Bengal. At that time, I was in charge of shopping, canteen and the children’s store. Bábá came there several times. He had given me even more duties, construction of roads to the hospital, the college and others. The hill area was full of stones and with these we were making stone roads with help of the labourers. It took too much time; there was too much pressure. I was not sleeping for three months, so I did not know what was sleep. I realised that the body can go a very long time without sleep. Bábá would come and stay at Ánanda Nagar and sleep on a blanket. He would enquire about the progress of the construction.

One day, the Diocese Secretary complained to Bábá that I was not working hard enough. Bábá came to my room. He called me and told me that He had a complaint against me, that I had not been working properly. How could this be, day and night I was

working and never took any rest. He asked how many hours it would take to complete this construction work. I was tired and I become angry. I told Bábá, ‘You are asking how long the job will take. You never ask me about my sádhaná and my lessons.’ I was crying loudly as I was telling Him this. Bábá kept mute during my outburst.

Then He said, ‘Akśayánanda, you sit in asana.’ As I sat in *padmāsana* and closed my eyes, Bábá took a register book and He touched at my pituitary gland, my ájiṇá cakra, and asked, ‘What can you see.’ Before my mind’s eye I could see many monks doing meditation and they were not opening their eyes. He said, ‘How do they look.’

I said, ‘There is no flesh, just skeletons.’ I knew that they had been doing so much meditation.

Bábá asked, ‘How are they living?’

From my vision I replied, ‘They are taking food from the air and light.’

Bábá asked, ‘Why after doing so much meditation have they not attained liberation and are looking like skeletons.’ It was clear to me that without the grace of Parama Puruśa nothing can happen. Bábá was feeding them.

After finishing the demonstration, Bábá began telling the other Dádás present that up on the big hill they were to make a small house for me and arrange someone to provide me with food and water. ‘I am not giving him any responsibility. He is now free to do as much meditation as he wants.’

I was thinking, what is Bábá telling me, that even if I meditate till I become a skeleton, I still may not attain liberation? I said I would not go to that hill and pleaded with Bábá. Finally, Bábá agreed, on one condition, that I did His work without question and Bábá would do my sádhaná. However, the little sádhaná that I could do in between my work was very intense, with Bábá’s help of course.

Bábá finally came from Jamalpur to stay at Ánandanagar in December 1966. I was thinking that after so much work that I was doing here, now I would be with Bábá and I could enjoy my spiritual life, but after fifteen days only, I was asked to leave. Two Dádás had come to Ánandanagar to see Bábá asking who will solve their problem. A family there was causing trouble. Their daughter had become a Didi, a renunciant; and left her family. This had greatly upset them and their relatives. They were now disturbing the Ananda Marga School. Bábá asked me to go to Balurghat in West Bengal. I was the one to be sent to solve these Dádás' problems. When I heard that I would have to go to that place, I was deeply upset. Bábá called me and told me in front of all the márgiis, saying, 'He is a sincere worker, working very hard.' I was weeping because Bábá was sending me away. Bábá's wife was also trying to convince me that I had to go. Bábá said, 'Don't worry, in two weeks his mood would be okay.' Everyone was trying to convince me. Finally, I made up my mind to go, but on one condition. Bábá asked, 'What?'

My sorry reply was, 'Whenever I wish to see You, You have to give me Darshan.' Bábá agreed.

I went to Balurghat and from then on, every night in my dreams, Bábá was appearing to me and teaching me. In addition, whenever my eyes were closed, Bábá would be there. The family of this Didi had caused plenty of trouble in the whole village. Ananda Marga, and me as its representative, were blamed for her leaving her family to follow the spiritual life. In the market place, people would always be looking at me, and saying that he is the one taking the girl away. This affected all the local people. They were very angry. They would call me a 'girl thief'. Everyone would close the doors on me. They would speak behind my back, but when I would look at them, no one would say anything to me. I didn't mind the trouble, as Bábá was with me. Slowly, as this anger built, there were plans to attack me.

This Didi also had a younger sister, who was very supportive of her sister and of Ananda Marga. She gave me information that the family was planning to attack. I decided that I would just not go at the time they had arranged or go somewhere else. The younger sister would keep informing me of their plans and I would keep evading them. Every night I was looking at Bábá in my dreams and in sáadhaná. I was working very hard, that time. Running the school, I realised how hard it is for mothers to take care of children.

Bábá shifted to Ranchi from Ánandanagar. There was the March 1967 incident. Five Dádás were killed at Ánandanagar. Disgruntled local villagers had attacked them. I had been transferred at end of January. If Bábá had not sent me away to the school that may have been me killed.

The heat of the day is coming down on the rooftop now and we decide to finish here. Dádá escorts me down to the ground floor and I namaskár goodbye and head off to the Central Office.

Later in the day at the Office I am told that Bábá will not be giving Darshna today. I notice three Didis waiting for Bábá outside His office door, each with a small clay pot of Bengali *rasagollá* sweets floating in sugary syrup. When Bábá comes out of His private office, they present the rasagollás to Him as a simple gift and expression of their devotion. Bábá talks and laughs with them while sampling a sweet and is obviously pleased. He directs that the rest of the rasagollás be distributed to everyone present as prasád. At the door, as He is leaving, Bábá says to a Didi, “I will be giving Darshan tomorrow.”

“But I will be leaving tomorrow, Bábá”, she complains.

“Then I will give Darshan after you leave,” replies Bábá, cutting jovially through her comment.

Dádá Keshavánanda sits down across from me at the lunch bench. “Jiñáneshvar, have you heard about the new Global Jágrti here in Calcutta?”

“Yes Dádá. Bábá has mentioned it to me and said márgiis should own their own Jágrtis and build a similar construction.”

“You may be able to see it soon, but not right now as Tiljala is not a safe area to go yet.”

“Why did the Global Jágrti get built there?” I ask.

Dádá goes on to explain:

After the Lake Gardens Márga Guru quarters were built, márgiis have started to come more in numbers from all India and around the world. It is becoming difficult to accommodate all these márgiis in Lake Gardens, in the grounds or the hall. So Bábá said, ‘You should find a roomier place where you can have a big hall and space where márgiis can sit.’ Bábá has guided what type of land and where to get the land. He told clearly, ‘don’t try to get the land just by the side of the road. If it is roadside you will get costly land, so try to get it away from the road.’ To get a loan was a big problem as this was a large piece of land.

After looking for some time, all of a sudden one person appeared, I think this might have been Bábá’s creation. This man, a non-márgii, heard we were looking and came to us, saying he knows some persons and they might be able to help with the land. I told Bábá this and He said, ‘For good work, if anyone comes to help you, you should take help.’ This person started looking here and there and he found an old man from Varanasi who had a large plot of land in Tiljala, on the outskirts of Calcutta. He was contacted about that land. We reported this to Bábá and He said, ‘Yes, yes, ok and in the future it will develop very nicely. Ok, go ahead.’ This resulted in two acres being purchased in Tiljala, near the Eastern Metropolitan Bypass road. There was no road to the land, just a dirt track. On the day it was reported to us that the land was acquired, Bábá said the next day, ‘You should have a boundary.’ On this direction from Bábá, we immediately constructed a large boundary wall around the Tiljala property.

There have been many problems as this is a CPM communist party stronghold area at Tiljala and they have attacked the property many times, throwing rocks and charging the gates. They do not want to allow Ananda Marga to settle there. Two or three times this boundary wall has fallen down due to these attacks, but we rebuilt it. When we applied for the building permit it was not approved, again because they opposed Ananda Marga. Then after three months, our solicitor was telling, there is some clause in the High Court, that if permit authorities are not responding, we can go ahead and build. This is what happened.

“When can I go to see the Global Jāgrti Dádá?” I asked.

“Soon it may be arranged. How long will you be here in Calcutta?”

“A couple of more weeks, I think, Dádá.”

“Then this may be possible.”

Come evening, it is raining hard and the three of us, Púrña Premá, Áshrava and I, are huddled under a large umbrella borrowed from the guards room, but still joyfully doing kiirtana. Bábá comes down, followed closely by VSS with an even larger umbrella and Dádá Yatiishvaránanda with his own small umbrella. Bábá is holding His dhoti raised a little to prevent it getting wet. Despite the rain Bábá stops next to us and says, “I think you are being drenched? Drenched in the rain of Divine Bliss... In the what?”

I reply, “In the rain of Divine Bliss, Bábá.”

He turns to Dádá Yatiishvaránanda who is accompanying Him and asks, “Yatish, in the what?”

“In the rain of Divine Bliss, Bábá.”

“Remove the umbrella of ego and you will be drenched in the shower of Divine Bliss. Go to the meditation room”¹, Bábá directs us.

As He drives off for the evening, we scuttle through the downpour and into the sanctuary of the meditation room at the front of the house. Here we sit and do some kiirtana and commence our sádhaná. Some

time into my meditation the thought occurs to me that we should have held Dharmacakra. Was this what Bábá was directing us to do? I put aside this thought and return to my mantra. This meditation room has a deeply peaceful vibration that allows me to sink into a serene state easily. It feels like the boundaries of my body slowly dissolve and my sense of self spreads out becoming part of a larger world. The rain begins to ease and when Bábá returns, we are back doing kiirtana in the driveway, with no need of an umbrella. Seeing us there, Bábá cryptically comments as He passes, “I see that you did not get drenched.”

Wednesday 2/4

In the morning Bábá inspects His garden, again inquiring about the plants and giving directions to Dádá Akṣayánanda. Today, He pays particular attention to a rose bush. When He finishes, He comes over to us and asks, “Is everything going properly? Is everything going smoothly?”

“Yes Bábá,” we reply. Two Filipino Didis approach with garlands for Bábá and as they present them to Him, He inquires with mock surprise and enthusiasm as if it is the first time this has been done, “Is this for me?” and again to the next, “Is this for me also?” How many untold thousands of garlands has Bábá been presented and yet He still approaches each presentation anew and gives the devotee His complete attention in that moment, fresh and one hundred per cent present. I have never seen Bábá or heard of Him being grumpy or unpleasant towards a person. He then moves on and begins speaking with two brothers for some time about pronunciation. I have come to realise linguistics is one of His favourite topics. As Bábá gets into the car He comments to these Didis, “I have learnt so much from you. You know so much and I am just Bábá, I know so little.”

When He is sitting in the car waiting to drive off, Púrñá Premá asks Him, “Is everything growing nicely in the garden, Bábá.”

He tilts His head once to the side and replies simply, “Ok.”

Later, the three of us walk over to the Office. Once there, Áshrava sits talking with Didi Ánandakaruná and I accompany her, listening in. Áshrava inquires about Auntie's health and if she needs anything. Didi assures Áshrava that Auntie, although struggling with some health problems, is not in any need. Rather, Auntie is an inspiration to all the Didis, although they too worry a little about her health. Didi Ánandakaruná explains that Auntie is always rising above any problem she may have and maintaining a happy disposition. She is steeped in her devotion.

I decide to line up while waiting for Bábá to come. I position myself at the bottom of the stairs in a row of márgiis stretching out to the street. When He does arrive, Bábá passes down this line, stops near me, does namaskár, and then continues up the stairs and into the Office. As I follow amongst the crowd of devotees, Raghu see me. He motions for me to come into his little transcription office. There he cheerfully hands over the cassette deck and reminds me that this is only for a few days as there will be more transcription work to be done very soon.

In the evening, on returning from field walk with some Indian márgiis, Bábá stays at the car continuing an animated talk to them in Bengali, but dropping in phrases in English, "Do you understand..., and this is why...", that intrigues us English speakers to know what the subject is that is so interesting. Finally, He turns and includes us in the conversation, explaining in English that He is speaking about the two systems of inheritance in India, the Hindu 'Mitakṣarā' and the Bengali 'Dáyabhága'. The Bengali is a personal system, Bábá says. He explains at length how the systems operate and that the courts would recognise one or the other. Finishing, He says, "In our PROUT we follow the Dáyabhága system."

The márgii brother who had originally asked Bábá the question during field walk replies with enthusiasm, "Yes, this is what I wanted to know, Bábá."

Bábá grasps the márgii's hands in His own and with an earnest expression of understanding says to him, "I know it, I know it. That is why I said so much to my little boy."

Bábá goes upstairs, but we stay on talking with the other márgiis until much later. When Áshrava and I finally decide to go it is quite late. Walking down the road and realising the lateness, Áshrava calls out to a rickshaw wallah, “Rickshaw to Gol Park?” With a wave of his hand and happy to have a fare at this time of night, he motions us over to climb aboard. We negotiate the price, climb up and set off. Traffic is very light at this time of night and the driver pedals easily along the straight stretch of road back towards our hotel. Many shops are shut, houses dimly lit and all is quiet. The air is pleasantly warm and humid, cooled by the breeze from our cycling speed while we cruise along. As we approach a large body of water on the side of the road, a delicate floral perfume scent wafts across to us from some night flowering plant. Áshrava comments, “What is that beautiful scent.” “It could be jasmine, or frangipani or even tuberose,” I offer, breathing in the heady perfume. Just then as we look at the expanse of water, still as glass, the waning full moon comes into view from behind clouds and is doubly reflected in the water. Everything seems to be lit with an ethereal glow. This is one of those perfect moments that stays in my mind and represents the beauty of India that I find so attractive. Áshrava and I look at each other and feel that tenderness of love that flows when people are touched by such beauty. We bask in the scent, the light and the tenderness of the moment.



It's So Long that I Have Been Away from You

Thursday 3/4

Next morning Bábá takes a tour of His garden, examining and admiring the plants. The orchids look like they are standing up bright and sparkling for His inspection, showing off all their flowery talents. We are doing kiirtana and become enthused and vibrated with our chant while watching Him stroll around the garden. We are singing our joy directly to Him and our joy shows. We are also standing tall and freely expressing our colours. The scene reminds me of one of those pictures of Kṛṣṇa and his entranced devotees, the Gopiis, in a colourful forest setting. As Bábá comes over from His garden inspection, He inquires, “And what do they say? They are doing kiirtana?” Immersed still in the vibration of the kiirtana I simply reply, “We are saying ‘Bábá náma kevalam’, Bábá.”

“And you are doing kiirtana with Madhu?”

Áshrava, holding the guitar replies, “Yes, Bábá.”

“Very good. Very good.”

Once Bábá has gone, Áshrava and I proceed into the meditation hall and set up the cassette player acquired from Raghu yesterday. Púrña Premá and Shivaprabhá join us in our new recording studio for the first session. Áshrava is the chief singer and guitarist and has written up a list of devotional bhajans songs and kiirtana tunes that we can put onto the tape. I hand out photocopied sheets with the words to the songs. The four of us sit in a semicircle in front of the altar, with Bábá's picture before us and begin with the kiirtana tune that Bábá has liked so much

from the Spanish song. This rouses our spirits as we warm up with it. I do a sample recording on the cassette and play it back for all to hear. Not too bad for a single in-built microphone and tiny recording level meter. I move the deck a bit closer and put it up on top of the harmonium box to pick the voices up more as the guitar is quite loud and we're right. Beggars can't be choosers and we make the best of what we have at hand, remembering that devotion is the measure.

Now we are ready to record this first song. I click on the cassette recorder. Lightly strumming our new guitar, Áshrava slowly rolls out the Spanish song, singing the '*Hace mucho tiempo*' with her deep melodious voice. Gradually Púrñá Premá, Shivaprabhá and I join in, lightly introducing percussion with drum and cymbals. We sing on and on, slowly building up the tempo till we are in full flight and the sound reverberates around the empty hall giving a backing echo that sounds much more than our four voices. Áshrava changes from the Spanish words to the kiirtana chant in the same tune and we follow her lead. This begins a new level as again we progress the song up to another crescendo. Here we are in the *Dhyán Mandir*, meditation hall of Báábá's house, singing for Him. My voice soars, as do the others in our little band of devotees.

For our second song Áshrava soulfully sings out one of my favourite devotional songs that she wrote:

Rest my soul awhile. Dry my tears awhile. It's so long that
I have been away from You.

And though I wandered many lifetimes to be with you again.
I sometimes remember the way it was when, we would be
together, walking hand in hand. We would be in perfect harmony,
you see, for there was only you and me.

So rest my soul awhile. Dry my tears awhile. It's so long that I
have been away from You.

Though I've searched the narrow pathways and the winding
corridors, clambered over brambles and injured by the falls, it's
You and me together and I'll fight all hell and fire, if it'll bring
me to You once more, my Lord.

So rest my soul awhile. Dry my tears awhile. It's so long that I have been away from You.

Though I've wandered many lifetimes to be with You again, though the pain is sometimes love and the love is sometimes pain, but when You hold me in Your arms, I know only one thing, that I can never leave You again, my Lord.

So rest my soul awhile. Dry my tears awhile. It's so long that I have been away from You.

My heart just calls out at these simple words. They express a sense of alienation from a Oneness that it seems I have experienced in a previous existence. A Oneness that had fulfilled me in every way. But only after an excruciating search for something, looking for a power greater than me, that I intuitively knew existed, did I again in this lifetime find this Divine Existence behind the veil of *máyá*, worldly illusion. This Divine longing can sometimes make living in the world hard and seemingly meaningless, unless that Divine is seen embodied in all of creation, the animate and the inanimate. Then it becomes a *lilá*, a Divine play, and a devotion of service to the created form. I dry the trickle of tear from my eye and join in the singing; with gratitude towards the depth of feeling and wealth of experience that life has afforded me.

We rehearse each new song, getting our timing co-ordinated and then sing with gusto on the recording, pleased with the project set before us. I am very happy to be able to do this small thing asked of me by Bábá. That I am able to give Him something in return for all that He has given and in this express my devotion.

I realise that we have possibly very limited time to use the cassette recorder as it may be called back to Central Office at any moment. So we plan to complete the tape in a couple of days of sessions. The tape is edited in the machine as best as I can, listening back to the recorded song to check if it is technically satisfactory. Each new song is followed by a *kiirtana* in that tune.

We come back early in the evening to continue our recording and get to complete one side. Then it is outside to do *kiirtana* in the

driveway before Bába comes down. Having just earlier recorded the Chilean kiirtana, we are inspired and are now playing this same tune in full flight using guitar, drum and cymbals. Our spirits are soaring with the rhythm and revolutionary sentiment of the original song. Bába comes downstairs, walks up to us as we are singing and says, “This tune is so charming, so attracting, extremely fascinating, marvellous. I am extremely pleased.” We continue singing until Bába has left for field walk and then we go to the meditation hall. Sitting in deep meditation, I feel that ‘drenching from Divine Bliss’ that Bába had previously mentioned.

After returning from field walk, Bába stops next to the car and speaks in Bengali with the Dádás who have accompanied Him, about some engaging subject from the walk. We are gathered around next to them and in the middle of discussion, Bába suddenly turns to me, pointing with His finger and saying, “And you...what is the effect of nature on human psychology and human psychology on human psychology? This is a very knotty problem. Not ‘knot’ in the sense of bad, but knot like this... [He demonstrates by linking His fingers together and spelling out] ...K.N.O.T. Do you understand?”

“Yes, Bába.” I simply reply, rather stunned at the sudden question and direct attention. Although I understand the words, I do not understand the significance of what He has asked me and fail to follow up with a request for further explanation.

Bába then walks on to the doorway, stops and asks one of the Dádás accompanying Him, “And what did I say?” The Dádá begins to answer in Bengali, but Bába interrupts and in English says, “No, no. What is the effect of nature on human psychology and human psychology on human psychology? If there is a good little girl [He looks at Púrña Premá] and she comes in the company of a bad man, then after some time her mind will become a little...rough. And so, you see the effect of human psychology on human psychology. And the effect of nature on human psychology? You are living in a slum area like in Calcutta or Hong Kong, then your mind will become a little...disgusted...uurrr... [Bába shakes His head and hands in a shiver with this utterance to illustrate it

a little better]. If you are living in a garden with sweet scenting flowers. Is it scenting or scented?"

Dádá answers, "Scenting."

"Yes, scenting when it comes from it, scented when perfume is added, like scented handkerchief. When you are in a garden smelling the fragrance of sweet flowers, then your mind will become poetic, like a poet."

Púrńa Premá comments, "Like in Digha, Bábá?" This was the beach town Bábá went to for His holiday break and where Púrńa Premá was inspired to write poetry. Bábá laughs and does a strong namaskár to all, then leaves for His rooms. Is Bábá giving me a message here? Is this something I should learn back-the-front. He has certainly emphasised this point well. It seems He passes on key points to devotees in this way.

Friday 4/4

This morning we do not make it to Bábá's house to see Him go on morning field walk, but later in the day go to the Office to hear Him give Darshan. To everyone's surprise, Bábá gives the Darshan completely in English. He speaks about how no philosophy has yet been able to achieve the balance between the internal and the external and that this is the greatest tragedy of human society. He goes on to explain that it is essential that there be harmony between the internal man and the external man.^K While Bábá prepares to leave, Áshrava and I line up with other márgiis along the wall before the stairwell. As we are standing there with palms together in namaskár, Bábá walks past, commenting to us, "I do not think there is need for English rendition, but certainly it must be translated into Bengali."^v

Áshrava, Púrńa Premá, Shivaprabhá and I gather in the meditation hall in the late afternoon. This session, we must finish to music tape as the deck is to be returned tomorrow on Raghu's request. Two rosy dim

v The audio copy of this Darshan is no longer available and no known transcription was ever made.

wall lamps cast a soft glow about the darkening room. Storm clouds are gathering and the air is thick and sultry. We can't have the overhead fans on as they may create too much noise on the tape, so we sit in the humidity and soak.

I start the recording and Áshrava begins with the bhajan 'We feel the softness of Your soul, my Lord'. And I do feel it. Singing bhajans and doing kiirtana for Bábá in this Dhyán Mandir, meditation hall, is very special, even just sitting in here the vibration is palpable. Bábá told once that 'if He stays in a place even for a day His vibration can be felt by a sadhaka, if he does sádhaná even for a while. If He stays in some place for even a few hours a sadhaka can feel the vibration after doing kiirtana for a while. Even if His stay in a place is only for a few seconds a sadhaka can feel the vibration by doing kiirtana for a bit longer time.'¹⁹

The three of us join in singing with Áshrava:

Take my hand and lead us on, Bábá, with your love.

We don't ever want to leave your side Lord',

We sing on, then continue into kiirtana... 'Bábá náma kevalam'. This longing for the Divine, for the Supreme is so strong, how can I ever forget such attraction.

A resounding 'thunk' reverberates through the suburb, startling us, as power sharing cuts the electricity and all the lights go out and electrical items grind to a halt. There is silence for a few minutes until the guards kick over the great hulking petrol generator outside and a couple of lights flicker on. This only adds to the atmosphere in the hall, but now we have the constant rattle-hum of the generator in the background. The mains electricity may be out for a long time, but we must press on and complete the recording. While we progress through the songs the growing storm outside builds and finally breaks with a thick downpour punctuated with flashes of lightning and cracks of thunder that become a background to our singing and go onto the recording.

Áshrava has taken us through a cycle of sweet, then rousing, then longing bhajans songs and as I estimate we are nearing the end of the

tape, we decide to finish off with the Spanish kiirtana. All of us throw ourselves into this rousing tune and I think of Bábá's pleasure at hearing it the other night when He commented, "This tune is so charming, so attracting, extremely fascinating, marvellous. I am extremely pleased." My wish is that our sincerity, our bhakti, our devotion will again bring Him pleasure through this tape. What else do I have to give an infinite being, an enlightened one, but my love, my longing to be one with that Supreme Entity? At times like this it's like I can feel lifetimes of this pursuit, this spiritual path. There is a mix of the pain of separation and a longing, with a profound love and gratitude for this creation and 'That', which is behind it, encompassing and pervading the entire universe. Words fail me in description and I am left with a New Age compilation of words that just does not do justice to the depth of my feelings.

The Spanish kiirtana vibrates throughout the meditation hall, through us and through the tape. There is a click of the cassette button and we have completed the tape. Áshrava has drawn up a simple cassette cover for the box with a title. We name the tape 'Madhu Giita', with no pun intended this time on the guitar, but meaning sweet songs. It is nearing time when Bábá will come for His field walk, so we go out to the driveway to continue our kiirtana.

Eventually, when Bábá comes down to the driveway, we finish our kiirtana and Áshrava steps forward to present Him with a large garland of Tuberose flowers, Bábá's favourite so we are told. He puts it over His head, namaskárs and then gives it to Dádá Rámánanda to hold. I then step forward and present the kiirtana tape, 'Madhu Giita', to Bábá, saying, "We have finished the kiirtana tape for you Bábá." He does not hear properly over the noise of the generator and Dádá Rámánanda takes the tape to see, and then explains to Bábá that it is a music tape. Bábá takes the tape, saying to me, "Is this for me?" "Yes, Bábá", the four of us declare. He then places the tape to His forehead between His hands as in a blessing, and then leaves for field walk.^{vi}

vi A copy was made of the Madhu Giita music tape and is available on the authors website along with additional photos.

Upon returning, Bábá alights from the car and stands before the devotees present. After returning everyone's namaskár, He holds a mini-Darshan expounding:

There must be an adjustment between the individual and collective psychology. The individual must surrender to the collective interest. The unit must think for the collective welfare or else the future of the human psychology will be dark, in Cimmerian darkness. If the individual takes up spiritual practices and leads others to the path of spirituality, then the future of mankind will be very bright. You are standing on the horizon of the crimson dawn. The collective is the same as the Macrocosm – Parama Puruṣa. The only way is for all to surrender to Parama Puruṣa. How can we surrender? The way, the path is through spiritual practices. The collective flow is the same as the Macrocosm and the unit has to find the link between the Microcosm and the Macrocosm. Mysticism is the never-ending endeavour to find the link between the unit and Cosmic Consciousness. That is finite and infinite.^L

The days activities seem to have taken it out of me and tonight I am a bit tired, maybe I didn't take enough water during the heat of the day and I'm a little dehydrated. Áshrava is also ready for any early night and we head off to the Asia Hotel. This requires a rickshaw to Ramakrishna Mission roundabout and then a tram to the hotel. When we arrive it is enough to do the minimum and go to bed. I make a hasty decision to record Bábá's evening Darshan tomorrow, using the help of those who have also heard it.



An Outing to Tiljala

Saturday 5/4

Áshrava and I sleep in more than usual this morning and after a quick round of shower, ásanas and meditation, race off to Bábá's house. We arrive a little before He departs. When Bábá comes down for field walk, we are doing kiirtana and He comments to us, "You are doing kiirtana? With the help of Madhu?"

Áshrava responds, "Of course, Bábá." He drives off for His field walk and who knows what else, because today we have been told that there will be a special event and we are to meet over at the Central Office, but Bábá will not be there. In the rush of the day, I put off writing in my diary till later.

Áshrava and I catch a rickshaw to the Office and when we arrive the front of the Office street is crowded with a number of large rugged open-windowed buses. The mystery event is revealed – we are all going to Tiljala to visit the Global Jágṛti site. I have no idea where Tiljala is, except it is on the outskirts of Calcutta. There has been ongoing trouble with the Communists agitating against Ananda Marga having a presence in their stronghold area, but now that the large boundary wall is complete it is deemed ok to go out in strength of numbers to do a foundation stone laying ceremony. There are many márgiis and stacks of Ácáryas milling up and down the street in an excited festive mood. Áshrava has dressed in her lovely white sari trimmed in a light orange for this special occasion.

The word comes and the crowds start boarding the buses hired for the trip. Before long, there is barely standing room left on board and still there seems to be lots of márgiis waiting to get on. So it is push a little

more and another ten people scramble on board. None of this interferes with the jubilant mood and many márgiis are doing kiirtana and hanging out of the open windows chatting and laughing with friends.

Finally full, the first couple of buses roll forward with a lurch and a chug and we're off. The buses wind their way through the streets of Jodhpur Park, along Gariahat road and heading west, through Ballygunge. We are making our way to what is now the edge of suburban Calcutta and the newly constructed E.M. Bypass Road. I see rice paddy fields now, interspersed with simple brick dwellings and then we turn off the road to park on the verge of the Bypass road.

Everyone piles out of the buses and as I step down, I take a look around. We are in a dusty gravel space with a few brick single story residential buildings scattered about, all set in a flat rural landscape. The disembarked márgiis, led by a couple of Ácáryas, are turning up a grassy edged gravel road, more of a track, between these buildings. Áshrava and I follow. A gathering of locals stands outside their modest homes watching with interest as the márgii parade passes by. Large muddy-brown canvas tents are set up on the left side of the track. One Dada I ask tells me that these are for the hired itinerant labourers working on the Global Jágrti. Looking ahead past more tents set in grassy paddocks, I can see the corner of an immense brick wall over three metres high and stretching a long way either side.

Approaching the corner of this wall, I hear a groaning metal creak as a VSS guard pulls open fittingly massive iron gates and welcomes everyone into the Jágrti compound. Entering through the gates, I am surprised to find only an expanse of empty, grass area surrounded by the high brick wall. In the centre is a five-metre pole of bamboo flying the Ananda Marga flag of golden saffron with an orange swastika. There are a few small buildings on one side of the wall. This is as far as the construction has gone at this stage. All work has been centred on creating the massive security wall first. As the bus-loads of márgiis enter, the compound begins to stream with people. This crowd is liberally dotted with the brilliant orange saffron robes of Ácáryas.

After walking around the site and happily chatting with each other, everyone gathers in one far corner to begin the foundation stone ceremony. The crowd congregates in a semicircle around a prepared area that has a chair with a photo of Bábá placed upon it. Shivaprabhá has brought the guitar and she begins a kiirtana tune to which everyone sings and dances. At the conclusion of the kiirtana we sit to meditate for a short while and then an Ácárya reads the ceremony script from Bábá's book *Carya Carya*. Whereupon, Bhárata, Dr Burt Roberts, from the USA, comes forward to perform the official duty of laying the foundation stone, which he lowers into place in a bed of cement. With the ceremony finished, boxes of sweets are served out to everyone and then we head back out to the buses for the trip back to Jodhpur Park.^{vii}

In the evening Bábá again stops at His car after field walk and gives us His Darshan:

The whole universe is the conation of the cosmic entity. The unit, microcosm, should have adjustment with the macrocosm. Macrocosm has produced all of this universe. Conation: nation comes from the Latin 'Nat' meaning created at the same time. So, nation is people born at the same time. Conation: the Cosmic Entity has created this whole universe at the same time. The Cosmic Entity has created this world without any difference between the created beings.

For Him all are the same, whether educated or not educated, rich or poor. There are no senior or junior for Him. The microcosm is like a drop of water in a vast ocean. If the unit is removed from the Macrocosm, it will evaporate. It is the duty of the unit to remain merged with the vast ocean. Hence, if you want to exist you must merge your entity into that vast ocean of Cosmic Consciousness through sádhaná and service. To do this you must

vii I am unsure of this exact date, 5.4.80, for the Foundation Stone ceremony at the Global Jágri, but it did occur on a day around this date. Conversely, the booklet *Marga Guru's Quarters* (p.7) says: "Bábá performed the foundation ceremony (Shilányás) in May, 1980, of the Global Jágri." There may not be a conflict of dates here as Bábá may have done this in addition to the one by Bhárata.

behave properly. You must ascribe Godhood, Macrocosm-hood, by Guru Mantra for thinking and doing everything.^M

Again, after a long day, I leave writing of this Darshan until later. Now it is two days that I have not recorded what Bábá has been saying. The first time since I have been here that I have lapsed for so long. I plan to catch up the next day. I haven't told anyone that I have not been writing, not even Áshrava.

Sunday 6/4

We do not make it to Bábá's residence to see Him this morning. Later in the day, Áshrava and I proceed to the Office as Bábá will be giving another Darshan, but again it is in Bengali. I sit at the back alternating between meditating and watching Bábá as He speaks. When I do not have to listen to the words, then I can just watch Bábá's expressions and gestures. He is a lively and entertaining speaker.

Yajña – Gotra, Marriage and Last Rites

Bábá explains the tendency to collective living in some animals and human beings and in the case of humans this gave rise to the creation of defined gotra (group compartmentalization of society).

He states that women, who were considered equal in earlier society, had become subjugated through ritualistic marriage systems in these gotra. Bábá gives details of three practices from that time that stemmed from the forced subjugation of women, which are still enacted out symbolically today. There were often conflicts between different gotra and captured women may be made servants or made to marry, often being bought forcefully to the winning gotra by tying up and sometimes being struck on the head to subdue them, sometimes giving a bloody gash.

Today in Hindu wedding practices the tying up is symbolised by the tying of the bride and groom's clothing together in a wedding knot. The bloody gash has transformed into women applying the red vermilion in the crease on the top of the head to signify being married. Before going for marriage, the male would go

to his mother to let her know that he will be bringing a maid-servant (dásii) for her. The wife could only use the surname phrase dásii. Ananda Marga does not support these practices, as they are humiliating to women.

Bábá proclaims that practices like these have become a cause of division in society, full of superstition and great expense. They have created division between the rich and poor and reaffirms superstition in the society. They are of no relevance to today.²⁰

In the evening when Bábá comes down we are doing the Spanish kiirtana. He jovially says, “And what do they say...? And what do they say? They are doing kiirtana.”

Áshrava answered, “Bábá náma kevalam.”

“Was today’s Darshan intelligible? And have you asked for the English rendering?”

“No, Bábá.” “No! And why not?” He asks, puzzled.

“We will ask, Bábá.”

He softens, saying, “Maybe they were a little busy today. You should have it in a couple of days.” For some reason we do not see the significance of Bábá asking about the English rendition and make only half-hearted inquiries about translations. We never see a translation of any of these Darshans.

On His return from field walk, Bábá strides directly up the line of márgiis and stops before me. Pointedly He asks, “And what have you been doing? What have you been doing during the day? Kiirtana? Sádhaná?” I had been doing many daily chores as well as attending the Darshan at the Office, but nothing in particular to mention. Not fully understanding what Bábá is referring to and in a little trepidation about His directness, I take a total stab in the dark and stupidly reply, “Sádhaná and kiirtana ... Kiirtana with the help of Madhu?” I weakly offer this in the hope that I have the right answer to Bábá’s direct, probing question.

Then to my great surprise Bábá goes straight to the point and asks, “Have you recorded what I said last night?” I stop, caught out, mouth

gaping open. I have missed two days of writing, when usually I fill in my diary directly after the event or at the latest the very next morning. With a clench of my teeth I attempt to cover myself with the grimaced reply, “Part, Bábá.”

“Only part, but not all! You should have recorded all. For others. I have not said this previously in any Darshan, workers meetings or DMC. It should be recorded, not for you, but for others. You know so much. You are an ocean of knowledge.”

“Yes Bábá, I will get it all down.”

I am embarrassed and shocked. Bábá has driven the point home without any doubt on my part and He has motivated me to continue my writing. I see that this is not just for my personal curiosity anymore. It is to be shared with a wider audience. I have become a scribe. Bábá alludes to lots of things with devotees in His talks and asides, but when He gives a direct instruction, only a unworthy devotee would ignore it. I make the resolve to catch up the arrears immediately and keep a current record from now on. I check with Áshrava and other márgiis to get as best as I can what has been said in the previous two days. As a result, Bábá’s mini Darshans after field walk on these two days are not direct speech as on other days’ journal entries, but a general rendering of what He said.



A Very Good Name

Monday 7/4

Next morning Áshrava and I are at Bábá's house bright and early. Bábá comes down unannounced and alone. No-one is ready for His arrival and He begins to stroll around the garden by Himself. VSS immediately run after Bábá with an umbrella to shade Him from the hot morning sun. Bábá enjoys a leisurely stroll examining the plants, tenderly stroking particular ones that catch His attention and checking others for any ailment. Eventually He comes over to the driveway where a few márgiis, Áshrava and I included, are waiting. A Didi steps forward and hands Bábá a flower garland. Because she has given Him one the previous day, He enquires, "Another garland for me?"

"Yes Bábá. I am leaving today."

She then presents Him with a box of Bengali sweets and He says, "Before I make it prasáda, I will have to take a little bit, won't I?"

"Yes, Bábá." He then puts the box in namaskár to His forehead and quietly says a mantra, then proceeds over to His car. Leaning to the car window Bábá gives Áshrava a big smile and a namaskár. She returns His greeting and asks Him, "Is your leg better Bábá?"

"Oh, yes, it is nearly all..." He gestures with an evaporative flick of His fingers at the end of this sentence indicating that it is gone.

Later in the morning, Áshrava and I, on one of our trips into the bustling city centre of Calcutta, come across a small bookstall in Chandni Chowk market area. It is poked between a chai shop of equally micro proportions and a street stall spread with everything required in

stainless steel kitchenware – cups, bowls, graters, pots, cutlery, vases, thali trays and cauldrons, all arrayed in sparkling splendour under the growing heat of the morning sun. I don't know what made me stop at this stall, but books have always attracted me from an early age. Despite growing up in a literature sparse working class household, I had haunted the school library, borrowing every book I could to read during school holidays, while friends played cricket outside. By my mid teens esoteric texts attracted me and I was studying numerology and palmistry. I wasn't just an academic book adherent, lighter comic-book entertainment also attracted me for its simplicity and visual images, but it usually had to have some interesting meaning mixed with the light story amusement. I wasn't interested in the beat-em-up popular super heros, but comics like 'Dr Strange' and his esoteric occult adventures had a special lure for me.

Rummaging through the piles of dusty, mouldy bundles of books in Chandni Chowk seeking a bargain, I see a pile of Indian children's comics based on stories from the Mahábhárata, Rámáyana, Saints lives and Independence Freedom Fighters. I give them a cursory flip through and stop. There is one titled, 'Jñáneshwar'. Surprise, surprise, I had never known there was such a public personage. I pay the few rupees cost and take my find away to read.

Over a large veg samosa and chutney sauce, I also devour the comic on Jñáneshwar and am hungry for more. We head back to the suburbs and the Ramakrishna Áshram library. Here in their air-conditioned luxury I read everything I can find on this Jñáneshwar.

Jñáneshwar was an elevated yogi of the thirteenth century, renowned as the author of the Jñáneshwari, a commentary on the Bhagavad Gíitá, sometimes referred to as the Bible of Hinduism, such is its importance as a seminal text.

Jñáneshwar was a social and spiritual reformer. The Jñáneshwari was more than just an eloquent commentary rendered in exquisite poetic form, it translated Kṛṣṇa's great treatise on the spiritual path from the then little known Sanskrit into the local Maráthi language so that all people had access to this revealing epic. In

ways like this, Jñāneshwar challenged the entrenched Brahmin caste religious and social control, giving the power of spiritual knowledge and practice back to all the masses.

Jñāneshwar (meaning Lord of Knowledge), also known as Jñānadeva, was one of the greatest saints of Maharashtra State in India. He was a Yogi of high spiritual attainments who laid the foundation of the great Bhakti movement in Maharashtra in the thirteenth century that still flourishes today. Jñāneshwar's biographical details are scant, variable in different tellings and probably elaborated over time into mythical proportions. This notwithstanding, Jñāneshwar's difficult family circumstances reflected upon his life's outlook and actions. His contribution to spiritual progress is evident in his written works. Jñāneshwar's blend of knowledge, devotion and social responsiveness by making elevated philosophy palatable for the masses touched a deep responsive chord in me, reflecting my own interests. Here was another role model to espouse in this namesake.

Jñāneshwar's father, Vithalpant, while young, was a Brahmin with strong religious inclination and aspirations to become a renunciant. While passing through the village of Alandi, which is near Pune, on a pilgrimage, he was offered the hand of Rukminibai as a suitable pious match, but being disinclined to the householder life, he refused. That night in a dream, he received a divine command to marry Rukminibai that was so compelling he could not refuse. They married, but over time the dream's potency waned and Vithalpant again yearned for a renunciant monk's life, particularly when the death of both his parents in quick succession unsettled his security in life.

Unable to control his growing conflict with his religious desires and family life, he ran off to Varanasi and secretly took Sannyāsa from Swami Ramanand, without revealing that he was married, and stayed in the Swami's ashram. Rukminibai eventually found out Vithalpant had left to become a renunciant and was deeply shocked. She prayed to God fervently to be reunited with her husband.

Events were being manoeuvred for a greater purpose and as it happened, Swami Ramánand, passing through Alandi, stopped at the Mareih Temple where Rukminibai worshipped. Not knowing him, she bowed to the Swámi in respect and he blessed her suitably as a married woman in those times, saying, “May you be the mother of many sons.” Unable to contain her sorrow, she wept bitterly at the seeming impossibility of this, much to the surprise of the Swami. Upon inquiry, Rukminibái revealed her sorry tale of estrangement and at the mention of Vithalpant, the Swámi realised he was the unwitting initiator of inappropriate *Sannyása*. Swami Ramanand immediately returned to Varanasi and while rebuking his disciple, commanded Vithalpant to return to his family duties with his blessings.

Vithalpant followed his teacher’s instructions and resumed family life, but the rigid orthodox Brahmins of Alandi declared that it was against the scriptures to return to married life again after taking *Sannyása*. Vithalpant and Rukminibai were cast out from the Brahmin community and forced to live outside the village confines in isolation and humiliation.

In this uneasy mix of thwarted and granted desires, wishes and hopes, the couple lived a pious life and raised four extraordinary and gifted children, Nivrittináth, Jñánadeva, Sopán and Muktabái, who excelled in study of the spiritual scriptures and Sanskrit taught to them by their father.

As the children grew up, Vithalpant and Rukminibai saw it as necessary to have performed the Brahmin sacred thread ceremony that would initiate the children into the Brahmin caste and all the consequent privileges, both social and religious. The Brahmins of Alandi flatly refused such a request to the outcasts.

In a dejected mood, Vithalpant took his family to Nasik to perform some purificatory rites with the vain hope that this might assist. During their pilgrimage, as they rounded the Brahmagiri mountain, the family encountered a tiger. In fear for their lives, they ran in all directions. The family regrouped further down

the mountain, but the oldest child, Nivrittináth lost his way in a violent storm that suddenly ensued just when the tiger had appeared. Unable to find Nivrittináth, the rest of the family sadly returned home. The parents were even more miserable without him than before.

Nivrittináth meanwhile found a cave and was drawn to enter. There he came upon the sádhu Jñánináth of the Náth sect of Yogis. Jñánináth initiated Nivrittináth and over an intense week, taught him the secrets of the Tantra yoga of Shiva originating from the Kaula sect. With this knowledge, Nivrittináth returned home. He in turn, under the direction of Jnaninath, initiated Jñáneshwar who then initiated Sopán and Muktabái. With these practices the children advanced along the spiritual path at a rapid pace, belying their already advanced spiritual nature. Around this time Nivrittináth was ten years old and Jñáneshwar was eight. Jñáneshwar is later reputed to say that his intelligence matured as a result of the austerity of truthfulness practised by him in his former births.

Some time passed and in desperation to obtain Brahmin-hood for their children, the parents again tried for acceptance. The Alandi Brahmins declined with dire pronouncements that the children could not be considered as Brahmins as the scriptures did not allow the performance of the thread ceremony of a Sannyásin's children and therefore the sacred ceremony was an impossibility.

Realising the futility of acceptance in Alandi, Vithalpant and Rukminibái declared they would travel to the major town of Paithan with the possibility of obtaining a letter of purification (*shuddhipátra*) that would then enable the ceremony. The Brahmin caste maintained its wealthy status and control of society by the rigid adherence to religious codes and expensive rituals that kept the majority in servile roles. To think outside this code or to make exceptions was to place this privilege in jeopardy. The new plan of obtaining a letter of expiation worried the parochial Alandi Brahmins who felt it could seriously

undermine their authority in the community. In a cunning move to solve this dilemma, the Brahmins suggested that Vithalpant and Rukminibái, having violated the sacred laws of the scriptures, could only redeem themselves by sacrificial drowning in the sacred Ganges and this might allow acceptance of their children.

Inconsolable and in total desperation to do what they saw as their social and parental duty to their children, Vithalpant and Rukminibái sacrificed their lives at the confluence of the Ganga and the Yamuná rivers at Prayág (Allahabad). By this they thought that the Brahmins would take pity on their sons and perform the required sacred thread ceremony, but this was to be in vain.

To the children Brahmin status did not matter. Still, they wanted to fulfill the dying wish of their parents and left for Paithan to apply for the letter of purification from the learned Brahmins there. But again, the Brahmins were obstinate.

In an attempt to show their preparedness, Jñāneshwar exhibited his required learning by reciting the Vedas in Sanskrit. The Brahmin priests demanded he stop as only Brahmins were permitted to recite the Vedas. Jñāneshwar countered that anyone may recite the Vedas; even the buffalo standing nearby them had that right. To show their learned superiority and to distract from his assertion, the Brahmins questioned Jñāneshwar as to whether the buffalo had a soul. Jñāneshwar, even at this young age, was already immersed in the oneness of God and replied that the One Soul existed in all things. So saying, he placed his hand upon the buffalo and it began reciting the Vedas to the utter amazement of the learned Brahmins. This is the first record of Jñāneshwar's *siddhis* (mystic powers). Bested intellectually and spiritually, but entrenched in their arrogance, the Brahmins still refused to perform the thread ceremony.

This train of events throughout childhood led Jñāneshwar and his siblings to champion the cause of the disenfranchised masses. They embraced the ascetic life with no need for the

Brahmin thread and travelled widely on pilgrimages, sharing their knowledge with any who came to them. Even renowned sages such as the self-important yogi, Chang Dev, proud of his yogic powers and ostentatious in behaviour, payed their respects to Jñāneshwar, but only upon meeting him and encountering his intellectual and spiritual elevation. During this time all four children became great saints.

In Newasa on the Prarasa River, Jñāneshwar healed a Brahmin, Satchidānanda Pava of an incurable disease and he became a devoted follower. At the Mahālayādevi temple in Newasa, before a large audience, Jñāneshwar composed the Jñāneshwari. Satchidānanda was the scribe while the thirteen-year-old Jñāneshwar dictated. The Jñāneshwari rendered the Gītā into the local Marathi and elaborated on it with allegorical stories in beautiful poetic form that captivated his audience, who up until then only had access to the Gītā through the Brahmin priests as it was in little-read Sanskrit.

At this first discourse of the Jñāneshwari in the Mahālayādevi temple, there was another great saint in attendance, Nāmadev, a Bhakti Yogi, worshipper of the personal aspect of God. Together Jñāneshwar and Nāmadev struck up an instant friendship and they developed a balanced spiritual path of Bhakti and Jñāna – devotion and knowledge, from each other's experiences. Nāmadev introduced Jñāneshwar to all the saints of the Varkari Sect of which he was a member. They were so impressed by Jñāneshwar that they became his followers.

Jñāneshwar forged a Bhakti path that blended the seemingly paradoxical stance of the impersonal Jñāna with that of ecstatic devotion and divine love inherent in the Bhakti approach. One prevalent approach of Advaita, still espoused today, says only pure consciousness is real and the world around us is māyā, an illusion that traps us from the reality of God Oneness. The Bhakti path says this approach is creating duality and holding the aspirant in illusion.

Jñāneshwar promoted both Jñāna and Bhakti as a unified approach without contradiction. This can be explained in the allegory that if God (Pure Consciousness) is the witnessing entity, it is also the creator of the universe, and Consciousness itself is the substance this universe is made out of. If there is God and an illusion, then this is duality. The only illusion is not seeing God in the universe itself; experiencing consciousness in every thing and person you meet. The essence of the Jñāna approach is correct, there is only one reality, one Supreme Being, monotheism. The Bhakti path emphasises the spiritual practice of experiencing God in all of the manifested universe and to serving God through that universe. The starting point of the Gītā is Arjuna's dilemma of action in the world, specifically on the battlefield. He would rather negate his responsibility of action. Kṛṣṇa rightly points out that action is required in the spiritual path, but in doing, to see God in all that you do and to give up the results of your actions to God. This is the paradox – to act as if it is your last day on earth, but to be dispassionate about the results, remaining centred in God. Bhakti, devotion, is the driving tool to bridge this paradox. As it is said, 'is the wave on the lake still not made of water?'

Jñāneshwar wrote many bhajanas (devotional songs) and travelled with Namadev on pilgrimages to many parts of India. As well as the Jñāneshwari, he also wrote the Amritānubhava, an account of his spiritual progress and experiences. Jñāneshwar returned to Alandi in 1296, where, at the age of 21 he entered into *Sanjivani Samādhi*, voluntarily giving up the body when entering deep Samādhi, and was buried in a cave. A temple was constructed around the cave and is still visited by many devotees, especially on Kārtiki Ekādashii (October–November). His brothers and sister followed him in Samādhi within an eighteen-month period.²¹

If I still had any doubts as to a worthy name, that also reflected my own inclinations, they were washed away by the story of this namesake, the thirteenth century Jñāneshwar. Although I have never heard Bábá

mention this Jñāneshwar, Bábá has Himself written extensively on the Gītā, giving clear explanation and clarification of Kṛṣṇa's spiritual discourses.

In the evening, I position myself at the front of the line of márgiis awaiting Bábá to come downstairs for field walk. When He arrives Bábá stops before me and asks in Bengali, “*Tomár nám ki?*” I still hardly know any Bengali and can't understand Bábá's question, but get the feeling that I should have. As I momentarily hesitate, the VSS guard accompanying Bábá says to me, paraphrasing Bábá, “What is your name?” Bábá shakes His finger at the VSS guard jovially castigating him that he shouldn't have told me. Regardless and relieved, I reply, “Jñāneshvar, Bábá.”

He nods and walks away saying very quietly, as if to Himself, “A very good name. A very good name.” Do I need further reminding?

When Bábá returns from field walk He gives another Darshan:

Our abode is not only this little earth, but it is the whole of the cosmos. That is the whole of the circum-rotarian planetary system. But mankind is divided by greed. The selfish people, they have divided humanity into several parts, by caste and creed, to make their dogma permanent. In Jamaica, I made the slogan: ‘Dogma, no more, no more. Humanity is one and indivisible. Do not try to divide it.’ You must decorate the whole of the circum-rotarian cosmos with your minds. The whole cosmos is our common patrimony, our common abode.^N

Turning to Púrñá Premá, He queries, “You, little girl, can you follow?”

“Yes, Bábá.” she replies. As Bábá walks past everyone to go to the stairs, He stops before me and does namaskár, which I reverently return, internally thanking Him for His guidance.



We are all Good People

Tuesday 8/4

Áshrava and I have been invited by an Ácárya, to visit an Ananda Marga primary school where he is the principal. It is in the northern Calcutta suburb of Maniktala. We don't know where this is, but are instructed to get a taxi and the driver will find the way from the address. The taxi driver, a burley fellow with a big smile, is all "Yes, yes, no problem, no problem."

We drive for some time down Gariahat road and along Chandra Bose road, traversing the east of the city centre. When the driver indicates that we have reached the suburb of Maniktala, he stops and asks a group of men sitting at a roadside tea stall for more specific directions to the school. They don't seem to have heard of it and the driver coasts further along the road to inquire. There are no street directories and everything goes on local knowledge and landmarks.

We drive past a huge match factory, where the driver informs us all the matches of India are made. Further along the road, talking to a local woman, he gets confirmation of the school and we seem to be going in the right direction. A few more turns and there it is. This is only a very small primary school, incredibly basic and run on a shoestring.

Áshrava and I enter a tiny gate into a rough dirt courtyard surrounded by a cluster of low set concrete buildings with iron roofs. The principal, Ácárya Amitábhánanda, is expecting us and comes out of the far room to greet us. He is very pleased to have us visit his humble school. Dádá tells us, "There are about thirty children attending this school. Many are from very poor families who would not otherwise have a chance at education. Let me show you the

classrooms.” Dádá leads the way into a small room crammed with children sitting at rough wooden desks.

The teacher, sitting at the front behind an old dilapidated office desk, stands up as we enter and instructs all the children to also stand. They are excited and boisterous until the teacher commands them to be quiet. Dádá Amitábhánanda introduces us and proposes that we teach an English language class to these children. Not having done this before, Áshrava and I leap in and improvise, telling the children about Australia and getting them to ask questions. Not surprisingly cricket keeps cropping up as a major subject of interest. The children are excited when I tell them that one of my sports teachers at high school was Rodney Marsh, a great Australian cricketer and wicket keeper. We keep them amused with stories about Australia and its geographical points of interest.

After twenty minutes, we are thanked and taken to another classroom by the principal, to repeat our performance. The classrooms are bare, with hardly anything on the walls and two small barred windows letting in air and light. The children have hardly any books and almost everything is rote learning from the blackboard at the front. The school uniform is a red shirt and black shorts for the boys and skirt for the girls. When asked about this, Dádá says, “Bábá has designated this colour combination for Ananda Marga primary schools as the colours resonate with the mind of the children at this age.” The children are a delight. They are all over us when they can be. They ask endless questions and stare unabashedly at our foreign faces. I don’t think this school has had *bideshi*, foreigners, visit here before.

One more class to converse with and then it’s photo time. The teachers shepherd all the children into a group before us. Áshrava and one of the teachers hold up a banner of the school behind them for me to photograph. When this is done, Dádá Amitábhánanda takes us into his office. While Áshrava and I have a cup of chai, Dádá tells us of the difficulty of service work and providing educational facilities on such little amount of donations and wishes that he could do more. But he proudly tells us a story of Bábá, “Many business men and capitalists

have told Bábá, ‘You work just with this Ananda Marga. This sádhana and service. And we will give you money for whatever you need, but do not continue with this Prout.’” Dádá explains, “These capitalists they do not want to see work that will have a profound social change happen in society, only the usual service programmes by religious groups, which although good, do not get to the real cause of the problems of suffering and inequality. This is why Bábá has created Prout.” Our chai finished, we gratefully thank Dádá and catch another taxi back to our hotel.

In the evening, we are doing kiirtana when Bábá comes down and He again asks, “What are they doing? They are doing kiirtana?” There is a Dádá here who has just finished his Ácárya training. Bábá asks him, “And what is your name?”

“Ácárya Siitikanthan, Bábá.”

“What does it mean?”

“Sweet voice, is it Bábá?”

“Sweet voice. Voice that produces honey.” Bábá walks on and holds a namaskár to everyone as He passes.

On return from field walk, Bábá again gives Darshan to the gathered group:

You remember what I said the last night about the macropsychic conation of the cosmic entity? What is conation? I said nation comes from ‘nat’ and conation means ‘born at the same time’. All of this universe was created at the same time. In the flow of *saiṅcara* there was not piece or part born here, but everything came... all of a sudden. This ‘all of a sudden’ was not at any particular time, but was beyond the periphery of time, in the eternal tempos. What is time? Time is the psychic measurement of motivity of action. Time is the creation of man. At this, ‘all of a sudden’ there was no microcosm, therefore no time. And, where were this little girl [indicating Púrñá Premá] and this respectable gentleman [indicating me] at that time? They did not exist. Man first came one million years ago. The apes were

man's grand ancestors. Protoapes and Prototherians. So, only when man came into existence was there time.^o

As Bábá begins to go, Dádá Rámánanda calls to Ácárya Siitikanthan, but uses an incorrect pronunciation of his name. Bábá quickly corrects Dádá Rámánanda and then elaborates on His previous explanation, “*Kanthan* means throat, the vocal cords [Here Bábá indicates the area on His throat]. *Siiti* means sweet. Voice as sweet as honey – nectar. You know nectar, from flowers. This is a good name.”

Dádá Siitikanthan says to Bábá, “Your name is better than mine, Bábá.”

Bábá counters, “Good, better, best. Your name is best. Maybe we should exchange names. I do not have as good a name as you.”

Dádá Siitikanthan, undeterred by Bábá's rebuke continues, “No, Bábá, your name is best”. Everyone breaks out into laughter at this insistence.

Interjecting, Dádá Rámánanda brings Bábá's attention to another new Ácárya, from the Philippines, Dádá Vishvabandhu, who steps forward, prompted by Dádá Rámánanda. Bábá namaskárs him and continues His name explanations, “*vishva* – in the solid structure there is a border, a boundary. Even though it is solid, there is still movement. *vishva* is also the whole, created universe. It is very big, but not infinite. Even though it is so big, still there is movement. Hence, it is called *vishva*. *Bandhu* means friend, but a special kind of friend. One who the bond is so intimately connected that he cannot tolerate to remain separated. Vishvabandhu is one who cannot tolerate being separated from the created universe, the suffering humanity. He must be there to serve the suffering humanity. This is a good name.”^p Turning to Dádá Siitikanthan, He continues, “Yours is also a good name.” Sweeping His hands around to include everyone, Bábá concludes, “We all have good names. We are all good people.”

Bábá has created a very intimate atmosphere at this stage. He walks with Dádá Siitikanthan to the stairs talking with him and we begin to do kiirtana. As Bábá walks up the stairs, He leans over to look back at

us and gives a pleasant chuckle. Life seems at its sweetest in moments like this.

Wednesday 9/4

I go late to Bábá's house, even though He has already left for His morning field walk and Office duties. I have arranged with Dádá Akśayánanda to talk and go on a little tour of some parts of Bábá's quarters. Dádá takes me to the rooftop where he shows me the rows and rows of potplants he tends for Bábá. As there are two levels of rooftop spanning most of the building, there are plenty of plants to see. Dádá points out special ones that Bábá pays particular attention to or has a particular interest in.

Dádá tells me, "Bábá is experimenting with vegetables to see which ones will grow well in parts of India for food crops." This is being done at Ánandanagar and Ánandasambodhi Master Units. "Along with this," Dádá continues, "Bábá is also interested in some very unusual plants. One is a carnivorous vine that grows in some parts of India. This is a very large vine that has a relatively fast rate of movement for a plant. I think that this plant may be on the edge between plant and animal. This vine grows up into trees and hangs in great thickets from them. It has been know that if a small cow, a calf, were to stand still for too long in the shade under one of these thickets chewing the grass, the vine would slowly encircle the cow until it is unable to escape. The cow is killed and eaten by the vine, sucking its juices out."

Dádá reassured me, "You are in no danger as this vine only grows in some very remote areas of India." Holding up a particularly beautiful yellow orchid for me to admire, Dádá continues, "Another plant of special interest to Bábá is a medicinal herb that is so potent, one leaf is sufficient to sustain life for a whole day and this could go on almost indefinitely as long as water is taken in sufficient quantity." "Can you show me these plants Dádá?" I ask with enthusiasm. "No, this is not possible. These plants are not here in Calcutta."

I am able to take a few photos of Dádá when I climb higher up on a watertank stand perched in one corner of the rooftop. He will also allow

me to take a few other photos throughout the house, but only in selected places. We go down the stair to the first floor. There is a decorative flowery white painted edge along each side of the grey marble step treads that catches my attention as we descend.

Dádá takes me into the entrance rooms before Bábá's personal quarters. This is the area I had previously come to for the mini Darshan and to wait for Personal Contact (PC) with Bábá. The walls are painted an apple green. The door frame to Bábá's room is sharply edged in shiny orange and the door hidden behind a lighter green striped curtain. Dádá explains that hangings and paintings on the walls have been presented to Bábá. In an adjacent room Dádá shows me the growing collection of artefacts that are becoming Bábá's museum. In here glass cabinets enclose many gifts presented to Bábá from márgiis around the world. These gifts either represent the culture of the presenter's country or are of particular spiritual concepts and traditions in harmony with the ideals of Ananda Marga. Amongst many items there are statues and pictures of Ramakrishna, Caetanya Maháprabhu, Shiva, Krśńa, Rabindranáth Tagore and pratikas; Bengali and other countries cultural icons; and the increasing range of fossil and archaeological items that Bábá collects on His tours. I am allowed to take some photos of these items.

Later in the day at Central Office, Áshrava and I, along with some other general márgiis, are requested to leave the upstairs area to create some space before Bábá comes out of His personal office to leave for Lake Gardens. As we descend the stairs, we hear Bábá exiting, and so wait at the bottom of the stairs. Bábá comes directly down and seeing Áshrava and me standing alone at the foot of the stairs, says to us in Bengali, "*Ki balche?*" I was hoping that Áshrava might be able to answer for us and I would smile along, but this was beyond her basic Bangla learning at this stage. We stand there mute in namaskár' pose. Then I brightly reply, "namaskár" in the slim hope that it goes with the question. Baba is never tiring in His encouragement. We find out later that Bábá was asking 'What do they say?' and missed our cue of 'Bábá náma kevalam.' Áshrava has at this stage been learning some Bangla, but even the simplest phrases still elude me. I think that there might be

a little piece missing in my language learning neural pathways, but I live in hope, Mashallah!

Come evening, we are all lined up awaiting Bábá and doing kiirtana. When He arrives, I am in my favourite spot at the beginning of the line, near the stairway entrance. Stepping out, Bábá namaskárs to everyone, glances at me, and then walks along the line of márgiis. Suddenly He stops and turns to Dádá Nirainjana from Australia, who is standing in the line and looks very intently at him, then continues, hands held in namaskár. Just before Bábá gets into His car He says to Dádá Rámánanda, “What are they doing? Rámánanda, what are they saying?”

“They are saying Bábá náma kevalam, Bábá.”

“With the help of Madhu or without Madhu?” He enquires.

“With Madhu, Bábá.” Now everyone is in on this play of Bábá’s.

On return from field walk, Bábá steps from the car and says to the awaiting márgiis:

Today, I will not say anything except one thing. You are here for a mission. Human life is a mission. You have come here to do something. Human life is an ideological flow and there is a mission before you. Your life is a mission, a goal. You must move towards that goal. The world is moving. We are also moving. Nothing is fixed or stationary. Life is meant for action, for doing. Never be stagnant. March on to that Supreme Goal. So, I would like you to go on doing your duty. Serve the suffering humanity.^o



When the Bliss Shone from the Master

Thursday 10/4

Today Bábá comes down quite early to tour the garden. After some striving, Áshrava and I have developed a routine of being a little early and are consequently here this morning to greet Bábá. We are told by Dádá Akśayánanda, “Bábá is fasting, but one day ahead of time. Dádá Rámánanda sets Bábá’s schedule, but he has been misinformed about the correct day. This is why Bábá has come down so early today.”

When Bábá finishes touring the garden, He talks with a sister from Bangladesh. They are standing on the edge of the garden area, near the driveway. Most of the half dozen devotees present are standing next to Bábá’s car, on the far side, a few meters away. Bábá stops and looks at everyone. He is just standing there, hands in a namaskár position at His chest, looking at everyone. This is a most peculiar look. It is not that He is doing anything different externally, but He does something through this look that I cannot explain. It is like some energy emanating from the closeness of His love for us. It is as if He is speaking to us on another level. What can I say! Although He is just standing there on the other side of the driveway looking at us with namaskár and smile, something else is happening. Everyone present can feel it. This builds to such a height that eventually everyone breaks out laughing at the sheer intensity. At this point, Bábá steps to the driveway and get into the car, nodding His head and chuckling to Himself.

When Bábá has driven off, I am still in amazement, my body abuzz. I turn to Áshrava, she is shaking her head and one hand is on her heart. She asks, “What just happened? Did you feel that? I nod my head. Stepping over to Dádá Akśayánanda I ask him about this experience with Bábá.

All smiles, he explains, “As a Sadguru, Bábá has perfect control over His faculties and the ability to affect others. He was doing this at the time. Sometimes Bábá shows a little of who He is to devotees, mostly He keeps this hidden, but He also has given demonstrations of this.”

Later Áshrava and I get Dádá to elaborate:

I have seen Bábá do things like this many times. As I said, sometimes He shows a little of who He is to devotees. In 1968, Bábá moved to Ranchi from Ánandanagar and there He began giving demonstrations of different spiritual states and phenomena to small groups of Ácáryas.

One day, Bábá was explaining about samádhi and the cakras, colours and sounds associated with it. Bábá wanted to demonstrate the sound *omńkára* [the sound of the first vibrational expression of creation, also om or aum].²² He did such that all the Ácáryas present would experience this sound. We could hear it for three hours. After Bábá had demonstrated this, we heard it everywhere we went for a three-hour period.

Another day Bábá expressed an interest in teaching us about two types of Tantra, *Vidyá* and *Avidyá*. *Vidyá* means light and *Avidyá* means darkness. Those doing magic, spells and involved in occult powers use *Avidyá*. There is no spiritual progress in this. As Ananda Marga is based on *Vidyá* Tantra, which we already knew, Bábá taught us about the process of *Avidyá*. However, He did not teach the *Avidyá* mantra that would activate the process. He asked us, ‘Do you want it?’

‘If you think we should have it Bábá,’ we replied.

‘No, no,’ said Bábá. ‘In the future, there will be so many clashes, so much conflict. If I teach it, then there will be harm to people. You may apply this power and it might go to harm others. So, better not to know.’

On the same day, Bábá taught us a process whereby you can die as per your wish. He taught us that process on that day. You can

willingly die at the moment of doing this process. Whenever you like you can die, any time any place. The other four people who learnt this process are now deceased. I am the only survivor. So, why did Bábá teach this? I do not know. A time may come when I need to apply it, who knows.

During this time, due to my sádhaná, I became aware that I could read people's minds. Initially I found this amusing and would test it out on people. But very quickly, I found that I also could not keep people's thoughts away from me. All the time I was being bombarded with the mundane thoughts of many people. This was unsettling my mind. I was finding it difficult to do my sádhaná. I did not want this thing.

Eventually, once while I was massaging Bábá, I took the opportunity to ask Him for something. I had never asked Bábá for anything before. Therefore, this time I said, 'Bábá, I want something from You.'

He said, 'Ask me and I will give it to you now.'

I continued, 'Bábá, I want to give up this thing, this reading minds, please take it away.'

Bábá asked me, 'Why? This could be very good for you.' For some time He continued to try to turn my request around despite my pleas. He tried to convince me by many appeals. I would be very popular. It would help my work. I would gain the respect of márgiis and the public. There would be no problems with money ever again. There were so many uses and benefits of this type of occult power. Nevertheless, despite Bábá's encouraging ways, I was determined in my request. I did not want this thing. He was testing me.

I was still massaging Bábá's feet during this conversation. He was silent for a while and then asked me not to touch His feet. I thought He might be angry. After fifteen or twenty minutes, He said to me ok or all right. The moment I heard this word, I became very light as if so many weighty things were removed

from my head. I was in a blissful state. From this moment on, this occult power was gone. Bábá had taken it away.

Dádá Akśayánanda concludes here and excuses himself to go about his work in the garden. Áshrava and I thank him and leave for the markets to do a little shopping.

In the evening upon returning from field walk, Bábá asks, “What did I say last night?” He looks at everyone expectantly. When there is no answer, He asks again. How much does Bábá say that just disappears into thin air because no one remembers it or takes note? I struggle to bring to mind the details of exactly what He said, even though I did write it down last night, but it eludes me in any meaningful way to present. Finally a Dádá answers, “Everything is moving. We are also to move and do our duty.”

Bábá continues what the Dádá has began, “The entire life is a mission. Do not separate the individual life from the mission. The flow is towards the Supreme Entity. What is the mainstream of life?”

Áshrava replies, “Sádhaná.”

“Yes, ideology. Sádhaná is like the trunk of a tree and all other works and service are the branches and offshoots. If you only water the branches and offshoots it would be futile, isn’t it?”

Bábá refers this last question to me indicating a reply. I comply with a, “Yes, Bábá.”

“Sádhaná is the perennial source of inspiration. Of What?”

Again I reply, “Inspiration.”

“Of vitality. And, you should water the trunk to keep it healthy and vital. Do you follow? Sádhaná provides you with the inspiration to do the mundane activities. You must not miss sádhaná because it is the mainstream of life. The vitality from sádhaná will make the workers, the social workers. The sádhaka, the spiritual aspirant, must remember that spirituality is the mainstream of life and everything else is peripheral to it.” Bábá then walks to the doorway of the stairs, but continues, “What did I say of the trunk?”

“To keep it healthy, Bábá,” we chime.

“And strong. Water the trunk of sádhaná to make it strong.” He circles His arms in front of Him as if embracing a huge tree trunk to emphasise ‘strong’. “With the inspiration from sádhaná you can go on working in the mundane, supramundane and psychic spheres. Do you follow?”^R



Prout – A Completely New Social Theory

Friday 11/4

When Bábá sets off for evening field walk, He takes Dádá Nirainjana with Him. While they are walking, Dádá attempts to ask Bábá a question but is interrupted by the VSS guard saying no questions while Bábá is walking. Later, returning in the car, Bábá turned to Dádá and asks, “Nirainjana what was the question you wanted to ask?”

Dádá replies, “Bábá, I was hoping you would give some guidance for P.U. [PROUT Universal] in Suva Sector [Australasian region].”

“You are posted in P.U.?”

“Yes, Bábá.”

“Then you should get guidance from Jagadiishvaránanda. For all of your questions speak to Jagadiishvaránanda.”

After a short pause, Bábá continues:

In Suva Sector there are so many islands. So many islands, each with their own peculiar problems. They have been the victims of colonisation and their rich cultural expressions have been severely subjugated. The whole Sector that is with the exception of Australia and New Zealand suffers from surplus labour. Top priority has to be given to solving unemployment and guaranteeing sufficient purchasing capacity, and then efforts should be made to increase this purchasing capacity.

There are two approaches, short term and long term. The short term is to solve unemployment and increase purchasing capacity. The long term is to solve the total economic problem.

In Malaysia and Indonesia, the problem is acute. In the Islamic countries, there is much increase of population. The Aborigines in Australia, the Maoris, also have severe problems and need much support.

There are two kinds of labour – intellectual and physical, and either can be in surplus or deficit. In Bengal, there is a deficit of physical labour and surplus in intellectual. Because of this intellectual surplus, the problems of Bengal cannot be solved by labourers coming in from other states. There needs to be industrialisation. For the Bengalese, they like the intellectual work – doctor, engineer, professor, and the physical labour comes from Bihar, Tripura. So, we will have to chalk out short-term and long-term programmes. There are certain places where there is surplus manpower. In some places, intellectual power is at a surplus. That is why in Bengal, where there is surplus of intellectual power, they go out to other countries to find work, but you will not find any Bengali going out for physical labour. You will not find any porter in America that comes from Bengal.⁵

When the car arrives at His house, Bábá steps out and calls Dádá Nirainjana to come and explain to everyone present what has been discussed on field walk. Dádá bemusedly gets out and Bábá cajoles him, “Nirainjana stand here and explain deficit labour.” Dádá begins a stumbling speech, but Bábá rescues him with an explanation:

If there are very few people and much work, then there are two alternatives. If you have very few people, then you can rationalise, can industrialise, or you can bring in labour from a labour surplus area. For example, in Bengal, manual labour is deficit and intellectual labour is surplus. Where intellectual labour is surplus then some more mechanised programmes should be implemented. Because of the intellectual surplus, you find Bengalis in many other countries as professor, doctor and engineer. In other States such as Maharashtra, specifically Bombay, there is surplus labour and their people migrate to other

countries and perform manual work. In Assam, there is deficit in both intellectual and manual labour and so you do not find Assamese migrating to other areas.

In Europe, there is mostly intellectual surplus with the exceptions of Italy, Portugal and Spain. In Britain there is intellectual surplus and deficit labour and that is why so many people go there, seeking employment. They go there from Africa, Pakistan and India. But, Britain is a small island. It can grow food for only four months of the year and hence there needs to be some control. If there is no immigration control, it will have many problems and so it is only right that there should be restrictions imposed on immigration.

So, in all the world such survey programmes are to be started. The world has been divided into many social/economic parts. According to local needs, you have to start programmes for manual labour, somewhere for intellectual labour – for intellectuals increased mechanisation. To solve the problems of the world we should know everything about every country. All the socio-economic conditions. Do you have some fascination with Prout? It is a completely new social theory.⁷

Saturday 12/4

After returning from field walk this evening, Bábá continues His discourse of the previous evening:

Last night I spoke about surplus labour and deficit labour and tonight I will talk about sentimental legacy. Sentimental legacy is fundamental to life. There are so many sentiments, but if the sentiment does not have a basis in logic and science, then there is every possibility of fissiparous tendencies cropping up.

Hence, we must adopt the sentiment of Universalism. This whole universe is the creation of Parama Puruṣa. We must think that He is our Father and the whole universe is our common

patrimony. All the children of the world are co-travellers, co-pedestrians. This sentiment must not be for the few, but for the whole universe. We must move along His path, but do not forget anyone. You should take them all along with you.

If there is no logic and science as a base for the sentiment, then there will be a fault. This sentiment of Universalism has a scientific and logical basis. Hence, all of you should work and serve society by doing your duty well with this sentiment. Do you follow? You can remember?^U

Initially speaking to everyone generally, Bábá now turns to me and specifies, “Do you understand? And you have some system for noting it down?”

“Yes Bábá. I am noting it down.” Bábá is being insistent with me now so that I keep an accurate written record. I can see that what started as a personal account could now have a greater possibility.



A Málá for Bábá

Sunday 13/4

Today Bábá holds a Darshan at Central Office, again in Bengali.

Yajiṇa – Changing Cultures

In this final Darshan on Yajiṇa, Bábá explains how civilisation developed along different river valleys and how manners, customs and cultures varied from one to another. He also explains how rituals and different ritualistic articles of Aryan Yajiṇa would vary from place to place.

Firstly He defines culture as the name of the collective human expressions and civilisation means the refined portion of those expressions. He states that civilisation proceeds along the rivers not along any road or mountain. These rivers provide human beings with the basic ingredients for survival through water.

The river Ganga comes down from Gangottarii in the Himálaya till it finally it arrives in Bengal. This is the Ganges civilisation. If one goes much north or south away from the shoreline of the river, one will find a different civilisation, but along the course of the river even to one thousand miles, one will find the same civilisation.

Bábá specifies that in North India, the Ganges civilisation is not similar to the Ganges civilisation in Bengal because the Brahmaputra River and the Ganga River have mingled with each other at Bengal. In the first instance Bengali civilisation is a mixture of Indo-Aryan civilisation along the Ganges and Tibeto-Indian or Tibeto-Chinese-Indian civilisation along the

Brahmaputra River coming from the different direction of Tibet.

From the old Gondwanaland, many rivers carried different Austrico-Negroid civilisations, which finally mixed up at different places in Bengal. Ultimately it can be said that Bengali civilisation is therefore an admixture of Ganga, Tibeto-Chinese and the Rarh civilisations of Gondwanaland.

Bábá says that the Aryan civilisation followed the rivers and valleys till they reached India coming from the north through the Khyber Pass. With the Yajña rituals there were changes in customs, manners and ingredients used according to the valleys and environment the Aryans encountered as they travelled, such as when they came across wheat in Iran and then rice in India. Bábá elaborates here saying that the Aryans called rice *brhii*, which became *rihii* in Old Persian, then old Latin converted it to *rici* and from that to present day English it became rice.

He states that the system of Yajña also changed according to the changes in civilisation. While Aryans were in the Volga civilisation, they would keep barley, some wool, and wine with the corpse in burial, presuming that the dead person would use those things. This has carried down through the ages until, even today in India, at the time of the last rites, some amount of wool is given as offering to the dead person.

Bábá then addresses the audience directly, saying you are all intelligent people; you have the capacity to understand everything. Do you allow this kind of superstitious belief to continue, even in this age?²³

Bábá challenges dogmatic and superstitious social traditions by pointing out their origins and development. One analogy I have always liked is: Religion is ninety per cent belief and ten per cent practice and spirituality is ten per cent belief and ninety per cent practice. The mystical tradition of Tantra falls into the latter.

Early evening, Áshrava and I make our way to the local markets. On the outside edge of the market, bordering a small road, are the stalls selling flowers. Bare, low-watt bulbs or bright flamed oil lamps light each stall. On every stall, a range of flowers are decked out to show the wares to the passing customers – tuberose with their long light green stalks standing in buckets along the front; orange or yellow marigolds strung in garlands and hanging around the top of the stall roof; gladioli with trumpet flowers in red, yellow or white stacked in ceramic pots; strings of little white bud flowers, called ‘*mathay fuler málá*’, used by Bengali women to adorn their hair are hung in bunches along the front. All this produces such a bright cheerful display, that it is a pleasure just to stand there and look, but this is not to be when commerce is to be conducted. “What do you want? Come and just look. Come over to my stall, just look.” Several of the flower vendors entreat us to enter the magic buying circle of their particular stall and once in, you are committed. With pleasure we take the plunge and step towards the nearest stall.

“We want a couple of garlands”, asks Áshrava.

“Marigolds are very nice, not too expensive.”

“No, no. Something more special,” I state. “Can you make a garland out of tuberoses?”

“Yes sir, certainly, this is possible.”

“And can you put one of those lotus flowers hanging from the centre?”

“Yes sir, a special garland.” Deftly she threads the tuberose flowers onto a cotton string. A lovely white lotus tinged with pink on the edges of the petals is hung in its centre. One garland for Áshrava and one for me. They are heavy garlands, look beautiful and are pungent with the heady, sweet floral scent of the tuberose. This is what I want to give Bábá on our last night. Cradling them carefully we clamber aboard the nearest rickshaw and set off to Bábá’s residence.

Once there, we again, for the last time, line up in the driveway with Shivaprabhá and Púrña Premá to do kiirtana for Bábá. Áshrava has

the guitar, Madhu and with it we sing out a beautiful melody of the Spanish kiirtana.

When Bábá comes down for evening field walk, Áshrava and I are waiting for Him with our garland each. He approaches, resplendent in His simple white kurta shirt and dhoti. There is a shine about Him. Áshrava hands her garland to Bábá saying, “A *málá* for You Bábá.”

He takes it and while admiring the garland replies, “Oh, *málá*. In Bengali, it is called ‘*málá*’. In Sanskrit, it is called ‘*Malyam*’ and in English, it is called ‘garland’. When it is used for *Japa* [repetition of mantra by counting] it is called ‘*Japamálá*’ in Bengali, and in English, ‘rosary’, and in Arabic, ‘*Tasvih*’.”

When Bábá finishes, I approach Him and offer my garland, holding it out draped across my cupped joined hands towards Him. Bábá stands looking at me, hands by His side and surprisingly questions, “Is this for me?”

I respond without thinking, “Yes, Bábá.”

He still does not take my offering, but again questions me, “Are you sure it is for me?”

Puzzled, taken aback, I inanely respond, “Yes, Bábá. We are leaving tomorrow to go back to Australia.” He takes the *málá*, but what point He may have been making is lost on my naivety. Somewhat unsettled, I sense that a seed has been sown in my subconscious or maybe stirred up from its depths. Bábá places my garland over His head, and gives me a namaskár, but His hesitancy in taking the garland is unnerving. What does He mean, ‘Are you sure it is for me?’ My mind is whirling. Who else is there? Is my intention not correct while presenting it to Him? Was I being too ostentatious in this grand style of garland, rather than in the meaning of the gesture? He is my Guru, isn’t He? My mind swirls with the inconsistencies. I don’t know what to make of it. This final act of offering to Him before I leave is thrown up in the air to fall where it will and I am whirling with it. Where I’ll land, I don’t know. It was like Bábá had put something, a kernel, into me, or brought it up from such depths

that I was completely unaware it existed, and this unsettling feeling grows.

Before Bábá gets into the car to go on field walk He addresses everyone:

Today is the last day of the Bengali year and tomorrow at sunrise, the New Year will start. This is the Oriental system of astronomical calculation. In the Bengali system, the day is counted from sunrise to sunrise. In the Occidental system, the day starts at zero hour to the next zero hour. Elsewhere we must observe the international system, the Occidental time. At the twelfth hour, we change the date. Today is the last day of the Bengali year and tomorrow morning at sunrise will be the start of the New Year. This will be the month of *Vaeshákha*, named after the star *Vishákhá* and after fifteen days *Vaeshákhii Púrnima* will come.^v

On His return from field walk, Bábá continues:

What is time? Say 16, 17, 18 days, months, years? Time is the psychic measurement of the mobility of action. Where there is some movement – the earth moves around the sun – you can measure it. Human mind can measure. Where there was nobody to measure it, there was no time. Man made time respectable. If there were no man, there would have been no time. The Eternal Tempus is something completely theoretical. It is neither existent nor nonexistent.

One day there will be no one on this little planet to measure time, but humanity is indestructible. In so many solar systems, many stars, there are planets where humanity still will exist. There they will measure time. There, there will be research, and they will watch the death of this planet.^w

On such prophetic words, Bábá ends His mini Darshan, the last I will hear Him speak in person. Everyone is silent, eyes turned on Bábá. He draws His hands up slowly, elbows raised high and proceeds to give one last intense namaskár before He retires for the night. The

solemnity of the evening is strong. I have mixed feelings of leaving Calcutta, of leaving Bábá and of the precious time I have experienced. Áshrava and I take leave of our friends, Púrña Premá and Shivaprabhá. We give our namaskárs to the VSS guards, Parimal and Suviira and to Dádá Akśayánanda, who I promise to send a subscription to an Australian orchid magazine. Áshrava and I catch a rickshaw back to the Asia Hotel, quiet in each other's company and sad at having to leave. We both like being in India and of course being around Bábá.

As I lay in bed this last night, many of Bábá's words spoken to me ring in my head:

"...the time is so short. Do not waste a moment. All your past mistakes, whether conscious or unconscious, forget them and as of this moment start anew."

"Become an asset to the Humanity."

"Have you recorded what I said last night?...I have not said this previously...It should be recorded, not for you, but for others."

"This tune is so charming, so attracting, extremely fascinating, marvellous. I am extremely pleased."

[Jiñáneshvar]... "A very good name. A very good name."

"May you be successful in all the stratum of life – physical, mental and spiritual. Be great by your sádhaná, your service, and your sacrifice."

What had I come to India for? What was I expecting? I had no conscious reason other than to meet Bábá, to see this person I called my Guru in the flesh. I have fulfilled this and much more. Many unconscious reasons have also been satisfied and others were stirred from their deep nest in my subconscious to emerge over time.



Going Home

Monday 14/4

Next morning, bright and early, Áshrava and I have no time to do anything except catch a taxi to the airport. This time the journey doesn't seem to take nearly as long as arriving and certainly we are more used to the scenes passing before us.

While sitting on the plane, flying across the vast reaches of lands that once made up the ancient continent of Gondwanaland, I remember what Bábá had said last night. "Today is the last day of the Bengali year and tomorrow morning at sunrise will be the start of the New Year." What would this New Year hold for us? Where would we go after this milestone in our lives? I had much to think about and a twelve-hour plane ride to contemplate, from Bábá's inspiration, some New Year resolutions. At about this time, I realise, Bábá would probably be giving His New Year Darshan to all the márgiis gathered in the meditation hall. While we fly high in the sky, above this little planet, in a solar system whizzing on the outer spiral arm of a great galaxy, Bábá's Darshan echoes across to me.

Bengali New Year

Although talking about the Bengali New Year and addressing a mostly Bengali audience, the sentiment of Bábá Darshan is applicable to everyone. He begins by defining history as the depiction of the laughter and misery of the common people, not simply the history of kings and emperors. Bábá describes the Bengali community as being very ancient, over 3000 years old. Bábá says, "While advancing from the distant past, this community has reached the end of a dark period; a new year's

dawn is about to break in its history. ...[Bengalis] are moving and they will continue to move. For movement is the very essence of life, the living proof of its vital existence.” Bábá discusses how the name of Bengal in Chinese is Banjal and can be found in 5000 year old Chinese literature indicating its ancient heritage. Bengal is not this current population who suddenly has a boundary or nationhood, though its political structure has faced various destruction and reconstruction. It is very old. Bengal also has very special customs, manners, social systems, its own calendar, language, script, system of pronunciation and system of inheritance. These are different from other parts of India. These unique factors represent Bengal as a constantly progressing community in the past. Life is systaltic, pulsative and now after a lull, Bengali must again move forward. Bábá outlines the approach, “This New Year’s Day is the day of recollection of our past resolutions, when we remember our past plans and goals. By reviewing our past mistakes, we find the rectifying measures which will help us gain enough strength to move ahead with new zeal.” Bábá stirs inspiration with this expectation, “Again the Bengali New Year has come. So the Bengali community, who were very vibrant in the past, are still alive today; and I hope they will live dynamically in the future also. ...This is a day of rejoicing, and amidst this rejoicing, the Bengalis will have to determine ways of improving their individual and collective life, and developing their resources for their future Progress.” And finally at this, Bábá draws His Darshan to a close, “This is not the time for laziness; rather it is the time for intense activity. Let every moment of your valuable time be used properly. With these words, I conclude my discourse.”²⁴



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When writing my diary entries, I attempted to confirm exactly what Báábá said by conferring with those present immediately after His Darshan or conversation. Other particulars of dates or names mentioned, have also been verified where possible with relevant Ácáryas, the Publications Department or the Archives of Ananda Marga Global Camp Headquarters, Kolkata.

To establish the accuracy of my records of Báábá's statements I have cross-referenced them below with what He has said in His own books published in English and on the Electronic Edition v6.0.

If anyone has any corrections or queries about the accuracy of any details, I would be grateful for their correspondence to improve any future edition.

A The History of Bengal -1

Sarkar, P.R., A Few Problems Solved, Part 3 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 21

“Take the case of Old Gondwanaland. In the distant past, some areas of India did not exist: There was neither northern India, nor Dabák nor Samataí areas of Bengal, but there was Old Gondwana. That was about 300 million years ago. At that time, the major parts of Sind, the Punjab, U.P., Bihar and Bengal did not exist. They were all submerged under the vast oceans. The Himalayas also did not exist.”

Recording of Báábá's Darshan, Part 1

Unpublished audio cassette, recorded 17.1.80 (in the author's possession)

“There was that continent of Atlanta. That area of Atlanta is now known as Atlantic Ocean ... , but long before that continent, there was a big continent to the south of ... which was known as Gondwanaland, to the south of Africa, to the south of Sahara, Arabian Sea, south ... excepting the northern land in ... , India also, Malaysia, Indonesia, up to Australia, to Tasmania, there was a big continent. And there, was the continent of Gondwanaland.”

B Táńdava, Kaośíkii And Kiirtana

Sarkar, P.R., Light Comes (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 941

“When a large number of people do Kiirtana, then not only their physical force is concentrated, but also their collective psychic power, getting inspiration from Parama Puruṣa, starts to flow in a single channel. Thus there is not only a concentration of physical force, but of psychic force as well; and this concentrated physical and psychic force removes the accumulated sorrows and miseries of the material world.”

Táńdava, Kaoṣikii And Kiirtana

Sarkar, P.R., *Light Comes* (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 959

Where Kiirtana is done, not only those who actually do the Kiirtana will be benefited, but even those who do not take part in it. Even those who do not even like it, and listen to it disrespectfully, will also be benefited. If you listen to it with reverence, it will uplift you; and even if you listen to it with disregard, even then it will benefit you.

C The Three Prerequisites For Spiritual Knowledge

Sarkar, P.R., *Ánanda Vacanámrtam*, Part 4 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 72

“Pariprashnena means ‘question’. The root verb ‘quest’ means ‘to look for’. The noun from quest is question.”

D Brahma Krpáhi Kevalam

Sarkar, P.R., *Subhásita Sańgraha*, Part 1 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 28

“Regardless of how vast it is, the visible universe is finite. But is the potentiality of the Cosmic mind also limited? When the Cosmic mindstuff merges into the state of Nirguńa Brahma, will the Saguńa Brahma also attain Mokṣa? No, it will not. Even though all the manifestations of the Cosmic mind-stuff are limited, the mind-stuff is not finite. The origin of Saguńa Brahma is beyond the limits of time.”

E Sádhaná, Abhidhyána and Kiirtana

Sarkar, P.R., *Ánanda Vacanámrtam*, part 8 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 39

“Similarly, if the sensory and motor organs are not kept engaged in the attainment of the divine, they may lead one astray. Kiirtana is therefore most beneficial as it keeps all the organs fully engaged in a spiritual pursuit. However, while doing kiirtana, if one listens to anything else, the mind will be diverted. Suppose, while doing kiirtana, one lady asks another, ‘Well sister, what did you cook today?’ This will also be heard by the practitioners of kiirtana. To prevent these undesirable sounds from being heard, it is advisable to play some instrument during kiirtana.”

- F** From The Physical Stratum To The Apex
Sarkar, P.R., *Ānanda Vacanāmrtam*, part 12 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 33
“Because the Supreme Creator knows everything. And why does the Supreme Creator know everything? Because everything is His internal psychic projection, and nothing is external, nothing is without, everything is within. So when, by dint of one’s practice of cult, one ensconces himself in the Supreme Existence, one becomes one with the Supreme, and that is why everything comes within the periphery of his mind - he also becomes omniscient.”
- G** The Evolution Of Indian Languages
Sarkar, P.R., *Prout in a Nutshell*, Part 17 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 23
“Bengali people as a race are Austrico-Mongolo-Negroid, not Aryan, but Bengali language is of Aryan origin, having 92% Saṁskṛta vocabulary. Similar is the case of Oriya. Racially Bengali, Oriya and Angika people are the same, all having Dravidoid blood, but their languages originated from Oriental Demi-Māgadhii with Saṁskṛtic vocabulary.”
- H** Social Values And Human Cardinal Principles
Sarkar, P.R., *A Few Problems Solved*, Part 2 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 15
“During the Vipra era the Kṣātriyas and other social classes were so overwhelmed by the Vipra’s intellectual might - which they had used to invent various things to further human welfare - that they surrendered before them. The Vipras were regarded as wise because their intellectual research benefitted the common people. Out of awe and respect everyone prostrated at the lotus feet of these great people.”
- I** Ideology, Goal And Devotion
Sarkar, P.R., *Subhāṣita Saṁgraha*, Part 20 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 52
“The Lord’s grace is on every human being. Some, however, are not drenched with His grace because they have the umbrella of ego around their heads. They will not be drenched with this grace unless they remove this shield of ego. Only after they have removed this ego will they be blessed by the Lord.
What must be done by the spiritual aspirant? The aspirant has to remove this umbrella of ego. If you remove the ego, you will become a devotee and surely you will reach the Lord. There is nothing more to be done. We have to do mental worship and not extroversial worship. You surrender your mind to the Lord and the Lord will be satisfied. Those who are ready to center their minds on Him will be established in their ‘Íśā’; they will be victorious. No power can stop them from this.”

- J** **What Is The Way**
 Sarkar, P.R., *Subhásita Saṁgraha*, Part 11 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 24
 “Varying social codes are prevalent in different parts of India. In most of India the Mitakṣará system of social inheritance as enunciated by Manu is prevalent; whereas in Meghalaya the popular system is the matrilineal order; in West Bengal the Dáyabhága system; in Kerala the Nayar system. People are confronted with a baffling choice.”
- K** **The Intuitional Science Of The Vedas - 4**
 Sarkar, P.R., *Subhásita Saṁgraha*, Part 2 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 99
 “Without going in for the external paraphernalia and formalities one has to prepare oneself internally, maintaining the balance between the internal and the external? One has to remain alert so that the external environment will not be detrimental to one’s purity of mind. A high-thinking man may meet his downfall within a short time, if he continually associates himself with bad company. Hence it is necessary to maintain a balance between internal and external expressions.”
- L** **Spiritual Cult: Progress From Crudest Matter To Subtlest Entity**
 Sarkar, P.R., *Subhásita Saṁgraha*, Part 19 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 90
 “Your longing for Him, however, should not be attributional. It should, on the contrary, be non-attributional. Your attraction for the Supreme is called devotion whereas attraction for any finite objectivity is called Ásakti. Attraction for a friend is Ásakti, attraction for God is Bhakti (Devotion). In case Ásakti the object is limited, in case of Bhakti it is unlimited. Mysticism is a never-ending endeavour to find out a link between finite and infinite. It is the first phase of non-attributional devotion. Attributional devotion is no devotion.”
- Spirituality And This Panoramic Universe**
 Sarkar, P.R., *Subhásita Saṁgraha*, Part 16 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 31
 “If we cannot cure the defects of the individual or collective psychology which is the source of all troubles, then we will simply be making arrangements for the temporary relief of human society while at the same time the defective individual and collective psychologies will be creating newer and newer problems, newer and newer miseries. That is, on the one hand, we will be removing the miseries, and on the other hand, newer sufferings will take their place. This will not do. We must make efforts - and only those efforts will be considered successful which will permanently remove those afflictions, which will rectify the sources of troubles in the proper way.”

M The Expansion Of The Microcosm

Sarkar, P.R., *Subhāsita Saṁgraha*, Part 5 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 168

“This creation which seems to be real to the microcosm is actually the psychic conation of the Macrocosm. Only He knows the secret of this phenomenon. Suppose you are thinking of Laheriasaral (in Bihar, India). Are you not inseparably associated with the Laheriasarai of your mind? Does not your individual identity lie in the atoms and molecules of that Laheriasarai? Is not the subject closely associated with the object? Certainly. Likewise His divine glory is inseparably associated with every molecule of this world of imagination.”

N Necessity Of Sādhana

Sarkar, P.R., *Light Comes* (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 331

“And how is one to expand the periphery of one’s mind? By a constant fight against all limitedness, against all physical limitedness and against all psychic dogmas. Any idea that is surrounded by boundary lines, is called dogma. Dogma seals the future of the human intellect. So, the spiritual aspirants who want to establish them selves in the Supreme Stance must fight against dogmas. In the realm of philosophy, economics, history, archaeology, sociology and all sciences and humanities, dogma is dangerous. You boys and girls, you spiritual aspirants must always remember that you must never surrender at the altar of dogma. In the past dogma created so many divisive tendencies in the human society. Your slogan should be ‘Dogma - no more, dogma - no more!’ Establish your selves above the boundaries of dogma, and be established in the excellence of human glory.”

O Towards The Noumenal Entity

Sarkar, P.R., *Ānanda Vacanāmṛtam*, Part 12 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 337

“In this circumrotatory universe, the controlling nuclei of all created entities are themselves moving, and their existence remains within the scope of the three fundamental relative factors - time, space and person. But in the case of the Supreme Entity, Its Nucleus is beyond the scope of the three fundamental relative factors, so it does not move. Whether an entity is mobile or immobile is dependent on whether it comes within the scope of time, place and person. In this universe, nothing in motion can be considered as absolute. Such things are always relative. Their movement is relative. Regarding Parama Puruṣa, it has been said that It is non-moving. The fact is that the Entity which is not relative is beyond the arena of mobility or immobility because It is beyond the periphery of time, place and person. We can neither say that It is moving nor say that It is non-moving.”

Who Is The Liberating Entity Of Human Society

Sarkar, P.R., Subhásita Sañgraha, Part 11 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 15

“Now what is time? Time is the mental measurement of the mobility of action. If there is mental measurement, there must be many unit minds to measure it, and there must also be movement - there must be at least three entities. So kála or kála shakti or Time cannot be the liberator. Even Mahákála will play with you but it cannot grant you liberation - it is not within its scope.”

P Bhakti-Rúpa Setu (Devotion Acts Like a Bridge)

Sarkar, P.R., Subhásita Sañgraha, Part 18 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 27

“What is this universe? Where there is predominance of Bhaeravii shakti the universe is unmanifested. The domination of Bhavánii shakti means the manifestation of the universe. The term vishva connotes expressed universe. He is in every particle of the universe. He is also well-acquainted with the feelings in your mind. He is Mahat i.e., great. The term Mahat means matchless and also bereft of narrowness. Brahma is one and the same for all persons.”

Parama Puruṣa - The Only Bandhu

Sarkar, P.R., Ānanda Vacanámrtam, Part 6 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 52

“What is the meaning of ‘bandhu’? In Sañskṛta, the meaning of the word ‘bandhu’ is ‘to bind’. Bandhu indicates that person or entity who cannot stand separation. Parama Puruṣa or Saguna Brahma is closely and intimately connected with this expressed world or jagata. He is pervasively connected with every individual entity, be it a living being or a crude object. He is also linked through and through with the universe as a whole. In other words, He is indissolubly and inextricably involved (ota prota) with everything. Therefore, He is the only bandhu of this universe.”

Q Do Not Delay

Sarkar, P.R., The Great Universe: Discourses on Society (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), line 43

“What should a person do? His life is a mission. I have said that human life is an ideological flow. Whatever one does must be done for one’s own liberation and for the elevation of the entire world. If someone works only for his own spiritual elevation, for his own liberation, is he not a selfish fellow? So while working for his own liberation, he must also serve others.”

R In Adoration Of The Supreme

Sarkar, P.R., *Subhāsita Saṁgraha*, Part 6 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 58

“When a microcosm develops as a result of the combination of the fundamental factors, it gains an awareness of the time factor. Time, as the motivity of action, comes within its micropsychic capacity of measurement. Where the time factor has become linked with the fundamental factors, the developed mind is said to be functioning. In the flow of *Pratisaincara*, the microcosm then rushes towards the Witnessing Force (Macrocosmic Consciousness). There is also a qualitative change in the nature of bondage. In Macropsychic conation, that complex structure, with the help of the subtler binding faculties, takes the form of developed beings or human beings, who move gradually along the path of progress with the indomitable vitality of spiritual inspiration.”

S Socio-Economic Movements

Sarkar, P.R., *A Few Problems Solved*, Part 9 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 40

“To solve the unemployment problem in both the short and long term there must be an accurate understanding of the surplus and deficit manual and intellectual labour trends. In India, for example, there is surplus manual labour in North Bihar, which is based upon an agricultural economy, and surplus intellectual labour in Calcutta. In both places there is high unemployment. In most of the countries of the world where there is high unemployment, there is surplus manual labour.”

T Some Aspects Of Socio-Economic Planning

Sarkar, P.R., *Prout in a Nutshell*, Part 15 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 89

“Exploitation exists in each and every sphere of life - social, economic, cultural, psychic, etc. Exploiters do not care whether an area is a surplus or deficit labour area. Bhojpuri is a surplus labour area while parts of Bengal and Assam are deficit labour areas. All of these areas are exploited by exploiters. Andhesha and Assam are the worst affected areas.”

Socio-Economic Movements

Sarkar, P.R., *A Few Problems Solved*, Part 9 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 31

“To create 100% employment among local people, PROUT supports both a short term and a long term economic plan. In the short term plan, labour intensive industries based on the collective minimum requirements of life should be started immediately or made more productive where they already exist. These industries should be based on the consumption motive. They should also provide a rational profit in order to guarantee adequate purchasing capacity to those employed in them and to ensure their continued existence and growth.”

- U Some Aspects Of Socio-Economic Planning
 Sarkar, P.R., *Prout in a Nutshell*, Part 15 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 33
 “PROUT is based on a universal sentiment which is applicable for the whole cosmological order, and it is systematically moving towards the implementation of this sentiment. Who will make the local people conscious of their local sentiments keeping universalism in mind? Only PROUT can do this. Communists have no such idea. Only PROUT can tackle all local sentiments and lead everyone in the world to universalism by gradual stages. Revolutionaries must be well-versed in arousing the sentiments of the people and channelizing the sentimental legacy of the society towards universalism. During the preparation for revolution, unstinting effort must go into arousing the sentimental legacy of the people, because sentiments inspire popular support for the cause of revolution, and infuse the revolutionary workers with tremendous power and conviction.”
- V Bengali New Year
 Sarkar, P.R., *A Few Problems Solved*, Part 5 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 85
 “This shows that the Kárttika was the last month and Agrahána was the first month of the year. But according to the Indian system of reckoning and the newly introduced system of Sarāvat, when the full moon takes place with the appearance of the Vishákhá star, the month is called lunar Vaesháka. In lunar Vaesháka as long as the sun remains within the scope of the zodiac sign (Aries), the period is known as solar Vaesháka. The Bengali month of Vaesháka is the solar Vaesháka. Yesterday the sun was in Pisces zodiac sign, but today it is in Aries. That is why today is the first day of the Bengali New Year. This was first introduced by King Shálibáhana.”
- W The Primordial Cause Of Creation
 Sarkar, P.R., *Subhásita Sarāgraha*, Part 4 (Kolkata, Ananda Marga Publications), Line 36
 “Time is only a relative factor, which is entirely dependent on the mutual relationship of place and person. Time is but the mind’s measurement of the motivity of action. When there is no motivity of action, or when there is motivity of action but no mind to measure it, there is no time.”

GLOSSARY AND ACRONYMS

ácárya *m.* or **ácáryá** *f.* one who teaches others by his or her exemplary conduct and character. • spiritual teachers of Ananda Marga qualified to give initiation and teach all lessons of meditation. • *abb.* Ác.

ácchá [Bengali] good, well. • *excl.* Oh, yes! I see! used mostly in colloquial Bengali.

aham the part of the mind which performs actions, the doer “I” or ego. • the second mental subjectivity.

ájñá cakra the sixth psycho-spiritual nerve plexus located between the eyebrows, see also cakra.

anáhata cakra fourth psychic-nerve plexus, located at the mid-point of the chest; the ‘yogic heart’, see also cakra.

ánanda divine bliss.

Ananda Marga path of divine bliss. • The system of spiritual practices as taught by Shrii Shrii Ánandamúrti. • *abb.* AM.

Ananda Marga Pracáraka Samgha *n.* the socio-spiritual organisation founded in 1955 by Shrii Prabhat Ranjan Sarkar (Bábá) for the propagation of the Ananda Marga ideology. • *abb.* AMPS.

Ánanda Sútram the book by Bábá covering the entire Ananda Marga ideology.

Ársá Dharma the religion of the Vedic Aryans. • the assembled teachings of the rśis (‘ársá’ is derived from ‘rśi’).

Aryan one of the four main races in the world.

ásana the third limb of aśtānga (eight-limbed) yoga. • physical exercises which harmonise the glandular system, curing physical and psychic problems, especially those that interfere with sáadhaná (spiritual endeavor).

áshram yoga or spiritual centre. • hermitage, monastery. • see also jágrti.

aum the Cosmic Sound of creation, see also oṃ (om).

aum mani padma hum a mantra of Maháyána Buddhism, a popular translation is ‘Hail the jewel in the lotus’, but its meaning is more complex.

avadhúta *m.* or **avadhútiká** *f. lit.* one who is thoroughly cleansed mentally and spiritually; a monk or nun of an order close to the tradition of Shaeva Tantra. • *abb. m.* Avt. - *f.* Avtká.

avidyá the force leading towards crudeness. • degeneration. • ignorance

avidyámáyá centrifugal, or extroversal force. • aspect of the Cosmic Operative Principle which guides movements from the subtle to the crude.

avidyámáyá tántrika practitioner of the black arts, preoccupied with occult powers.

áyurveda the Vedic system of herbal and natural medicine.

Bábá father, beloved, Supreme Father. • the affectionate name given to Shrii Shrii Ánandamúrti by his disciples.

Bábá náma kevalam universal mantra given by Shrii Shrii Ánandamúrti. • *lit.* only the name of Bábá. • everything is the expression of love. • love is all there is. • *abb.* BNK.

bhágavata dharma the dharma to attain the Supreme. • divine dharma. • the spiritual code of human beings.

bhajana devotional song.

bhakti devotion. • intense attraction for the Supreme.

bhakti yoga devotional form of spiritual practice.

bhálo [Bengali] good, well.

Brahma Supreme Entity. • Cosmic Consciousness. • comprising both Puruśa (Shiva), and Prakṛti (Shakti).

brāhmaṇa (brahman) the uppermost social group in India, who traditionally perform priestly functions or live by intellectual labour.

Caetanya Mahāprabhu Bengali bhakti yogi of the 16th century who developed the Hare Kṛṣṇa mahāmantra.

cakra cycle or circle. • psycho-spiritual centre, or plexus. • there are seven main cakras in the human body located along the suṣumnā canal (psycho-spiritual passage) which passes through the length of the spinal column and extends up to the crown of the head.

citta done “I”, objective “I”, objective mind, mind-stuff. • the part of the mind which expresses the result of an action.

dádá *m. lit.* elder brother. • may respectfully refer to a male ācārya of Ananda Marga.

dal [Bengali] cooked lentils.

Darshan seeing. • audience of the Guru. • guiding philosophy.

Dáyabhāga a system of inheritance in which the heirs right is subject to the discretion of the father, who has the right to disinherit any of the • another feature of this system is the women’s rights of inheritance.

DC see dharmacakra

dharma innate nature of an entity. • prominent characteristic. • the spiritual dharma of human beings is to realize the Supreme Consciousness.

dharmacakra collective group meditation. • *abb.* DC.

dharma mahācakra gathering of spiritual aspirants for collective meditation and spiritual programmes with special discourse and blessing of Bábá. • *abb.* DMC.

dhyāna contemplation. • advanced practice of meditation where the mind is directed in an unbroken flow towards the Supreme. • the seventh limb of aśtāṅga yoga, taught as the 6th lesson of Ananda Marga sādhanā.

didi *f. lit.* elder sister. • may respectfully refer to a female ācāryā of Ánanda Marga.

diikśá initiation into spiritual practices. • the process which leads to the attainment of the light of knowledge and the exhaustion of accumulated saṁskaras.

DMC see dharma mahácakra

ERAWS Education Relief and Welfare Section of Ananda Marga.

giita song. • singing.

Gondwanaland an ancient continental landmass some 500 million years ago. It comprised the present day Australia, peninsula India, Antarctica, Arabia, Africa and South America. It was named after the Gondwana region of central northern India (from Sanskrit gondavana ‘forest of the Gonds’).

gopa *m.* or **gopii** *f.* village cowherd boy or girl; related to devotees of Kṛṣṇa.

gotra *lit.* hill. • clan.

GS General Secretary. • the highest executive and administrative posting in Ananda Marga.

guña binding factor or principle. • attribute, quality. • Prakṛti, the cosmic operative principle, is composed of: sātvaguña, the sentient principle; rājoguña, the mutative principle; and tāmoguña, the static principle.

guru gu means darkness, ru means dispeller. • the entity that dispells all spiritual darkness is the Guru. • spiritual master.

guru mantra a mantra learned as the 2nd lesson of Ananda Marga sādhaná.

gurupújá spiritual practice of offering mental colours to the Guru. • see varnārghyadána.

Iishvara *lit.* the Controller of all controllers. • Controller of the Universe. • Saguña Brahma or God. • He who controls the thought-waves of the universe.

Iishvara Prañidhāna meditation. • 1st lesson of Ananda Marga sādhaná. • having the mental stance that Iishvara (the Cosmic Controller) is present in pleasure and pain, prosperity and adversity, and to think of oneself as the instrument, and not the wielder of the instrument, in all the affairs of life.

Iśá the goal. • one’s chosen ideal. • one’s personal deity or goal in life.

Iśá cakra the cakra used for concentration in the practice of Iishvara Prañidhāna (meditation).

jágrti *lit.* place for awakening. • Ananda Marga spiritual centre. • see also áshram.

japa repetition of a mantra or the name of God.

japamála repetition of mantra using a málá (string of beads) to count from.

jñána spiritual knowledge, self-realization. • proper understanding.

jñána yoga a form of spiritual practice which emphasizes discrimination or intellectual understanding. • self-realization through the path of knowledge.

jñánii a sádha who follows the path of knowledge or discrimination.

jol [Bengali] water.

kaośikī nṛtya the dance of mind expansion. • a dance-exercise for women created by Bábá that develops the glands in a way that encourages women to overcome complexes and strengthens the nerves.

karma action. • positive and negative actions which create sañskáras.

karma yoga a form of spiritual practice which emphasizes selfless action.
• the yoga of action. • actions performed without attachment to the results.

kiirtana devotional singing of the name of the Lord, sometimes combined with lalita mármika, a dance that expresses the spirit of surrender.

Krṣṇa the historical Krṣṇa (1500 BCE), in His early youth awakened the devotion and spiritual ardour of one and all in Gokula and Vrindavana. As a great kṣattriya leader and king, He played a pivotal role in the Mahábhārata campaign to unify India and to restore Dharma. • the word Krṣṇa has been used to represent Puruṣottama, the nucleus of the universe.

kṣattriya a member of the warrior class. • a person whose mentality is to dominate over matter. • written as kṣattriya it means the strong and the brave; the clan leaders. *dogm.* written as Kṣattriya it indicates a member of the second-highest caste in India.

kuṇḍalinī *lit.* coiled serpentine. • sleeping divinity. • the force dormant in the kula (lowest vertebra) of the body, which, when awakened, rises up the spinal column to develop all one's spiritual potentialities.

lalita mármika dance performed while doing kiirtana, stepping from side to side with arms raised above the head, representing surrendering the ego to the Supreme; a dance invented by Párvatī, Shiva's wife 7000 years ago.

līlā divine sport. • divine play. • the game of god in creating the universe.

lungi a single piece of cloth wrapped round the lower part of the body from waist to ankles.

madhu sweet. • sweet as honey.

Madhu Málaiṅca the name of the Lake Gardens residence of Shrii Shrii Ānandamūrti in, Kolkata, India.

madhura bháva sweet or honey devotional attitude. • ideation. • the highest type of devotional sentiment. • the devotional attitude which Rádhā held as the beloved of Krṣṇa.

madhuvidyá *lit.* honey knowledge. • the sweet ideation that god is everywhere, that he is doing everything.

mahá great, having a form which is supra-natural.

Mahábhārata *lit.* Great India. the name of a military campaign guided by Krṣṇa around 1500 BCE to unify India. • the epic poem written by Maharshi Vyasa about this campaign.

mahat, mahattattva "I", "I am," "I exist" feeling, existential "I".

málā garland. • a wreath of flowers. • string of beads for japa.

mantra a sound or collection of sounds which, when meditated upon, will lead to spiritual liberation. • a mantra is incantative, pulsative, and ideative.
• that which liberates the mind. • incantation taught by the spiritual preceptor and used during meditation.

márga path.

márgii a member of Ananda Marga, who follows its ideology and practices its meditation lessons.

máyá creative principle. • prakṛti in the phase of creation. • the power of the Creative Principle to create the illusion that the finite created objects are the ultimate truth. • expression of the cosmic operative principle.

mayúráśana peacock posture āśana.

Millarepa one of Tibet's greatest yogis, writer of The Songs of Millarepa.

mudrá meaningful gesture done with part or parts of the body. • a yogic exercise similar to an āśana but incorporating more ideation.

mysticism the never ending endeavour of an individual to try to find a link between the finite and the infinite.

namah homage. • veneration. • salutations.

namaskára method of salutation. • namaskára is done by bringing the palms together and touching with the thumbs, first the ájñá cakra, the mid-point of the eyebrows, and then the centre of the chest, without bowing.

• concentrate all the good feelings of the mind in the trikúṭi (junction of the eyebrows). • Ideation: I pay respect to the Supreme Entity residing within you - with all the goodwill and simplicity of my mind and the love and sweetness of my heart. • It can be done to all regardless of their age, because the idea in this mode of salutation is that everyone is the manifestation of the Supreme Entity.

namaste salutations.

Nirguṇa Brahma Brahma unaffected by the guṇas. • non-qualified Brahma. • unmanifested Cosmic Consciousness.

nirvikalpa samádhi the trance of indeterminate absorption, or total suspension of the mind. • the state of objectlessness.

om̐, om̐kára *lit.* the sound om̐. • the divine sound. • the sound of the first vibrational expression of creation. • the biija mantra or acoustic root of the expressed universe. *syn.* om; aum.

paneer curd cheese, plain, unaged or cured.

Parama Puruṣa Supreme Consciousness. • Cosmic Consciousness.

PC Personal Contact. • personal meeting between Guru and disciple.

práná energy, vital energy. • váyu or vital air functioning between the navel and the vocal cord responsible for inhalation and exhalation.

prañáma salutation with deep respect, see saś́aunga prañáma.

prasáda food that has been offered to god and consequently considered holy. It may be fruit, vegetable, milk or sweets. This food can then be eaten.

pratiika the emblem or symbol of Ananda Marga.

PROUT Progressive Utilization Theory, a socio-economic theory propounded by Shrii P. R. Sarkar.

pújá spiritual practices. • spiritual offering.

púrñimá full moon.

Puruṣa Supreme Consciousness. • the consciousness of the Cosmos.

Puruṣottama the Nucleus Consciousness. • the witness of sañcara (extroversion from the Nucleus) and pratisañcara (introversion to the Nucleus). • Supreme Consciousness as the nucleus of the Universe.

Ramakrishna mystic of 19th century Calcutta.

rasagollá [Bengali] spongy and juicy sweet made of milk and soaked in syrup.

rśi sage. • one who, by inventing new things, helps society to progress.

sabji [Bengali] vegetables.

Sadguru spiritual master. • *lit.* the Guru who leads one to Sat, the unchangeable entity. • the highest spiritual Guru.

sádhaka spiritual practitioner. • spiritual aspirant. • one engaged in sáadhaná.

sáadhaná *lit.* sustained spiritual endeavor. • spiritual practices, meditation. • from the root word sadh which means to try.

sádhv virtuous person, spiritual aspirant. see also sádhaka.

Saguña Brahma Brahma when affected by the guṇas. • qualified Consciousness. • manifested Cosmic Consciousness.

sañcara *lit.* movement. • the movement of the universe that goes from the nucleus towards the periphery. • the extroversive phase of creation from subtle to crude. • in the cosmic cycle, the step-by-step extroversion and crudification of consciousness from the pure consciousness to the state of solid matter.

samádhi *lit.* to become one with the goal. • to become one with God. • to expand one's unit mind by ideation on God until it merges in God's mind. • a state of peace and bliss. • absorption of the unit mind into the Cosmic Mind (savikalpa samádhi) or into the átman (nirvikalpa samádhi). • there are also various kinds of samádhi that involve only partial absorption.

sañskára potential mental reaction of one's action. • psychic reactive momentum.

sanátana dharma eternal dharma. See bhágavad dharma.

sannyása renunciation.

sannyásii *m.* or **sannyásinii** *f. lit.* monk or nun. • one who has surrendered one's life to the cosmic will or who ensconces oneself in sat, the unchangeable entity. • a renunciant.

satsaunga keeping the association of spiritual aspirants or good company.

saśaunga prañáma method of salutation involving prostration. • a symbol of simplicity. • it is to be done only to your Guru. • signifies surrender to the Supreme. • women may pay their respects by kneeling and touching the ground with the forehead while stretching forward the arms instead of doing full prostration.

sevá selfless service.

Shaeva Tantra Shiva tantra. • the practical side of spirituality as taught by Shiva.

shakti energy • prakṛti.

Shiva a great Tantric guru of 5000 BCE who guided society while His mind was absorbed in Consciousness. • also meaning Infinite Consciousness, Puruṣa. • considered the father of tantra and yoga.

shloka a Sanskrit couplet expressing an idea.

shrāddhāna funeral ceremony • food offered at a funeral service.

shūdra people who earn their livelihood by performing manual labour.

• a person of bread-and-butter mentality. • shūdrā, a person who only searches for physical enjoyment.

sūtram sacred thread. • aphorisms embodying a particular theory or philosophy.

tāṇḍava a vigorous dance for male spiritual aspirants, originally formulated by Shiva. • it develops the glands in a way that enhances courage and fearlessness. • when Shiva Himself does this dance (Shiva Natarāja), the dance becomes a metaphor in which Supreme Consciousness sends vibrations throughout the universe and causes all objects of the universe in turn to radiate vibrations.

tanmātrās *lit.* minutest fraction of a given fundamental factor. • microscopic particles emanated by an object. • the various types of tanmātrā convey the senses of hearing, touch, form (vision), taste and smell.

Tantra *lit.* that which liberates from crudity, that which liberates through expansion. • the cult of spirituality common to every path of spiritual practice. • a spiritual tradition which originated in India in prehistoric times and was first systematized by Shiva. It emphasizes the development of human vigour, both through meditation and through confrontation of difficult external situations, to overcome all fears and weaknesses. • also, a scripture expounding that tradition.

tāntrika a practitioner of tantra

thali an Indian meal often served on a tray consisting of at least rice, dal, sabji, chapatti and curd.

trikūṭī the junction of the two eye-brows, where the seat of the mind is located. • the concentration point of ājñā cakṛa.

vaeshya a person of acquisitive mentality, • a member of the business or merchant class. • *dogm.* written as Vaeshya, a member of the Indian caste.

varṇārghyadāna spiritual practice of offering mental colours to the Guru. • see guru pūjā.

veda *lit.* knowledge. • hence, a composition imparting spiritual knowledge. • a religious or philosophical school which originated among the Aryans and was brought by them to India. • it emphasizes the use of ritual to gain the intercession of the gods.

vidyā spiritual knowledge, intuitional science. • it is of two types: vidyā and avidyā. Avidyā is mainly concerned with external life whereas vidyā is concerned with internal life.

vipra intellectual. • a person who controls others by their wits, a member of the

intellectual social class. • dogm. written as Vipra, a member of the highest caste in India.

Vrindāvana located on the banks of the river Yamuna in the north of India. It was the place where Kṛṣṇa spent his childhood days.

VSS Volunteers of Social Service. • Ananda Marga security department also conducting difficult service work like burying corpses after natural disasters.

yajña ritual sacrifice. • service.

yoga spiritual practice leading to unification of the unit ātman (individual consciousness) with Paramātmān (Cosmic Consciousness).

yuga myth. age or era.

SANSKRIT PRONUNCIATION GUIDELINE KEY

a á b c d d é g h i j k l m n n ñ o p r s t t ú v y

It is possible to pronounce Saṁskṛta, or Sanskrit, using only twenty-nine letters of the Roman script. The letters ‘f’, ‘q’, ‘qh’, ‘z’, etc., are required in Arabic, Persian, and various other languages, but not in Saṁskṛta.

‘dá’ and ‘dha’, occurring in the middle of a word or at the end of a word, are pronounced ‘fa’ and ‘fha’, respectively. Like ‘ya’, they are not independent letters. In non-Saṁskṛta words, ‘fa’ and ‘fha’ may be written.

This key is a guide to the pronunciation of the Sanskrit words in this book, as adopted by Ananda Marga. In the case of those words of other languages (such as Bengali and Hindi) slight variations in the pronunciation will occur.

a = ‘a’ as in ‘mica’.

á = ‘a’ as in ‘father’.

i = ‘i’ as in ‘folio’.

ii = a somewhat prolonged *i*.

u = ‘u’ as in ‘lute’.

ú = a somewhat prolonged *u*.

r (alone or followed by a consonant) = *ri* as in Spanish *carido*.

rr = *rri* as in Spanish *corrida*.

lr = *l + ri*.

lrr = *l + rri*.

e = ‘e’ as in ‘cachet’.

ae = ‘ai’ as in ‘kaiser’.

o = ‘o’ as in ‘open’.

ao = ‘au’ in ‘sour’.

m̐ = a nasalisation of the preceding vowel, somewhat similar to ‘ng’ in ‘sung’.

h (following vowel, but not followed by a vowel) – an aspirated version of the vowel, or *ha* sound appended to the vowel. E.g., *vah* = either *va* with aspiration (expelling breath), or *vaha* sound.

kh, gh, ch, jh, ṭh, ḍh, th, dh, ph = aspirated forms of the consonants (expelling breath).

uṇa = nasalised 'wa' ('a' being pronounced as in 'mica'). Combining form *uṇ* before *k*, *kh*, *g*, *gh* = 'n' pronounced naturally for that location.

iṇa = nasalized 'ya' ('a' in 'mica'). Combining form *iṇ* before *c*, *ch*, *j*, *jh* = 'n' pronounced naturally for that location.

ī = cerebral 't' (tip of tongue touches centre of palate).

ḍ = cerebral 'd' (tip of tongue touches centre of palate).

ṇ = cerebral 'n' (tip of tongue touches centre of palate).

t = dental 't' (tip of tongue touches upper teeth).

d = dental 'd' (tip of tongue touches upper teeth).

y at beginning of a word = 'j' as in 'jump'. In middle of a word = 'y' is pronounced as in 'you'.

v at beginning of a word = is pronounced 'v' as in 'victory'. In middle of a word = 'w' as in 'awaken'.

sh = palatal 's' (tip of tongue touches back of palate), 'sh' as in 'shall' or 'ss' in 'issue'.

ś = cerebral 's' (tip of tongue touches centre of palate), 'sh' as in 'shun' or 'bush'.

kś = is either an aspirated version of 'k' (expelling the breath), or 'k' + 'sh'.

ṅ (preceded by a vowel other than *i* or *u*) = is nasalized.

jīṇa = 'gya' ('a' as in 'mica').

jīṇā = 'gya' ('a' as in 'father').

LINKS

Ananda Marga websites:

www.anandamarga.org

www.anandamarga.net/

Overview biography of Báábá:

www.en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Anandamurti

Ananda Marga online bookshop:

www.anandamargabooks.org/ (Kolkata)

www.shop.anandamarga.org/ (Singapore)

www.anandamargabooks.com/ (USA)

Ananda Marga centers around the world:

www.anandamarga.org/centers/index.htm

Ananda Marga centers Australia:

www.anandamarga.org.au/

Books on Báábá's theories by Sohail Inayatullah - academic and author:

[www.metafuture.org/Articles/IntroductoryChapterfromthebook
SituatingSarkar.htm](http://www.metafuture.org/Articles/IntroductoryChapterfromthebookSituatingSarkar.htm)

Sant Jñáneshwar link:

www.en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dnyaneshwar

Shantiniketan:

www.en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Santiniketan

CONTACT AND ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

The author would be pleased to receive any questions; expressions of personal response to the book; or creative suggestions and corrections.

Copies of this book can be obtained through the author's website or any Ananda Marga centre or Ananda Marga online bookshop (see Links).

There are additional resources related to this book available through the author's website that include photos; a recording of Madhu Giita the tape prepared for Bábá that includes the Spanish Kiirtana; and links to Ananda Marga videos and kiirtanas.

Please direct inquiries to:

makingwavesmedia1@gmail.com
www.makingwavesmedia.wordpress.com

baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ
nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba na
kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla ked
baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ ba
nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba
kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla k
baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ ba
nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba na
kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla ked
baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ ba
nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba
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baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ ba
nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba na
kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla ked
baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ ba
nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba
kedvalaḥ baba nalla kedvalaḥ baba nalla k

Walking With The Master follows the author's inspiring spiritual journey to India to meet his Guru and discover himself. In this memoir he unravels a tapestry of mysticism, spiritual knowledge, devotion and a delving into the inner self.

From the day he arrives in Calcutta to the day he goes back to Australia, the author finds himself the self appointed scribe to his Guru's discourses. This tribute includes senior disciples' recollections, photographs and intimate interactions.

Sometimes humorous, always thought provoking, this first-hand account of the daily life of Shrii Shrii Ānandamūrti, Guru of the international meditation organization Ananda Marga, sees the author chronicling such diverse subjects as yoga, meditation, linguistics, ancient Vedic history, spiritual chanting, origins of the Tantric mystical tradition, the prehistoric continent of Gondwanaland, and 'the eventual death of this little planet'.

"Have you recorded what I said last night?...I have not said this previously...It should be recorded, not for you, but for others."

– Bábá (Shrii Shrii Ānandamūrti).

